Dragon Raja II

The Mourner's Eyes

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English Translation Working Draft

This working draft contains the prologue and Acts One through Three. The remainder of this volume is in progress.

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Prologue Darkness in the Torrent of Rain

Act One Birthday Cake Is the Grave of Youth

Act Two None of Our Young Classmates Are Losers

Act Three Reward

Prologue

Darkness in the Torrent of Rain

A Dark Rainy Night

But Chu Zihang did not want to forget, because he was the only person in the world who still remembered that man. If he forgot too, it would be as though the man had never existed.

The man had once said that if he died one day, only one thing in the world could prove he had existed: Chu Zihang, who carried half his blood.

Chu Zihang stood at the window in a daze.

Rain rattled against the glass. The playing field was a blur of white.

The afternoon had been bright and sunny, but as the dismissal bell rang, leaden clouds swept in from the southeast and the sky darkened within minutes. Then thunder exploded, and millions upon millions of tons of water fell on the earth as though a reservoir in the sky had opened its gates.

Tire tracks crisscrossed the soccer field, its turf churned to pieces. Private cars were normally forbidden on campus, but in such terrible weather the parents worried about their children getting wet. Several forced the iron gates open, and all the cars swarmed inside. Half an hour ago the field had been as crowded as a market: cars parked every which way, hazard lights flashing a confusion of yellow, everyone leaning on their horns and shouting their children's names. In the downpour, students unable to find their families' cars wandered around like headless flies.

Now everyone had been collected. The classrooms and playing field were empty, and the sky-blue flag of Shilan High School fluttered wildly in the storm.

Like the dispersal of a crowd when the music ends.

He was alone in the classroom, beneath pale lights, while outside was as dark as midnight. On a day like this, people should go home early.

He took out his phone, dialed, switched on the speaker, and set it on the desk, watching it in silence.

After several rings, the call connected. "Zihang, it's raining where you are too, isn't it? Oh, Mom's shopping at Jiuguang Department Store with her friends. It's pouring here, and we can't get a cab. We're having coffee and waiting for the rain to let up. Get yourself a taxi home, or call your dad and ask him to send a car. Be good, Zihang. Mommy sends you a kiss." A crisp kissing sound came through the phone, and she hung up.

Chu Zihang put away his phone. He hadn't said a single word, nor had he planned to. He had called only to let his mother know he was all right, so she wouldn't worry and could keep enjoying herself.

Adults could be foolish sometimes. When a child reached out to comfort one, she thought he was asking for food.

There were no taxis outside. In rain this heavy, drivers didn't want the business and had gone home early. If there were no cars at Jiuguang, it was the same at school, but his mother wouldn't think of that. His grandmother said his mother was an innocent little girl, without a care in the world. Chu Zihang

didn't want to call "Dad" either. "Dad" was a very busy man who wouldn't remember the small matter of sending a car for his stepson on a rainy day. But if reminded, he would certainly send a driver. "Dad" was a fine, responsible, well-mannered man who loved his beautiful wife, a former dancer, and treated her son well for her sake. He often said, "Zihang, if you need anything, just say so. I'm your father, and I'll fulfill my responsibilities to you."

Having a wealthy "Dad" who wanted to fulfill his responsibilities sounded rather good.

But Chu Zihang didn't think he needed it.

The classroom door stood open. Cold wind and fine rain blew in, chilling him to the bone. Chu Zihang pulled his jacket tighter, stuck his hands in his pockets, and resumed staring into space.

"Chu Zihang? Let's go together. The rain won't stop—the forecast says it's a typhoon, and the weather bureau issued a warning!" A girl peeked in. Her long hair fell clean and straight, with a silver Hello Kitty clip at the end. Her delicate face was slightly flushed, and she lowered her eyes, too shy to meet his gaze.

"You don't know me? I'm Liu Miaomiao..." Receiving no answer, her voice grew softer and softer, like a mosquito's hum.

Actually, Chu Zihang did know Liu Miaomiao. A year below him, she was famous at Shilan High. She had passed the tenth-grade piano examination in her second year of middle school and played a solo at every annual celebration. Several boys in his class competed for her attention in secret; he could hardly have avoided knowing who she was.

"I'm on cleaning duty today. I'll leave in a while." Chu Zihang nodded politely.

"Oh... then I'll go first." Liu Miaomiao spoke softly and withdrew her head.

Through the window, Chu Zihang watched her family's driver open an enormous black umbrella over her. She took off her strappy sandals, and the driver crouched to help her into rain boots. Sheltering under the umbrella, she picked her way toward a black BMW whose "angel eye" headlights shone through the rain.

"Hey! Liu Miaomiao! Give me a ride!" a younger boy shouted from under the eaves.

"Walk, Lu Mingfei! My house isn't in the same direction as yours!" Liu Miaomiao didn't turn around.

Actually, Chu Zihang's home wasn't in the same direction as Liu Miaomiao's either. His was in Peacock Residence in the east of the city, hers in California Sunshine in the west, opposite directions altogether. Yet she had offered him a ride.

The younger boy squatted under the eaves and watched the BMW glide silently into the rain. Its taillights flashed, its engine roared, and it was gone. He stood, head drooping to one side, and walked slowly along the eaves. Watching his retreating figure, Chu Zihang suddenly thought he might give him a ride. But the boy ducked his head, wrapped his coat over it, and darted into the rain like a stray dog. He ran so fast that before Chu Zihang could call out, he had splashed away into the distance.

Zigzag lightning flickered in the clouds, and thunder burst overhead. The rain grew heavier. Liu Miaomiao was right: this was no ordinary rain, but a typhoon. Suddenly Chu Zihang very much wanted someone to pick him up. Otherwise he would have to splash through the cold rain like that younger boy. He took out his phone and typed: "It's raining hard. Can you come pick me up?" He read it over silently, made sure the tone was right, and sent it.

For the next several dozen seconds he counted his heartbeats. Thump-thump... thump-thump... thump-thump...

"Sure, sure, no problem! Wait at school. I'll be there in a bit!" The reply came. That person always sounded so cheerful.

Chu Zihang deleted both messages; it would be awkward if "Dad" saw them. He picked up the bucket at his feet and threw all the water onto the blackboard. Water streamed down as he seized an eraser and scrubbed hard.

On his third pass, a low horn sounded outside. He turned. Through the rain, xenon headlights cast two dazzling beams that made him squint.

It was a pure black sedan. In a triangular frame on its hood, two overlapping M's formed a mountain. A Maybach 62.

Maybach was Mercedes-Benz's top marque, apparently several times more expensive than "Dad's" Mercedes S500. Chu Zihang wasn't much interested in cars. The man inside had boasted all this to him.

The wipers swung back and forth like a deranged metronome, clearing layer after layer of rain from the windshield. The middle-aged man inside waved to Chu Zihang, his face blooming with a smile. Chu Zihang couldn't understand why he always looked so happy, as if nothing ever troubled him. Shouldering the Hermès bag "Dad" had bought him in London, Chu Zihang locked the classroom, checked the door, and walked to the edge of the eaves. He hesitated a moment before the downpour. The man hurried out, opened a huge black umbrella, and came to meet him, as attentive as Liu Miaomiao's driver. Chu Zihang didn't look at him. He pushed the umbrella aside, walked through the rain to the car, opened the rear door himself, and climbed in.

His attempt at ingratiation unanswered, the man paused, then climbed back into the driver's seat. He closed the umbrella and passed it to Chu Zihang in the back. "Stick it in the door. There's a hole just for umbrellas."

"I know. You told me." Chu Zihang put it away and turned to the window. "Let's go."

"Your clothes are wet, right? Want me to turn on the rear-seat heating? Once you try it, you'll know—comfortable as hell!" The man began boasting about his car again.

"No need. I'll change at home."

"Oh, okay." The man cleared his throat and spoke to the center console. "Start!"

The screen lit up, a cold blue light flashed across the dashboard, and the savage 5.5-liter turbocharged V12 began its self-check. Not a vibration could be felt inside; even the engine's deep growl was shut out.

"A nine-million-yuan car, no key. Only three voices in the world can start it: mine, my boss's, and guess whose?" The man looked immensely pleased.

"Not interested." Chu Zihang's face was expressionless.

Again the man's warmth met a cold shoulder, but he wasn't discouraged. He shifted and accelerated briskly. The Maybach roared forward, sweeping in a great arc across the field and cutting through the rain like a blade as it drove through Shilan High's gate. The guard stood ramrod straight in his booth, chest and belly thrust out in respect for the luxury car and the wealth it represented.

Chu Zihang couldn't see what there was to respect. On a rainy day like this, all you needed was a car to pick you up and someone who remembered to come. Whether it was a Maybach, a Mercedes S500, or a QQ made no difference.

"Such heavy rain, and your mother didn't think to pick you up."

"Lucky I didn't get the car washed this morning. An eighty-yuan touchless wash would have been money down the drain."

"That guard at your school wouldn't let me drive in. I told him I was picking up my son, and he'd get soaked in rain like this if I couldn't go in. Took no end of arguing. Finally I told him this car cost nine million, and nobody stops me driving into city hall, so why should Shilan High be so damned strict? He backed down right away. Ha ha!"

The man chattered on as he handled the wheel with a flourish.

Chu Zihang hadn't answered him once since getting in. He turned on the radio; the announcer's voice gave him more peace than the man's.

"We now bring you an emergency typhoon warning and traffic update. According to the municipal weather station, Typhoon Dandelion, number 0407 this year, made landfall on the city's southeastern coast this afternoon. Heavy rain and force-ten winds are expected. All organizations should take precautions. Due to the intense rainfall, provincial and national highways through the city will close in two hours. Winds are high on the elevated roads and visibility is below thirty meters. Drivers still on the road should take alternative routes."

He looked out. Visibility really was terrible: beyond fifty meters everything dissolved into a white haze. The raindrops were so dense they seemed to smash one another apart in the air, falling as a spray of foam. The sky was black as ink; occasional bolts of lightning struck straight down. Few cars remained, all creeping carefully with headlights on. When two met, their drivers sounded their horns hard, like beasts encountering each other in a forest, baring their teeth and growling a warning.

Traffic slowed to a crawl, one car feeling its way behind another. Horns shrilled ahead like boiling kettles, and countless red brake lights pierced the rain. There seemed to be a jam.

"You want my V12 to crawl like a turtle?" the man muttered. He swung the wheel and forced his way into the emergency lane.

It was a beautiful cut, like a sharp blade slicing through water, severing the stream of traffic behind them. The driver of an Audi braked hard, locked wheels skidding across the road. Without braking, the Audi would have hit the Maybach from behind, and the Audi driver would have been entirely responsible. Repairing the Maybach would cost as much as an Audi. The braking opened a one-second gap in the traffic, and the man squeezed into it.

"Do you know how to fucking drive? Rushing to a funeral?"

The man winked proudly at Chu Zihang, ignoring the Audi driver's shouted curses. The luxury car, more than six meters long, was like an iron catfish in his hands, flicking its tail at just the right moment and swimming freely through traffic. Who knew how many drivers rolled down their windows and cursed after he overtook them? A chorus of sharp horns followed. But there was little they could do: the car overtaking them was an ultraluxury vehicle with sports-car performance, and its driver was clearly skilled.

The man grinned broadly.

Chu Zihang couldn't see what he was so happy about. Would it kill him to follow the traffic slowly? He simply had to show off his car and his tricks. He was a professional driver; of course he should be good at driving.

"Damn it, we're really stuck!" the man swore.

Two cars had scraped each other ahead. Their drivers stood under umbrellas, spitting as they shouted. In weather like this, traffic police couldn't arrive quickly, and each blamed the other. Dozens of cars were blocked. Several drivers got out and told the arguing men to move their vehicles, only for another argument to break out, with pushing and shoving. Everyone else pressed their horns impatiently.

Chu Zihang wanted to cover his ears. What a mess. The whole world was a mess.

"Are they idiots? What's there to argue about over two lousy little cars? Insurance pays anyway," the man grumbled. "I've got things to do after I drop off my son..."

He craned his neck and looked around, his gaze settling on a branch road in the rain. An entrance to the elevated highway, just a step away; its sign was hidden among a willow's wildly thrashing branches. It was odd. The trapped cars should have poured onto an empty road, yet not a soul was there. Something stirred in Chu Zihang, a strange feeling that only they could see the road, or else everyone else knew it was impassable. His biology teacher had said animals had an instinct for finding their way: wild camels in the desert knew which paths were wrong and had no springs, and wouldn't take them even if driven.

"That road should lead up to the elevated highway, though it's probably closed now," the man said, even as he pointed the car straight toward it.

Closer up, the sign read "Elevated Highway Entrance..." followed by its number. Chu Zihang looked, but a sheet of rain burst against the windshield at that moment, and he couldn't make it out.

The Maybach climbed the ramp. The elevated road stretched ahead like a gray rainbow, disappearing into the white rain.

"What if it really is closed and we can't get down?" Chu Zihang asked.

"If we can get up, we can get down." The man wasn't worried. "At worst I'll offer the cop at the exit a cigarette."

"The radio said the wind's strong and visibility's poor up here. It told drivers to take another route." Chu Zihang was uneasy. He didn't know how fast the wind outside was blowing, but it shrieked like a whistle.

"It's fine." The man patted the wheel. "What's a little wind? Tiny cars have to worry about that. Know how much a Maybach 62 weighs? Two point seven tons! Even a force-twelve wind can't budge it! Your dad's driving and this car together are rock solid. Relax!"

The Maybach sped along the empty elevated road, throwing up sprays of water as tall as a person. The man turned on the stereo without asking and played "Daily Growing" by the Irish band Altan:

The trees they grow high, the leaves they do grow green,

Many is the time my true love I've seen,

Many an hour I have watched him all alone,

He's young but he's daily growing.

Father, dear father, you've done me great wrong,

You have married me to a boy who is too young,

I am twice twelve and he is but fourteen,

He's young but he's daily growing.

"Good, isn't it? Everyone said it was a great disc, so I bought it. It's about a father's love!" the man said.

Chu Zihang didn't know whether to laugh or cry. "Can't you hear? It's a conversation between a girl and her father, not a boy. It's not appropriate for me."

"Boy or girl, what's the difference? It's a father's love either way." The man waved it off. "You understand it? I hear your English is top-notch at school, that you won a competition... But your mother never told me. What's the song about?"

"A father marries his twenty-four-year-old daughter to a rich fourteen-year-old boy. She doesn't want to; she worries she'll be old by the time her husband grows up. But her father says his arrangement is right. He's married her to a wealthy young man, so she'll have someone to rely on when he's old," Chu Zihang said. "Later the boy dies before he grows up. The girl grieves terribly and weaves him a flannel shroud in a green graveyard."

"What the hell kind of song is that? No fun at all. The girl's husband dies before he even does anything?" The man really was not a sensitive creature. Chu Zihang had known since childhood that his biological father was as rough as they came.

"Let's just have a chat, father and son." The man turned off the stereo. "Did I tell you about our company's new building? The boss put in a steam room and gym, free for us to use. Everything in there is so damn fancy..."

The man had failed in life because he talked too much... yet if he hadn't talked so much, he might have failed even worse, Chu Zihang thought.

His gift of gab was how he had charmed Mom until she married beneath her. Everyone at Shilan High agreed Chu Zihang was handsome enough to live off his looks, thanks to his mother's genes. In her youth she had been the star of the city dance troupe, dancing Silk Road Flower Rain like a flying apsara from a mural, with suitors as numerous as fish crossing a river. Somehow this man had fought his way through the field. Every day he drove to the troupe's gate to pick her up after work, using nothing but his mouth to weave a beautiful future and charm her senseless. On a drive to Hangzhou she had absentmindedly agreed to marry beneath her, and on that same trip had conceived Chu Zihang. Only after pressing her fingerprints onto the marriage certificate did she learn the car wasn't his: he was a driver for his work unit.

His politics teacher was right: the economic base determines the superstructure. A man like that couldn't support the superstructure of a beautiful wife. His mother had always been absentminded and wasn't greedy; the man was simply too hopeless.

And so, snap, it fell apart.

At the divorce, the man thumped his chest and promised his former wife he would earn money every month to support her and their son, show her he could make something of himself, and come back to propose once he had succeeded. Full of grand ambition, he promptly quit his stable job at the state enterprise to find more profitable work. After hanging around the labor market for three or four

months without a single offer, he finally realized all he knew was driving. Shamefaced, he found a driving job at a private company. The boss of the Black Prince Group liked his gift of gab and put him behind the wheel of the Maybach. A driver needed to talk smoothly, so the boss could leave him to boast about things the boss couldn't conveniently boast about himself.

The car was better than before, but his pay had hardly changed. After his own expenses, he couldn't even support a cat.

Fortunately, Chu Zihang's beautiful mother finally did something for herself. She had no intention of waiting for him. After several tearful days, she left Chu Zihang at his grandmother's, bought new cosmetics, put on alluring makeup, and went barhopping with her friends. In less than a month, she brought Chu Zihang a new dad. Having learned from experience, she chose carefully this time: a man one in a thousand. "Dad" owned three companies, was divorced once, and had no children. When he proposed, he swore he would never have children of his own and would raise Chu Zihang as his son.

With a rich dad and beautiful mom, talented and capable himself, Chu Zihang seemed exceptionally fortunate to his classmates. They had no idea his private life was far more exceptional than they imagined. But he couldn't take credit for it; his biological parents were the exceptional ones.

"Want to watch a DVD? I've got Shrek 2, though it's a bootleg filmed in a theater." The man stopped chattering, perhaps embarrassed at getting no response.

"No." Chu Zihang hesitated. "The three of us are going to see it this weekend."

The three meant Chu Zihang and his rich dad and beautiful mom. The man had nothing to do with it.

That was "Dad's" rule. Busy with work, "Dad" gave his clients every meal from breakfast to late-night snacks. But after one divorce, he had recognized the importance of family, so he permanently marked one weekend day on his schedule for them. Their usual activities were shopping, a movie, and a lavish dinner, followed by a discussion of Chu Zihang's studies. "Dad" followed his schedule strictly: never one day less or one day more of family time, just as he appeared in the company's main conference room at nine every Monday, rain or shine, for the weekly meeting with senior executives.

How did a stepson with a face that rarely smiled deserve the same treatment as executives earning a million a year? It was all thanks to Mom.

"Is the air warm enough in back?" the man asked again.

"Enough. Stop talking like a chauffeur!" Chu Zihang was irritated.

You're my father! Do you understand? he wanted to ask the man. Do you?

Under the visitation agreement you only get one day a month, and even then you're often too busy. Even when you come, what can you say to me while you sit in someone else's house? Actually, of course, you can talk plenty: you sit on the horsehair sofa "Dad" bought for 170,000 yuan and praise how fancy it is! Why did I ask you to pick me up? Because no one else would? Because if you picked me up, we could talk! If you can't say anything profound, just ask plainly, casually, how I've been, whether I'm happy... Don't hold an umbrella over me, so attentive. I don't care about that. Do you want to kneel and change my rain boots like Liu Miaomiao's driver? I don't need a chauffeur. We already have one at home... You're my father. Do you understand?

"What's shameful about being my son's chauffeur?" The man shrugged. His skin was as thick as a city wall, or his nerves slower than a turtle's. "When you were little, you rode me like a horse."

Something in Chu Zihang's heart twitched, as though it had cracked and released bitter water. He was tired and didn't want to speak. He leaned back against the leather seat and stared out the window.

He always said things that hurt so calmly... Couldn't he stop bringing them up?

Many years ago... in that shabby little room of barely a dozen square meters, the man crawled around while a boy rode on his shoulders shouting "Giddyap!" and a beautiful woman fussed over the gas stove... The images flickered in his mind like a film played by a battered hand-cranked projector.

The sky slowly darkened and the streetlights came on. Through the layers of rain, their light was as faint as fireflies.

"How's your mother lately?" the man asked, breaking the silence.

"Same as before. She gets up in the morning and plays with the cat, shops in the afternoon, and goes drinking with her friends at night. When they're having fun they come back together and talk until late, then sleep until noon. Anyway..." Chu Zihang hesitated. "Dad is always out entertaining clients and has no time for her. He thinks it's good that she amuses herself."

The words were a little hurtful. A down-on-his-luck man asked after the woman he had once loved, and she was happy, having forgotten him altogether.

Grandma said Mom had been a carefree girl since childhood, but being carefree and beautiful meant she could live well. Mom had long since put her unhappiness behind her. She regarded "Dad" as her first husband: married happily in their youth, with an outstanding son like Chu Zihang. In Chinese, perfect; in English, perfect.

People had to accept reality. The man's image had been erased from the limited memory in Mom's head.

Calling another man "Dad" in front of him was not easy for Chu Zihang either. A moment ago he had tactfully said "the three of us." But once the word was out, it wasn't so awkward. He had promised "Dad" to call him Dad, not Uncle, Four-Eyes, or Side Parting... even though in Chu Zihang's mind "Dad" was a four-eyed fellow with a side part, or a side-parted fellow with glasses. But Chu Zihang was stubborn about keeping promises, whether people were watching or not.

After all these years, surely the man was used to it. He hadn't tried hard to win custody of his son back then, anyway.

"Take good care of your mother," the man said.

In the rearview mirror, his still handsome but somewhat aging face showed little expression.

"Mm. Like you said, I make sure she drinks milk before bed. If she's talking with her friends, I warm it and bring it to her."

It was the only thing the man had asked Chu Zihang to do. Strange: he had lost the woman, yet still remembered a cup of milk. Since childhood Mom had needed a glass of warm milk with half a spoonful of sugar every night, so she wouldn't wake repeatedly. By now she had probably forgotten that years ago the man had warmed it for her. Before him, Grandma had done it; after him, her son did.

A fortunate woman always had someone to warm her milk.

"Shilan High is damn impressive! Seventeen students got into Tsinghua and Peking University this year. Work hard, son! Don't disgrace me!" The man made a show of concern for Chu Zihang's studies.

"Dad says I'm not taking the domestic entrance exam. I'm going abroad for college. I'm taking the TOEFL next month," Chu Zihang replied coldly.

Disgrace him? When had he ever really cared? He only ever talked.

Last year a coproduced movie had filmed locally, and Chu Zihang had been chosen as an extra. Hearing about it, the man had sworn he would visit the set.

"My son's making a movie! I'll bring tea and water. If I drive this car there, I'll look spectacular, won't I?" He patted the wheel, beaming.

So during breaks Chu Zihang kept looking, consciously or not, toward the parking lot. The spectacular Maybach never appeared. But "Dad's" Mercedes S500 was always there, with the driver, Old Shun, wearing huge dark glasses and a neck thicker than a man's head, looking every bit a bodyguard. He called Chu Zihang "young master" in front of everyone and behind their backs, making people stare.

And then there was that disastrous middle-school entrance ceremony. It fell on "Dad" and Mom's wedding anniversary, when they were going on vacation to northern Europe. After much thought, Chu Zihang called the man and asked him to come. The man was happy but hesitant: what about your mother and stepfather? After a long silence Chu Zihang said, just say you're my uncle. The man didn't feel slighted at all. He chuckled and said, then remember to call me Uncle; don't let it slip... In the end Chu Zihang was the only student with no parent standing behind him at the ceremony. He stood in the most prominent place, first in line, as the principal awarded him the new-student scholarship. He ranked first among Shilan's incoming class and had wanted to surprise the man.

"Oh, I really didn't forget, but that day the boss suddenly said an important client was coming and wanted a bath, so I had to drive them there. Who knew they'd bathe until the next morning..." Later the man scratched his head and mumbled his explanation.

Chu Zihang had a vague idea what sort of person the man's "boss" was, and what sort of place he meant by "a bath."

A classmate had told Chu Zihang, "I saw your Maybach parked outside a bathhouse last time," then lowered his voice. "Isn't that a place where people do bad things?"

Obviously. At the entrance, decorated like a Roman palace, seven or eight heavily made-up hostesses wore skirts almost short enough to reach their waists and necklines nearly low enough to fall below their breasts. Men of every kind climbed out of luxury cars and marched in, bellies thrust forward. Chu Zihang had passed once and glanced from a distance, imagining the man's boss and clients reveling inside at night while the man leaned against his beloved Maybach, smoking, the smoke spreading into the dark.

Chu Zihang didn't blame him much. The man was simply who he was and lived the life he lived, very far removed from Chu Zihang's.

"Going abroad isn't good," the man mumbled. "It's not fashionable anymore. China's developing so fast; opportunities are everywhere. If you ask me, go to college here, study finance, and have your stepdad use his connections to find you a job..."

It was as though a needle pierced Chu Zihang's chest. He shuddered with pain. "Have your stepdad use his connections"... Couldn't a person have some dignity? Did he have to be so shameless?

"Shut up!" Chu Zihang growled.

"What?" The man hadn't heard clearly.

"Shut up." Chu Zihang was like a young lion with its fur on end.

"What a rude child. I'm doing this for your own good." The man stared. "You should listen to adults..."

"Is listening to you any use? If I listen to you, will I find a girl and marry her without getting divorced? Will I make it to my son's graduation on time? Will I pick him up and drop him off at school on time? If I listen to you, all I'll do is ask my stepfather to use his connections!" Chu Zihang stared into the man's eyes in the rearview mirror, hoping to see disappointment or anger.

Every word struck at the heart.

Many people thought Chu Zihang couldn't even swear, much less speak with cutting bitterness. Even when fouled on the basketball court he never lost his temper, only raised a hand for the referee. But who couldn't say cruel things, when anger lay buried like needles in the heart? Now he was furious and wanted to stab the man hard with those needles. The words came out without thought.

"You're still young. Family matters... you'll understand when you're older." The man was clearly at a loss. He reached out as if to pat Chu Zihang in the back seat, but didn't dare; he drew his hand back and scratched his head.

It was always the same answer: "You'll understand later," "You're too young," "It's not what you think." Bullshit! When those two fools divorced, Chu Zihang had been small. He had cried as though the world were ending, and the man comforted him with "It's not what you think," "Mom and Dad just won't live together," "I'll still take you out on Sundays." Chu Zihang believed him; he believed home was still the three of them. Then he followed Mom into their new house and saw a gentleman with side-parted hair, a bathrobe, and two hairy legs politely open the door. Not knowing who this stranger was, Chu Zihang was so shocked that he shoved his ice cream into the man's face.

All these years later, the little kid had grown up, and they were still lying? To hell with that!

"Enough! Just drive, and stay out of my business! When we get home, don't come in. 'Dad' might be unhappy!" Chu Zihang clenched his teeth and turned away.

"What kind of thing is that to say? I'm your real father. If he's unhappy, let him be unhappy. Who the hell is he..." At last the man sounded wounded in his pride.

"He isn't my real father, but he comes to parent-teacher meetings. He takes me to amusement parks on weekends. He knows my final grades. At least he buys me a schoolbag for my birthday!" Chu Zihang slammed the Hermès bag against the seat. "Do you even remember my birthday?"

"Of course I remember!" the man protested, red-faced. "You're my son. Your mom and I made you together... As soon as we heard she was pregnant, we counted the days, when you were conceived and when you were due, waiting eagerly. You little rascal wouldn't come out; you stayed two months extra! How could I forget? Haven't you had health class? Men deserve credit for making babies too. Aren't you smart because I made you well?"

Chu Zihang was so angry he nearly laughed. How could any man be so shameless?

"Was it hard? Marrying a beautiful woman and having her give birth... was that such an achievement?" His voice shook. "I've had health class! The woman carries the baby for ten difficult months. What does the man do? What was hard for you?"

The man wilted, his voice sinking. "I'm not discussing health class with my son..."

"Was it hard after I was born? Did you ever look after me? Why exactly are you my 'real father'? Just because you and Mom 'made me together'? As though you manufactured some product? Tell me what 'real father' actually means." Chu Zihang's mood was as bad as it could get, and the anger he had suppressed flared again.

"A real father means... you... carry my blood." The man chose his words carefully. "You're my legacy in this world, don't you understand? You're half of me... I know I haven't looked after you much these years, and I'm sorry, but what father doesn't care about his child? Our blood connects us, we..."

"Live and prosper together, too!" Chu Zihang sneered.

The man fell silent, and so did Chu Zihang. Only thousands upon thousands of raindrops drummed heavily on the roof. The air inside seemed to grow much colder all at once, beyond the reach of the heater.

After a long time the man sighed slowly, sounding like he was repeating an old saying. "That's why I say you're young. You don't understand. When you have a child of your own, you'll see. Having a child is like giving half of yourself to that child. It's as if you can sense where he is, like telepathy. You'll always care about him and think about him. It comes naturally, for no reason at all. Besides, everyone dies. When I die, everyone else will forget me, but you'll still be in this world, and half of you is me. It's as though I've left something behind."

"You only know how to make a child, not raise one. If someone else raises him, he'll grow less and less like you!"

"I... I wanted to raise you too," the man said haltingly.

A low laugh came from the stereo. Chu Zihang started, unsure whether it was static or the CD player accidentally turning on. The laughter was deep, immense and solemn, as though echoing inside an ancient bronze bell. He had been watching the man's face in the rearview mirror. Suddenly it changed: blue veins sprang up at the corners of his eyes like restless little snakes. His usually slack face tightened, like red-hot iron quenched in ice water.

Chu Zihang had never seen that expression on him. He was a different person altogether, his abruptly narrowed pupils betraying immense terror.

Someone tapped softly on the car door.

"In rain this heavy, who's outside?" Chu Zihang turned and saw a black shadow cast on the window. Had the elevated road been closed, and traffic police come to check? He reached to lower the window.

"Sit back!" the man barked.

A vast terror suddenly engulfed Chu Zihang. He glanced at the speedometer: 120 kilometers an hour. Who could run after the Maybach on the elevated road and reach out to knock at the same time?

The knocking grew urgent. There was not one figure but three, five, more and more gathering outside, staring down at Chu Zihang through the rain-streaked windows. A dazzling mercury-colored light shone from outside, turning both their faces deathly pale. The man turned to Chu Zihang and struggled to keep his voice from shaking. "Don't be afraid... son!"

The knocking became the piercing scrape of sharp things across steel and glass. Chu Zihang thought they must be the shadows' nails.

"Where are we?" he screamed.

The man reached back, seized his wrist, hauled him bodily from the back seat, and threw him into the passenger seat.

"Buckle up!" he said quietly. All fear had vanished from his face, which was hard as cast iron.

He floored the accelerator. The Maybach shuddered and surged forward. Within seconds it reached 180 kilometers an hour and continued accelerating, because they had failed to shake the shadows. Mercury-colored light came from every direction, revealing countless dark figures surrounding the car... standing silently... like a crowd of death gods around a dying person's bed. They opened their eyes together, golden pupils blazing like torches. Chu Zihang curled up, clutching his head in pain.

Pain tore through the depths of his brain. Tangled blue-violet lines twisted like countless snakes, like hieroglyphs on an ancient tablet come alive and dancing like spirits. Images he would never have dared imagine in his worst nightmares flashed before him: a young man with a golden eye split open in his forehead lay on a black stone throne, a long bone sword in his chest; girls writhed on a carved stone altar, screaming in pain as if labor were beginning; black wings rose against the sunset, blotting out half the sky; a woman bound to a bronze pillar slowly opened her eyes, white hair flying as two streams of foul blood ran down her face...

It was like watching snakes dance in the primeval darkness, telling him a lost history in a strange language.

"It's spirit vision. Your bloodline is being awakened. Such a strong reaction—I don't know whether it's your luck... or your misfortune." The man gripped Chu Zihang's hand. "I always hoped this day... would come later."

After an unknown time, Chu Zihang slowly lifted his head, as if waking from a nightmare as long as a lifetime. The feeling was hard to describe: like a nearsighted man putting on glasses after years without them, the world suddenly became extraordinarily clear. Sight, hearing, even smell awoke. He looked blankly at the man, who gently stroked his head, in a gesture that might have been care or sorrow.

"What's happening? Are we going to die?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Son, welcome to"—the man drew a deep breath—"the real world."

"The real... world?"

"Don't tell anyone what you just saw, or whatever you see next. No one will believe you; they'll think you're crazy," the man said. "I think living in an unreal world is happier, so I always wanted you to learn all this later. I kept trying to stay away from you so I wouldn't drag you into it. But when I got your text today... I couldn't stop myself from picking you up... Well, it's no big deal. If a father wants to make an impression on his son, he has to act like a man. I never had the chance before." He licked his lips. "Are these guys giving me a stage to show off? Not bad!"

Chu Zihang didn't understand. He thought the man must have been scared out of his wits. Why was he talking nonsense?

The Maybach had reached its top speed, 275 kilometers an hour, the tachometer needle jumping into the dangerous red zone. The man floored the accelerator, gripped the wheel, and stared ahead. There was only mercury-colored light; nothing was visible, as though they were racing toward a silver

sea. Pale handprints without palm lines struck the windshield with loud bangs. Shadows pounded the windows on every side, hard enough to break blast-resistant glass.

The man pulled the black umbrella from the door.

Was he going to get out and talk to the shadows with an umbrella at a time like this? Chu Zihang stared, then saw clearly: it wasn't an umbrella but a sword, a slender Japanese blade in a black sheath, with no guard. It was a devotional sword. Chu Zihang had read a book called Knowledge of Japanese Swords: in Japan, swordsmiths omitted the guard only on two kinds of sword, those carried by poor ronin and ceremonial swords dedicated to the gods. Sacred swords were never used for cutting, so a guard was unnecessary. The sword's elegant, antique-style sharkskin sheath showed it was a decorative craft object.

The blade slipped from the sheath, its gleam clear as water.

Chu Zihang was dumbfounded. What was happening? Wasn't the man a driver, a loser who should be carefully ferrying his boss around? Yet now he held the sword, eager to act, radiating an edge sharp as a spear... with a decorative sword?

"Sacred sword Murasame, the cursed blade destined to kill the Tokugawa family. Heard of it?" The man laid it across the steering wheel. "The original was destroyed long ago. They recast it in regenerated metal and enshrined it at Gion Shrine for ten years."

Veins bulged on the man's wrist. Reversing his grip, he thrust straight into the left door. The long blade pierced the cast-aluminum door and lodged there, half its length exposed outside. He slammed on the brakes. The speedometer plunged, the wheels skidding on the verge of losing control. Foul blood trailed a black ribbon a dozen meters long in the wind, then the rain washed it away. The shadows couldn't slow in time; those on the left were cut through by the exposed blade before they could even cry out. Simple, pure killing, as though they had struck its sharp edge at 250 kilometers an hour. Black blood splashed across every window on the left and even seeped through the cracks. Chu Zihang held his head and trembled uncontrollably.

Sacred sword Murasame—was it a decorative replica? It had been forged to kill! Its tough blade could cut through the bones of more than a dozen people without breaking. This way of killing... this man, and the whole world... had they all gone mad?

The man immediately floored the accelerator. Tires shrieked against the road: wheelspin, the power exceeding their grip. Even through the air filter came the smell of burning rubber. He jerked the wheel and the Maybach spun out, its heavy 2.7-ton body sweeping the shadows away and into the roadside barrier, which cracked under the impacts.

Black blood coated all the windows, only to be washed away by the rain.

It was hell.

As the car spun violently, the man pressed a warm palm to Chu Zihang's head. Chu Zihang suddenly remembered childhood, when the man, the woman, and he were still a family, and the man took him to ride a carousel, holding his head just as gently.

The car stopped, facing the opposite direction. The man floored it again, and the Maybach charged back the way they had come like an enraged stallion. A chilling sound came from under the wheels, like bones being crushed... The car kept shuddering as one shadow after another flew away. The man held the accelerator down, his face expressionless. In his hands the car had become a killing machine.

Chu Zihang couldn't believe such a useless man had suddenly become a demon who killed without blinking.

"Don't be afraid. Things like Deadpool... don't have civil rights," the man said hoarsely. "They aren't human, so the law doesn't protect them!"

One shadow wasn't thrown aside. Taller than the others, he was built like a giant. He braced both hands against the hood and was driven rapidly backward by the Maybach, his feet scraping shrilly against the road. In the rain his golden eyes seemed to burn. The scene belonged in a Superman or Spider-Man movie. For an ordinary person, such enormous friction would dislocate joints and break leg bones.

"Die!" the man growled. The Maybach drove the shadow into the barrier. He shifted into reverse, then forward, accelerated, and struck again, then a third and fourth time, until the barrier broke. Only then did the gold in the shadow's eyes dim like a lamp out of oil. Even so, he made no sound.

The man turned the car and accelerated away. Trembling, Chu Zihang looked through the rear window. The fallen shadows slowly rose, their golden eyes flickering as they silently watched the car recede.

"Those... who are they? Call... call 110!" Chu Zihang looked fearfully at the man.

"No use. Your phone probably has no signal," the man said softly.

"As for who they are... that would take some explaining," he added after a moment.

"Don't be afraid, son. A dad for one day is a dad for life. Your dad's still your dad, not a monster." One glance at Chu Zihang told him what the terror in his son's eyes meant.

"Don't worry, don't worry. Your dad is actually very capable. I just don't look the part..."

Apparently he was still the same man; at least he was just as talkative. But Chu Zihang could see he was far from relaxed. Sweat covered his face, his hands trembled slightly on the wheel, and he hunched like a shrimp, eyes fixed on the road ahead.

Sure enough, the phone had no signal. Chu Zihang turned on the radio; only static came through. GPS couldn't find a satellite signal either. Everything was beyond his understanding. How could so many strange people be on an elevated highway? It was covered in surveillance cameras, yet no road police came after such a serious accident. They seemed to have entered a space cut off from the world, containing only the elevated road, the storm, the shadows, and the Maybach.

"To put it simply, your bloodline is a little different from other people's." After a long silence, the man offered this rather unconvincing explanation.

"Don't look like it's the end of the world. A different bloodline is nothing to be ashamed of. Mine's different too. If you hadn't inherited it from me, you'd be perfectly normal."

He scratched his head. "Forget it. Let's not talk about it now. I'll explain properly when there's time... Actually, going abroad isn't bad. But remember, don't apply to a college called Cassell. It's full of lunatics."

"Say, will your stepdad leave you his fortune? Keep an eye on him. Don't let him take a mistress... or there'll be someone competing with you for the inheritance," the man said seriously.

"Have you seen Indiana Jones? The professor and his son are great! My lifelong dream is just like that: Dad driving in front, son behind him firing a machine gun!"

What went on inside this man's head? Even now he could chatter and grow animated.

They raced on for more than ten minutes. At their speed they had covered over forty kilometers. The shadows hadn't caught up, and the mercury light had vanished. Chu Zihang's pounding heart slowly returned to normal. Surely nothing in the world could run as fast as a Maybach at top speed. They should have left the shadows forty kilometers behind.

"Where are we going now?" he asked.

"I don't know. They're still here... they haven't gone... because the rain hasn't stopped. We have to find the exit." The man kept the accelerator floored. Chu Zihang could see he was no less tense.

The rain hadn't stopped? What did that mean? What did rain have to do with the shadows? His head was splitting.

A speed-reduction sign flashed past, announcing a toll station one kilometer ahead. Bright white lights emerged from the darkness. The man let out a long breath of relief.

"We should be back in a normal area. Get out after the toll station and see if a passing car can take you home. Your dad can give them some money." The man took out several banknotes for the toll, then pulled the sword from the car door.

"Where are you going?" Chu Zihang asked.

"They'll follow me. Don't worry, your dad really is capable, and this car—a nine-million-yuan Maybach—is no joke. I can outrun them."

At a time like this, he was still boasting about his car? Chu Zihang looked at him speechlessly.

"I was joking. Don't take it seriously." The man smiled. "But I really will be fine. I still have to attend your parent-teacher meetings. Don't worry... son."

The Maybach didn't slow. The toll station drew closer, its brilliant white light warm as an inn's lamp seen beneath the eaves by a traveler lost in night fog, making him quicken his steps, knowing he could lay down his worries once he arrived. Both Chu Zihang and the man gazed eagerly ahead.

The car abruptly slowed, brake pads squealing.

"No... something's wrong!" the man said hoarsely.

Chu Zihang sensed it too. The light ahead conveyed not only warmth but solemnity and grandeur, like... pilgrims approaching a temple.

Yes! That longing to draw near wasn't like seeing a lighthouse at sea. It was the reverent desire to worship a god, to approach the radiance of divinity.

But Chu Zihang believed in no god, none at all... until he saw that light.

They had stopped, but the light came toward them, threads of white radiating through darkness and rain.

Chu Zihang heard a horse neigh. He thought it must be an illusion. It sounded very much like a horse, but if it really was, what an immense creature it must be! Its deep roar was like thunder held in its mouth, lightning shooting from its nostrils.

"Listen to your dad. Don't get too far away from me, but don't get too close either." The man looked at him. "Like when I took you to fly a kite."

A kite never strays far from the person flying it, because a string connects them. When it does fly away, the string has broken.

Chu Zihang nodded.

"Buckle your seat belt!" The man pressed the accelerator with all his strength.

The Maybach surged forward at maximum acceleration, charging straight into the white light. The mist parted, and Chu Zihang suddenly saw what stood in the radiance...

His worldview collapsed. Everything he had believed was shattered. The world was nothing like he had imagined!

In the white light stood a horse as mighty as a mountain, draped in heavy armor inlaid with metal patterns, its white coat glowing like crystal. Eight powerful legs resembled the outriggers that steady a wheeled crane. Dark-gold horseshoes tore one wound after another in the hard road. A mask covered its face, and after each thunderous neigh, sparks of lightning sprayed from its metal nostrils.

A huge black figure sat astride it, encased in heavy dark-gold armor that glimmered under the rain. He carried a curved spear, its shaft arcing like a meteor across the sky. Behind his iron mask, a single golden eye lit the surroundings like a great lamp.

Odin, chief god of the Norse Aesir!

Chu Zihang had read his story in a book. Now he had come, just as in legend: riding the eight-legged Sleipnir, carrying Gungnir, a spear made from a branch of the World Tree, clad in dark-gold armor and a dark-blue cloak, one-eyed!

He should have existed only in words and murals!

The Maybach crashed into him. Sleipnir screamed, four front hooves rearing into the air. Rain from every direction gathered before Odin and struck the front of the Maybach. Chu Zihang could see nothing; it was as though a waterfall rushed toward them. The car's immense momentum dissolved within a few meters. Alarms sounded and airbags deployed, saving Chu Zihang's neck from snapping instantly.

The torrent pushed the Maybach back. Sleipnir slowly sank to its eight knees and stopped. Odin drove Gungnir into the wet asphalt, his divine horse his throne. Crowds of black figures emerged behind him like priests preparing for Mass. They surrounded the car on every side, all in identical black clothes, with identical pale faces and identical hollow eyes shining gold. The Maybach was completely surrounded. Apparently the gods' tactics resembled those of humans.

"Get out," the man said softly.

Chu Zihang moved mechanically, following him out. They stood side by side in the brilliant headlights, the man holding the long sword in one hand and drawing Chu Zihang close with the other.

"Don't be afraid... although I was terrified the first time I saw it too... But fear won't help. I didn't want you to see this, but since you have, don't miss the chance. Open your eyes wide!"

Chu Zihang gripped his hand. He had never felt the man so tall, as immovable as a mountain. Rain filled heaven and earth; beyond it lay limitless darkness. Beneath them stretched the broad elevated road, surrounded by transparent curtains of water, as though all the world's rain had gathered in this space, streams pressed together without gaps.

"You dare crash into the throne of a god!" Odin's deep voice came through the rain.

"I'm a driver. When you drive too much, your hand inevitably slips." The man spoke calmly. "I know what you want. Fine, I can give it to you."

He patted Chu Zihang's head. "Get the case from the trunk. Black, with a silver emblem."

There was indeed a black case in the trunk, its special leather rough and tough, with a silver plate engraved with a flourishing World Tree.

Chu Zihang handed it to the man, who weighed it, gave it back, and looked at Odin. "I'm ready."

"Then, human! Approach!"

"You've disobeyed me many times, but this time you must listen," the man whispered in Chu Zihang's ear. "Remember, don't leave me, but don't get too close. When I say 'run,' run toward the car. Don't look back, whatever you do. Don't look back!"

"Mm!" Chu Zihang trembled.

The shadows closed around them and carried them forward, whispering to one another in an ancient tongue, like singing and weeping. Chu Zihang couldn't understand a word, but the snakelike lines in his mind were waking, shifting endlessly. Suddenly he understood those eager voices of the dead:

"Human..."

"Humans again..."

"The child's bloodline..."

"Such mouthwatering fresh meat..."

"Thirsty..."

Chu Zihang covered his ears and looked around in terror. The shadows' faces were all alike, all expressionless, yet each bore too many stories of the past.

"I hear what you hear. Don't be afraid. Dad is beside you," the man whispered.

The man stopped about a hundred meters from Odin and a hundred from the Maybach behind them, exactly halfway between. Rain washed continuously over the sword in his hand.

"Even if I give you the thing, I don't think you'll let us go," he said.

He planted his feet wide, soaked trousers flapping in the cold wind, looking as swaggering as a street thug. But showing a thug's swagger before something like a god?

"I will promise you life," Odin said. "A god never lies to mortals."

"Life like these dead men?" The man pointed his thumb at the shadows.

"No. Your bloodlines are far superior to theirs. You will be much stronger."

"No room to bargain?"

"All who have been to this realm can return to it. Therefore everyone who comes here must be a servant of god."

"Son, they say you're a center on the city team, good at breaking through defenses?" the man murmured in Chu Zihang's ear.

Chu Zihang nodded nervously.

"Negotiations have broken down," the man said. "Give me the case."

He took it and gently stroked Chu Zihang's head. "Remember everything I told you. Every word." He suddenly slapped Chu Zihang on the rear and roared, "Run!"

Without thinking, Chu Zihang turned and ran madly toward the car. For a long time he had no longer believed the man's words, but on this rainy night, holding his warm hand, he had suddenly become a child dependent on his father again.

The man hurled the case toward Odin, like fresh meat thrown to draw wolves. Half the shadows rushed after it, half intercepted the man and Chu Zihang. Their forms distorted with speed, like long snakes springing from the ground. The man ran after Chu Zihang, but perhaps because he was middle-aged, he wasn't as fast; the distance between them widened. Watching his son's back recede, a smile touched his mouth. "Fast little rascal."

He spun, his sword carving a blinding arc and sending rain splashing outward in a circle.

Chu Zihang heard terrible sounds pursuing him: blood pouring from wounds, bones breaking beneath a blade, mingled with the storm.

He actually heard the shadows wailing: "It hurts," "It hurts so much," "It burns with pain"... desperate cries, as if from hell.

Thick, foul blood without warmth spattered his back, and even the rain could not wash it away. The man remained behind him. Chu Zihang gathered his courage and looked back. Like a lion the man swung his sword, and shadow after shadow split in its gleam.

A transparent curtain of air opened in the rain. A high cry burst from deep in the man's throat, as ancient as the shadows' whispers.

Where the curtain spread, time slowed. Wind and rain seemed to thicken, and the shadows slowed too, everything like a film in slow motion. Only the man was unaffected. He turned and swung his sword, stepping and sliding, water slowly splashing underfoot and the shadows' foul black blood slowly flowing out, all suspended for a moment in the air like ink drifting through water. Amid the ink, his flashing blade was a silver swallow in flight.

Chu Zihang had never imagined a man could look so magnificent, and this man was his father.

At last he threw himself into the car and shouted into the rain, "Dad!"

Suddenly he had a strange feeling... the kite string had broken.

It was the string between him and the man. For a very long time he had seen him only at long intervals, but there had always been a string between them. Now it had broken.

The man had not run back with him. After shaking off the shadows, he had turned and raced toward Odin!

The shadows with the case had counterattacked, and the man's domain expanded to cover them all. But Odin did not slow. He drew Gungnir and struck, lightning darting. Countless thrusts in an instant: each stroke of the legendary spear that always found its mark carried a dark-gold gleam. Arcs of light surrounded the man, attacking vital points from different directions like a dense meteor shower.

The man ignored the shadows. He dodged among the meteors, spinning with his sword, stepping on a shadow to leap high, and struck downward—at Odin, at the god's head!

Blood suddenly poured from his back. He fell among the shadows. The "meteors" he had dodged curved around like fireflies and struck him from behind. Odin withdrew Gungnir, and the shadows closed on the man step by step.

"Son! Drive away!" He turned sharply and roared at Chu Zihang, thick blood-red mist rising from his body.

Chu Zihang understood. The man wanted to draw every shadow surrounding them to himself. He was using himself as bait.

"Listen to me! Remember what you promised." The man's blood-red eyes stayed fixed on Odin, but he spoke to Chu Zihang. "If I die, you're all I leave in this world. If you die too, I'll have nothing left here."

"Son, trust your dad. If you live, we'll have a chance to meet again." He flexed his bleeding arm. "With you here, there are some of my big moves I can't use."

"That car's wonderful. It cost nine million! Something that damn expensive can't be stopped even by a god!"

Chu Zihang looked at the keyless console. He understood what the man had boasted about: three people could awaken the engine, and he was the third.

"Start," he said.

The engine roared.

"Well done, son!" The man raised his sword, his voice like thunder.

Chu Zihang reversed, the car flying backward. The man had secretly taught him to drive in this very Maybach; they had once sped along a country dirt road in spring with the sunroof open.

The Maybach struck a barely visible curtain of rain. Whirling wind battered its body, walls of water pressed in from every side. The twelve-cylinder engine roared at full power, but could not move the car out of that place.

"Hey! God! Open sesame!" the man roared, hurling his sword at the eight-legged horse's head. Gungnir struck again. The man leaped, surrounded by countless golden meteors.

The water wall's force weakened for an instant. The Maybach roared through it and plunged into the deep night.

Chu Zihang's mind was blank. He drove mechanically through the rain. At some point the stereo had come on again, and daughter and father were singing to each other:

Daughter, dear daughter, the match I made was right,

I married you to a wealthy family's son,

When I grow old, he will be the man you can rely on,

He is young, but he is growing.

Suddenly he understood the song.

Those were the words the man wanted to leave him. Whether he was a son or daughter didn't matter: the man had sent him into a wealthy family because he had no certainty about his own life. He wanted his child to live well and have someone to rely on.

This was a man who always lived a double life. Only rarely was he fierce and formidable; in most people's eyes he was a man of little ability. Yet he dared not show that fierce side to his son, so he could appear only as a driver, snatching time to collect him from school. That was all he could do. Many times he had waited outside the school in the Maybach, only to see the Mercedes S500 arrive and retreat with his head lowered. Believing his "daughter" had someone to rely on, he fled far away.

"You'll understand when you're older."

Now Chu Zihang understood. And the man... the man might already be dead.

What was death?

It was the end, a final parting, something irretrievable: a hand you could never hold again, warmth you could never feel, and "I'm sorry" you could never say.

Chu Zihang slammed on the brakes. Tires shrieked; the car stopped sideways on the empty elevated road in the rain. He opened the sunroof and leaned back, gasping like an asthmatic, looking up. It seemed all the world's rain poured through the opening, hard and cold against his face, but he felt neither cold nor pain. Only the man's voice and the song played back in his ears.

"Start! Start!" he suddenly shouted at the console.

The engine gave a low, feeble sound. The car had reached its limit and could not move again.

Chu Zihang flung open the door and ran into the wind and rain. At that instant he understood that he was truly about to lose the man. What the man would leave in the world, what he had promised him—all of it was forgotten. He had gone mad. He feared neither the shadows nor Odin nor Gungnir. He had to find the man.

In the downpour, a small figure sat on the Maybach's roof and watched him go, eyes faintly golden, humming the Irish folk song.

On July 3, 2004, Typhoon Dandelion, number 0407, made landfall in the city, bringing torrential rain and force-ten winds. The city was given three days off.

For the people of this coastal city, typhoons were ordinary, so no one panicked. Instead they happily enjoyed three unexpected days at home. Unable to go out, families sat together watching variety shows on television, and parents took the opportunity to make up for the time they usually couldn't spend with their children.

Naturally the typhoon caused trouble. Although the elevated road had been closed promptly, some drivers had still gone up. Eventually the wind grew too strong for them to drive, and police cars couldn't reach them. Officers phoned and told them to park against the barrier, close their windows tightly, and endure the night in the storm. Thanks to this, no cars were overturned, though their paint was scraped against the barrier and water got into their engines. In the morning the wind subsided and tow trucks went up to bring them out one by one. Every rescued person was overjoyed. A damaged car was nothing; insurance would pay. Having escaped death, everything was wonderful. At the exit they embraced waiting relatives, young people kissed, and older men and women wept. What a moving scene.

At last the families waiting at the exit left one by one, until only a boy remained. Without an umbrella, soaked through, he stood behind the crowd watching every car towed down. He seemed frozen, lips purple, trembling slightly, yet he did not move. Finally, when all the tow trucks had assembled and were about to leave, he approached the officer in charge. "Are there no more?"

"No more," the officer said. "Haven't found your family? Don't worry, we rescued everyone on the elevated road. Nobody was hurt. If you didn't see them, you must have missed each other. Go home and check."

Something faint in the boy's eyes seemed finally to go out. After a long silence he slowly crouched, both hands on the ground, saying nothing.

The officer couldn't see his face and thought he was crying. He wanted to pat his shoulder and comfort him. A boy didn't need to cry just because something had gone wrong; when in trouble, ask the police...

But he suddenly stopped. He did not dare approach. He could clearly see the boy's ten fingers, braced against the ground and curled into claws, digging deep into the asphalt. He had no time to wonder how a middle-school boy possessed such terrifying strength. He simply sensed, instinctively, the overwhelming waves of... sorrow erupting from that slender body.

On the night of July 12, 2010, rain fell on the city again, a fine, steady drizzle.

The World Cup final in South Africa: Spain against the Netherlands. The streets were empty, traffic lights changing lonely colors. All over the city, people gathered before televisions, drinking beer and shouting at good plays and bad.

Chu Zihang lay on his back in the dark, hands folded on his chest, staring at the enameled chandelier. Mom and her friends screamed in the next room; someone must have scored. They had already finished a case of beer. If they kept drinking, those beautiful, eccentric aunties would run into the garden in low-cut silk nightgowns, holding hands and acting crazy. But never mind; let them. A little madness once in a while was fine.

Mom had already drunk her milk tonight.

Chu Zihang was reciting his diary. It was written neither on paper nor in an electronic file, but in his mind. It contained many images, passing frame by frame: riding on the man's shoulders shouting "Giddyap!"; the only expensive toy the man had bought him, a model train set; and the scene the man himself would have considered the most spectacular of his life, standing with legs apart and holding a sword for worshiping—or killing—a god... Every night before sleep, Chu Zihang recalled them, every detail, until he was sure he had forgotten nothing.

Masashi Toyama, who taught Introduction to Brain Science, said human memory was unreliable, like a worn-out hard drive easily demagnetized. The past was like a picture drawn in sand. As time passed, wind blew the sand away, memory blurred, and finally everything became an indistinguishable haze. Toyama said this was a form of self-protection: imagine remembering every detail of the past forever. The saddest, most painful, most sorrowful images of your life would torment you constantly, and you could never escape the bad times behind you.

But Chu Zihang did not want to forget, because he was the only person in the world who still remembered that man. If he forgot too, it would be as though the man had never existed.

The man had once said that if he died one day, only one thing in the world could prove he had existed: Chu Zihang, who carried half his blood.

"Dad, it's raining again." Having recalled the final image, Chu Zihang spoke softly.

Rain rattled against the window. He slowly closed his eyes and fell asleep.

Act One

Birthday Cake Is the Grave of Youth

Birthday Cake is the Grave of Youth

Birthdays did not really matter to Lu Mingfei. Who would remember? His uncle and aunt? Don't be ridiculous. His parents? They were spectacularly unreliable. Was there anyone in the world who actually cared that Lu Mingfei had taken another step toward becoming a sleazy middle-aged man?

A birthday with no one to celebrate it with was just another ordinary day. He had had plenty of those.

He woke to cicadas shrieking their hearts out. The sunshine was almost poisonous, and the stuffy room felt like the steamer in Journey to the West in which demons cooked a fat monk.

Lu Mingfei waved a paper fan inscribed I COME BY MOONLIGHT—words that made him feel like a lecherous thief—and typed www.i-cassell-you.com into his laptop.

He entered the username Ricardo.M.Lu, a password that changed with the date, and authentication from a security USB drive. A tap on Enter refreshed the screen to the Cassell College Vacation Daily Report Form: a dark-green interface with clean, thin borders and more buttons than he could take in at a glance. Lu Mingfei fished a wrinkled little notebook from the pocket of his baggy shorts and began following its instructions item by item.

"Have you detected any unidentified dragons?"

Lu Mingfei checked No. Under a clear blue sky in broad daylight, where would dragons be running around? Coming home for summer vacation meant returning to the real world and severing all contact with reptiles.

"Have you used a Yanling?"

Another No. After the battle at the Three Gorges Reservoir, all his Yanling abilities had vanished again. He had risked a quarter of his life for them, only to get a single use and no after-sales service. Lu Mingze was a crooked businessman.

"Have you experienced any physical abnormalities?"

"Have you discovered any suspected alchemical equipment?"

No, no, no, no, no... This was Lu Mingfei's summer vacation after freshman year. He was doing his daily report.

The daily report was a Cassell College rule. During winter and summer breaks, students had to report online every day. Professors graded the reports: good ones raised a student's GPA, while lying counted as cheating on an exam. In a sense this was their vacation homework, that turd teachers left to spoil your happy days off and remind you they existed. It was like finally getting dessert after a meal, only for someone to sprinkle mustard oil over it. But at Cassell College the daily report was absolutely necessary, because its students were absolutely exceptional.

Cassell College was a private, elite institution for the privileged in the Great Lakes region of Illinois. None of those adjectives quite captured it. It was a paradise for monsters and lunatics.

A college for dragon hybrids.

The professors firmly believed that dragons had once ruled the world as an intelligent race. This rewrote evolution: humanity was no longer the sole pinnacle of the evolutionary tree. Before mammals produced humans, reptiles had given rise to a supreme intelligent species, the dragons. That history had been buried after humanity rose, surviving only in scraps and fragments of ancient myths. But the decline of the dragons did not mean their extinction. The Dragon Kings, bearers of the most sacred bloodlines, merely slept, and would one day awaken. They were unlikely to join the United Nations and build a better home with humanity. They intended to restore the theocratic age of reptiles.

They could do it, too. They were nothing like the monsters of knightly romances, clumsily flying about and stupidly breathing fire. They possessed a mysterious art called alchemy and the sacred power of words known as Yanling, which could even alter the laws of physics.

Most humans believed dragons were only myths because a certain group had long erased evidence of their existence: the dragon hybrids. Born of humans and dragons, they had human hearts and draconic powers. They kept the dragons' secret and bore the duty of guardians. Cassell trained the finest hybrids and sent them around the world to prevent the Dragon Kings' awakening and, when necessary, devise plans to slay them and send those unrepentant monarchs back to their long sleep.

Lu Mingfei had grown up under the red flag and in the sunshine, educated in materialism with all the proper beliefs. Though he sometimes indulged in wild fantasies, he had never imagined supernatural nonsense like dragons could have anything to do with him.

Yet Cassell College had come all that way to recruit him, singing the praises of his bloodline.

The courses were outrageous, and the textbooks even more absurd—more absurd than Japan's new history textbooks. There it was in black and white: humans had not struggled against nature for a million years before learning to use tools and fire; dragons had taught those skills to their servants. Attila the Hun was a dragon, which was why he was so powerful that no one could stop him as he fought his way to Rome. Chinese emperors had not been boasting when they called themselves descendants of dragons, because as far back as the Three Sovereigns and Five Emperors, every enlightened person fit to lead had indeed been a dragon hybrid...

After taking classes there, Lu Mingfei figured every historical event probably had something to do with dragons. Maybe, just as in Stephen Chow's version of The Deer and the Cauldron, the Qing dynasty had really fallen because the Red Flower Society severed its dragon vein.

Since everyone was a human-dragon hybrid, geniuses were everywhere and elites were a dime a dozen. Every genius and elite had a shocking side, and without strict discipline and management the consequences of letting them run wild were unthinkable. Compared with these hybrids, even Ultraman, Pikachu, and the Transformers might be nothing special. During summer break these people lived among ordinary crowds. If one of them accidentally unleashed a Yanling...

They had indeed learned painful lessons in that regard.

Fortunately, the college leadership were not elegant but useless intellectuals. Before the college was founded, the dragon slayers' organization had been called the Dragon Blood Secret Party. Anyone daring to call themselves a party had to be a scheming customer, no pushover; without an iron hand,

how could they command obedience? Principal Anjou therefore played his trump card: the daily report. Students complained, but it worked, reducing accidents that required the college to clean up afterward by as much as eighty percent. Of course, eliminating them entirely was impossible. Last year a student with a heroic streak had secretly taken alchemical equipment from campus to excavate a hidden dragon tomb in Egypt's Valley of the Kings, awakening a dragon about to emerge from its cocoon. He missed his return date and pursued it across thousands of miles, taking Star Alliance flights from Cairo to Istanbul, then New York and Cape Town. Finally, when he fired an alchemical missile at the dragon's seaplane, he shot down a new stealth drone the Pentagon was test-flying. The American stealth-aircraft industry interpreted the incident as proof that an adversary had mastered every technique needed to detect their aircraft and was making an unmistakable demonstration. They abandoned their existing research and threw themselves into a space-shuttle project for attacks from outer space.

The Board of Trustees punished the student severely, but Lu Mingfei had to admit that was how students at Cassell thought: anything went in the pursuit of dragon slaying. The plane had only itself to blame for crossing the senior student's missile trajectory at exactly the wrong moment.

"Mingfei! Don't get up and start playing on the computer first thing! Go downstairs and buy a bag of Cantonese sausage and a bunch of scallions, and check the front desk for any new packages while you're at it!" His aunt's voice carried so well it came through a twenty-centimeter load-bearing wall and left Lu Mingfei reeling. A demonic sound straight through the brain.

"Okay, okay! Just a second!" Lu Mingfei hurried to his feet.

His parents had gone abroad for work when he was little and never returned, leaving him in storage with his uncle and aunt. Only after enrolling at Cassell did he learn they were both distinguished alumni, traveling the world for the cause of dragon slaying and far too busy to look after their troublesome kid. Fortunately, that meant the college viewed him differently and classified his bloodline as S-rank. He was its only S-rank student, with an exclusive scholarship worth tens of thousands of dollars. Admittedly, nobody had seen anything extraordinary about him yet—in other words, everyone else at the college had a Yanling and he did not—but perhaps that could be explained by a modest, understated personality...

After years of swallowing insults in his uncle and aunt's house, he could finally hold his head high. Summer vacation was the perfect time to return home in glory!

He was no longer that troublesome kid. In his first semester's practical course, he had stabbed the King of Bronze and Fire, one of the Four Monarchs of the dragons, to death at the Three Gorges Reservoir... though one might suspect a little cheating.

By comparison, a student ID that doubled as a credit card with a hundred-thousand-dollar limit was nothing. Once you had saved the world, why discuss something as vulgar as money?

He even owned a car now. He had won a Bugatti Veyron in a bet... though he had smashed it up on his first drive and still couldn't afford repairs.

He had a boss, too. He had joined the Student Council under President Caesar Gattuso. Brother Caesar had very few virtues, only three. First, he could fight: with two modified Desert Eagles and Yanling: Kamaitachi, he had actually wounded the Dragon King Constantine. Second, he was rich; Lu Mingfei had won his Bugatti from him. Third, he was generous and grand, spending lavishly every birthday on a swimsuit-and-champagne party by the pool. Few people in the world caught Caesar's eye,

yet in front of every Student Council officer he had clapped Lu Mingfei on the shoulder and said, "Recruiting Lu Mingfei is our greatest achievement this year!" His next words were, "Even if he's good for nothing, I won't let our only S-rank fall into Chu Zihang's Lionheart Society!"

What an honor! How could Lu Mingfei not be proud? With that background and status, he had no weaknesses at all!

As the plane crossed the Bering Strait on its way home, Lu Mingfei practiced smiling. No matter how his uncle and aunt praised him, he must smile calmly, not grin and show his gums. That was the aristocratic Cassell style. The passenger beside him watched the boy smile faintly, compose himself, smile faintly again, then compose himself again, over and over as if practicing a secret martial art, and spent the entire journey in terror.

But when he stepped through his uncle's door, he was greeted not by flowers but by a heap of radish strips on the dining table. His uncle and aunt were sweating over a lively operation to pickle dried radish.

"Mingfei, you're back? Perfect timing! Go buy me half a jin of coarse salt!" His aunt was delighted to see him.

"Okay, okay." From habit, Lu Mingfei put down his luggage, took the two and a half yuan in change, and headed downstairs.

Only outside did it hit him. Damn it! He was practically a successful man now. Did he really have to buy salt himself? Shouldn't his precious hands be reserved for saving the world?

He returned with the salt and helped his aunt cut radishes. Just as he was preparing to describe his year in America with suitable restraint, she spoke first. "Mingfei, let me ask you something..."

He had not yet realized this was the prelude to Cheng Yaojin's three axe blows.

"You've been in America a year. Have you saved any of your scholarship?"

The first blow turned him to stone. She had struck his weak point. On paper he was rich, but the college had strict rules: to collect his scholarship he had to pass every test, submit papers on time, and earn excellent grades. Apart from his practical course, his results were miserable. In twelve months he had received only four months' scholarship money, and his credit card was now thousands in the red. Some of his swagger deflated, and he unconsciously put more effort into cutting the radishes.

"People say American girls are very open. Have you found a girlfriend?" The second blow followed hard on the first.

Lu Mingfei's head dropped. That question really hurt. How could he put it? The figure that kept appearing and disappearing in his heart was... He couldn't very well confess, "I think my boss's girlfriend Nono is great, and she's been good to me, but I'm rather like a toad gazing up at a swan, and I'm still single."

"Did you see your parents?" The ultimate finishing move.

Lu Mingfei had almost forgotten what they looked like. In a whole year he had received only two letters from his mother, Qiao Weini. Even on the emergency-contact form when he enrolled, he could only put his uncle and aunt. His impressive parents, his dashing parents, his busy parents, the parents who supposedly loved Lu Mingfei so deeply, were occupied with some great enterprise to fight dragons and save the world. They had no time to come back and see him.

In his heart they were as distant as a myth.

You couldn't always ask someone else to say "I love you" for you, could you? Even if you wrote it a thousand times in letters, one day you still had to say it yourself. Lu Mingfei wanted his parents to prove their sincerity one day, with something dramatic: suddenly appearing before him, travel-worn, suitcases in hand, standing amid steam from a train or the rush of air behind a plane, gazing silently at their troublesome son and saying in trembling voices, "You've... grown so much?"

Right? That would be moving! Then he could resist the urge to crouch on the ground and bawl, and say casually, "You're back."

Come on, heroes! Prove to the unlucky kid you brought into this world that you would cross mountains and oceans just to see him and say a sentimental "I love you"!

But so far, to Lu Mingfei, his parents were merely signatures at the ends of letters, definitions in a figure of speech, and two splendid names in an alumni directory: Lu Lincheng and Qiao Weini.

Lu Mingfei fell silent. His knife struck hollowly against the chopping board.

His aunt understood at once. With a contemptuous smile she said she'd known his parents were unreliable. She had hoped they might recommend Mingze, but fortunately she'd had the foresight not to wait. If she had relied on them, would Mingze ever have gotten into Austin University?

His cousin Lu Mingze had just received his acceptance from Austin University, and the whole family had celebrated. After spending a year in the shadow of "even a loser like Lu Mingfei got into an American university," his aunt could finally hold her head high. Her back straightened, her legs stopped aching when she walked, and she could speak without running out of breath. An American university acceptance letter worked like a calcium supplement for her.

"Don't cut the strips so thick! The salt won't get in!" his aunt barked.

"Mm-hmm." Lu Mingfei was sweating buckets.

"Apply to our Austin University. It's a famous school, everyone's very friendly, and the professors are especially nice..." Lu Mingze's voice came from the inner room. Wearing a headset, he was chatting on QQ voice with his feet on the desk and the air conditioning turned up high. Cool air bathed him, and a girl's soft admiration at the other end sent him floating, lending his voice ever more dramatic rises and falls. He was 160 centimeters tall and weighed 160 jin, but when it came to chasing girls he was far more reliable than his cousin. He had heard his cousin was still single; if he got a girlfriend first, he would be what his mother called a winner in life.

Actually Lu Mingze had no real need to look down on Lu Mingfei. With Austin University behind him, he felt superior to his cousin from head to toe in every possible way. But since he was so outstanding, he might as well show off without shame.

To the clatter of the keyboard, Lu Mingfei packed the radish strips into a pickle jar, rubbed coarse salt over each layer, and sealed it. Salt seeped into his skin, leaving it dry and rough.

"Carry the jar out to the balcony! Look how clumsy you are. You didn't learn to cook in America either, did you?" His aunt pointed.

Among the most invincible creatures in the world were middle-aged women: sturdy, practical, and sharp-eyed. With only three questions they could reduce a swaggering brat to his true form. To a middle-aged woman, if you had no parents, girlfriend, or money, what were you showing off for? However capable you were, however many dragons you'd killed, it meant nothing. Even if you were

great enough to master Star Platinum, you still needed a reason to throw a punch, didn't you? You had nothing, not even a reason to throw a punch... Were you supposed to fight for eternal justice?

What nonsense.

"Hurry up! How long have I been calling you? Lazy and poor go together, ever heard that? If you're lazy, you'll be poor!" His aunt grew sharper still.

Lu Mingfei hastily clicked Send and rushed out. His aunt's demonic voice boring through his brain... even a hero like his uncle, who had practiced the Golden Bell Shield for twenty years, couldn't withstand it.

"Ricardo.M.Lu, you have one unread message." A window suddenly appeared on the screen.

Ricardo:

According to your enrollment information, you were born on July 17, 1991, and turn nineteen today.

On this important day, on behalf of Principal Hilbert Jean Anjou and all the professors of the academic board, I wish you a happy birthday.

Thank you for attending Cassell College and sharing these wonderful times with us. It is an honor to grow together.

Yours sincerely, Norma.

PS. Under college rules, a student celebrating a birthday may collect one birthday cake from the cafeteria. Since you are currently on summer vacation in China, your complimentary birthday cake has been canceled. Furthermore, the summer term begins July 20, 2010. Your transcript shows D grades in two courses last semester, meaning you did not pass. I regret to inform you that you must attend remedial classes and retake the examinations during the summer term. I have booked your flight back to campus. Please be ready to depart at any time.

"Birthday?" Lu Mingfei stared. Since coming home, he had spent his days serving at his aunt's command and his evenings playing StarCraft. The days had blurred together, and he had completely forgotten.

He was nineteen, just like that? Time really flew. Think of what heroes had accomplished at nineteen... Zhou Yu and his sworn brother Sun Ce had already established a base in Jiangdong and married the Qiao sisters, with territory and women to call their own... And this was how his own nineteenth birthday arrived?

"What the hell? What kind of congratulatory email is this? It's just telling me my free cake is canceled and I failed classes!" After reading the PS twice, Lu Mingfei finally caught on.

Birthdays did not really matter to Lu Mingfei. Who would remember? His uncle and aunt? Don't be ridiculous. His parents? They were spectacularly unreliable. Was there anyone in the world who actually cared that Lu Mingfei had taken another step toward becoming a sleazy middle-aged man?

A birthday with no one to celebrate it with was just another ordinary day. He had had plenty of those.

His phone chimed. A text had arrived.

"Happy birthday. Chu Zihang." As concise as that senior student's expressionless face.

Someone actually remembered his birthday, and that someone was Chu Zihang.

Chu Zihang was president of Cassell's Lionheart Society, the Student Council's sworn enemy, while Lu Mingfei was a new Council member. It was like Lu Su waking on his birthday to a card from Cao Cao: bewildering and full of conflicting feelings. Lu Mingfei had no idea how Chu Zihang had gotten his number. He certainly hadn't saved Chu Zihang's, and the senior had spoken fewer than a hundred sentences to him altogether. Was this an attempt to win him over? But would the stone-faced senior, who would cut down anyone who stood in his path, really resort to such tactics?

While Lu Mingfei was speculating, another text arrived.

"Lu Mingfei, is this your number? I'm Chen Wenwen. The Literature Club is having lunch at Sophie Lad Pizza at 11:30 today. Come along if you get this."

His heart rippled... No, a colossal meteorite had struck the middle of the Pacific, raising towering waves!

The sudden message was like Chen Wenwen's invitation to join the Literature Club years ago: casual, unexpected, and delightful. That had been a summer too. Cicadas screamed their hearts out, the sunlight outside was blinding, and the shadow of the eaves lay sharp as a blade across the ground. He had leaned against the windowsill, bored out of his mind, while Chen Wenwen, in a blue-and-white cloth dress and low-heeled sandals, moved lightly past as though walking on tiptoe along a road at night.

"Are you Lu Mingfei? Do you like reading?" Chen Wenwen had stopped abruptly.

He had looked up in surprise. Her eyes were like water, rippling faintly as they reflected the sun.

"Pathetic," Lu Mingfei muttered. Chen Wenwen had a boyfriend now, and the whole affair had left him miserable... Yet remembering that instant when he looked up still stirred him.

"Sure," he replied.

"Mingfei, you haven't left yet?" His aunt burst in.

"I'm going, I'm going!" Startled, Lu Mingfei snapped to attention.

"Good thing you haven't." She waved what she was holding: a cracked toilet seat. "Your uncle cracked it sitting on it. Go to the building-supply market and buy a new one, beechwood, something decent. Your uncle and I are taking Mingze to buy a suit for going abroad, to wear at the graduation ceremony! Don't dawdle. Buy the seat and have the property management people install it. We'll be back at four thirty this afternoon. Steam the sausage, clean the scallions, and cut some radish for soup!"

Having issued her orders, his aunt turned and left. The outer door slammed, and a few minutes later his uncle's little BMW drove away downstairs.

Lu Mingfei's head ached. What a busy birthday: the Literature Club gathering, his aunt's many errands, and a family dinner that evening to celebrate Lu Mingze's departure for study in America.

Eleven time zones away, at Cassell College in Illinois.

Late at night the central control room on the library's second floor was ablaze with light. Manstein stood before a giant 3D projection: a virtual globe five meters high floated before him, spinning rapidly to whatever location he wanted with a light wave of his hand. It felt like a god manipulating his creation, a thrilling sense of command and power. If politicians knew such an advanced projection system existed, they would scramble to buy one and indulge their urge to direct the world: cosplay Hitler if they liked, Genghis Khan if they preferred, like the old teacher in From the Herbal Garden to

the Three Flavor Study reciting of an iron scepter wielded in splendid command and golden cups emptied without drunkenness.

But Manstein was not enjoying himself at all. Manstein wanted to die.

Seven or eight red lights flashed at once on the ghostly blue globe, alarms rising and falling. The control room was filled with rapid keyboard clatter, printers hissing, and mechanical cipher machines clicking as they translated coded messages. His head was ready to explode. Day or night, the atmosphere was always like this; tonight Manstein was the unlucky professor on duty.

As many as seventy experts and interns worked there, each facing several terminals at once. The college secretary, or rather the supercomputer named Norma, gathered information relevant to the college from across the world, but people still had to analyze it and make decisions. The central control room was the college's think tank.

"Executive Department agents intercepted a smuggling plane over Peru. We found priceless Egyptian alchemical equipment dating from 700 BC in the cabin! They have the situation completely under control," an intelligence officer shouted hoarsely through his headset. "But they shot the plane down... They're making an emergency landing and requesting rescue!"

"Please sign this reimbursement form. Our agents in Greece are waiting for the funds!" A female secretary hurried up in clicking high heels and handed Manstein a bill.

"Seventy thousand dollars?" His eyes bulged. "For a sum this large they need to submit a formal report!"

"There's no time... They're dealing with the mob."

"We're a college! We're educators! What are we doing dealing with the mob?" Manstein exploded.

"Several recent serial murders are suspected to involve a death servitor. The mob knows something, and our agents in Greece believe it must be captured before the police get involved." The secretary caught her breath. "It's urgent. They called directly for money. Both sides reportedly have their fingers on their triggers while they wait. If the money doesn't arrive... the other side may think they're being cheated and open fire!"

Manstein was about to say more when an anxious financial expert rushed over.

"OPEC announced an increase in crude oil prices five minutes ago!"

"What the hell do crude oil prices have to do with me?" Manstein glared. "I didn't buy oil futures."

"But the college did... a huge position, using over 1.2 billion in reserves. If we don't sell in time, we'll suffer enormous losses."

"How enormous?" Manstein covered his face.

"Conservatively, possibly two hundred million..." The expert wiped cold sweat from his face.

Manstein felt one breath away from spraying blood all the way to the ceiling. He signed the secretary's bill with a flourish, turned to the financial expert, and ordered, "Sell! Sell everything!"

He couldn't be bothered about Greece's seventy thousand dollars. Tonight a word from him moved hundreds of millions; was there any point getting angry over a mere seventy thousand? What a wretched night, and he alone had to hold it together. Normally three professors shared a shift: tonight it was his turn with Guderian and Schneider, director of the Executive Department. The scatterbrained Guderian was plainly unreliable, so when he said he was used to going to bed early and didn't want

overtime, Manstein agreed to cover for an old friend. But Schneider, famed as an iron-willed enforcer, had let him down too, saying he had an important academic paper to revise and asking Manstein to cover. Manstein knew that although Schneider was a butcher—he regarded everyone in the Executive Department as butchers, crude people who knew only knives and guns—he had always wanted more publications so he wouldn't fall behind the other professors academically. So he agreed.

But the whole world was unsettled tonight, and not one piece of good news had arrived to lift his spirits.

"The Equipment Department has achieved tremendous success testing a new alchemical weapon in the Sahara!" An intern sprang from his chair and raised his arms in triumph.

His wild delight caught on. Everyone knew the department was preparing a secret weapons test deep in the Sahara: a superweapon that might tip the balance between humans and dragons. It had succeeded! Everyone raised their arms and cheered, as if NASA had just announced a successful moon landing.

Manstein perked up and started toward the intern's terminal. Then a piercing alarm swept through the control room. It was a high-level warning. He turned to see a rapidly flashing red light expanding in the heart of the Sahara on the globe, threatening to engulf the entire earth!

"What happened? Didn't you say it was a tremendous success?" he roared at the intern.

"A minor problem... The Pentagon's spy satellite Tungusta happened to be passing over the Sahara and observed our test. It mistook it for... a nuclear explosion. According to our inside source, the CIA has reported it to the president. Since the test site was in Libya, the ambassador there will probably issue a stern diplomatic note very soon... accusing Libya of conducting a secret nuclear test..."

Manstein slapped himself hard. I knew it, he thought. When has that bunch of lunatics in the Equipment Department ever brought good news? But did they have to make it this outrageous?

"What alchemical weapon could possibly be mistaken for a nuclear explosion?" the duty professor cried in anguish, his voice echoing through the library's marble corridors.

"A tactical missile fitted with an alchemically refined silver warhead... Combined with refined mercury, niter extracted from Vesuvius's volcanic ash, and the blood of a holy infant, the explosion can lethally poison dragons in its central zone."

"What use is that? How many dragons will wait in the middle of the desert for you to bomb them? What if one is in New York? Kill thousands of people along with one dragon? Those ingredients can kill humans as well!" Manstein collapsed into his chair. "I need to make some calls to deal with this... I need a little time..." Then he sprang up again, slamming both palms on the desk. "Executive Department, send people immediately! People! Fly them to the Sahara and clean up the site before the Pentagon gets there!"

A tremendous roar drowned him out. The floor shook violently and the lights went out, then came back on. Manstein fell, rolled to his feet, and rushed to the window. A column of dark-blue flame shot into the night sky from the direction of the Ice Cellar, the storehouse for alchemical equipment. The things kept there could destroy the earth several times over!

"Something's happened!" He lunged for the central console and grabbed a hammer to smash the glass covering the red lever for the campus-wide alarm.

Then the red telephone on the console rang. He hesitated, but answered it first. The line went directly to the Ice Cellar; he wanted to find out what was happening. Intruders? An accidental explosion?

"Hello? Who's on duty tonight?" asked a casual voice.

"Manstein, head of the Discipline Committee! What's going on?" The tone infuriated him. He recognized the Equipment Department's spokesperson. The weapon-obsessed lunatics rarely appeared in person and entrusted their communications to this unreliable representative.

"Just a routine experiment, a tiny bit of open flame. Everything is under our control," the spokesperson said calmly. "No need to make a fuss. We're calling to notify you that the Equipment Department has an experiment in the Ice Cellar tonight."

Manstein's eyes blazed. "Under control? Your Sahara experiment..."

"All departments in position! Hydrogen flame ready. Let's do it again..." someone called through the receiver.

"Again? You lunatics won't stop until somebody gets killed, will you?" Manstein roared, but only a busy signal answered. The spokesperson had already hung up with brisk efficiency.

He slowly replaced the receiver and sank weakly into his chair. What could he do? Some departments at the college could not be offended, and Equipment was one of them. Even knowing their reckless experiments might bring the sky down... no one wanted their new equipment to explode for no reason on the next assignment.

Quick, sharp footsteps approached and the control-room door was shoved open. Schneider was dragging Guderian along. These two disloyal fellows had left Manstein to take the blame alone; ordinarily they would hardly return out of kindness. Guderian had apparently been dragged from his nest and was still wearing a Pikachu nightcap. Entirely in keeping with his taste.

"What is it?" Manstein snatched off Guderian's cap and tossed it aside, but addressed Schneider. Guderian looked sleepy, with an expression that said this had nothing to do with him and he wanted to go back to bed.

"We lost some information in China." Schneider's voice was low and hoarse, always enough to make a listener's skin crawl.

"Tsk!" Manstein scoffed. What was one lost document in China? One of them had gone to sleep in a Pikachu cap, the other had used a paper as an excuse, and he had been left alone for twelve hours. In that time he had cleaned up after seven Executive Department teams around the world, authorized as much as $120,000 in expenses, prevented a gunfight, and was dealing with an imaginary nuclear crisis... And now they rushed in to tell him some information was lost?

Schneider slapped a file onto the desk. The dark-red stamp on its cover brought Manstein's overtime-muddled brain awake as if someone had poured cold water over it. It showed a great serpent holding its tail in its mouth to form a circle, its scales distinct, with two bold black letters in the center: SS.

"Top classification..." Manstein said softly.

Cassell missions, like bloodlines, were divided into grades. In descending priority they were A, B, C, D, E, and F. Special missions beyond those grades were designated S-rank. S-rank missions were rare; Operation Bronze against the Dragon King Norton at the Three Gorges Reservoir had been one.

SS was an exception among exceptions, not necessarily more important than S but extraordinarily special. Such missions came directly from the Board of Trustees, bypassing Principal Anjou.

The nuclear crisis had just been classified A-rank and had already reached the diplomatic level, yet the mission involving this information was SS. What could be so deadly important that even the trustees hidden behind the scenes couldn't sit still? Some scandal involving the trustees?

"Yes. Something the board wants." Schneider nodded slowly.

Manstein nodded and clapped his hands. "Ladies and gentlemen, give us the room."

Everyone else stood and filed out. As the financial expert passed Manstein, he asked quietly, "Sell in stages?"

"That's not important now. Decide for yourself." Manstein waved him away, leaving the 1.2-billion-dollar transaction to the expert. Only one thing mattered now: an SS-rank mission. Once one appeared, everything else gave way.

"You can't leave!" He caught Guderian trying to slip out at the back of the line and pulled him back.

"You said you wanted to talk alone," Guderian said, scratching his head. "I don't understand those things you're discussing anyway."

"But you're a professor on duty." Manstein sighed. "None of us can decide an SS-rank mission alone. With the principal away, the duty professors decide together. You have to be here."

Only the three of them remained in the vast control room. The doors closed tightly. No one dared eavesdrop on a secret mission from the trustees; the college might have a free atmosphere, but its rules were strict.

"What is it?" Manstein asked.

"You're better off not asking," Schneider said. "You weren't supposed to know anything about it. It was handled directly by the Executive Department. We only had to tell you because something went wrong."

"With a mission classified this highly, the Executive Department should have given it everything. How could there be a problem?"

"We did give it everything. We made detailed plans, obtained the information, and sent our best man to escort it back to campus personally. But it was lost on the way." Schneider gestured. The projection changed to a building with a turtle-shell-shaped glass dome, like an airport waiting hall, except it had been completely deformed. Its high-strength aluminum-alloy beams were twisted like pretzels. A simulation showed the disaster: as the ground shook, every beam twisted inexplicably, as if turned by giant hands, and thousands upon thousands of glass panes broke loose and fell straight down.

"I've seen that hall. It's the South Railway Station!" Guderian said suddenly.

"Yes. You saw it in Lu Mingfei's hometown. It was still under construction when you went for the interview, and began trial operations this summer. Its glass dome consisted of 3,200 high-strength panes, and its aluminum frame was designed to withstand a magnitude-eight earthquake, using the most advanced building technology. But this morning, Beijing time, it was destroyed in a magnitude-three quake. All 3,200 panes fell vertically, like 3,200 blades cutting at once." Schneider paused. "And our man was waiting for a train there with the information."

"He died?" Manstein asked.

"Cut to pieces," Schneider said quietly. "It was Raymond."

They had deployed Agent B007, Raymond, which showed how careful the Executive Department had been. A 2006 graduate of Cassell's mechanical engineering department, B-rank, Raymond possessed Yanling number 28, Blazing Sun, radiating light up to 4,000 lumens within his domain. The light could not kill, but his domain was a giant incandescent bulb fifty meters across. Anyone approaching him effectively entered the bulb and couldn't open their eyes. Though not a high-level Yanling, it was considered absurdly powerful, a game-breaking ability. Yet Raymond had died, and Blazing Sun had been useless, because his opponents had no eyes: 3,200 panes of glass falling from the sky.

"The casualties must have been terrible," Manstein said.

"Besides Raymond, only three people were injured. The station was still in its trial period, with few departures and few passengers waiting."

"Was he attacked by one of our kind? A building designed to withstand a magnitude-eight quake collapsing in a magnitude-three one is impossible to explain," Manstein said.

"I know. In China they call that tofu-dreg construction," Guderian interjected.

"If you don't understand, stop squawking!" Manstein snapped. "A magnitude-three quake wouldn't even bring down a condemned building!"

"We don't know. I've never heard of a Yanling like that," Schneider said. "What Yanling could destroy an aluminum-alloy hall large enough for thousands of passengers? That kind of force is almost comparable to Rhine."

"We don't have time to send an investigation team, do we?" Manstein said.

"No investigation team. Send someone to recover the information directly. The board's deadline is seven tonight, local time." Schneider checked his watch. "About eight hours."

"Who can we send? Who's nearby? Dispatch someone local."

"People in other cities can't make it. Railways and airports are closed until nine tonight against aftershocks," Schneider said. "The campus maintenance staff could drive there; they have a group vacationing in China."

Manstein pictured those men with steel-hard arms and stone-slab chests and shook his head. "Maintenance can assist, but the agent should have a bloodline advantage."

"Then we can only call on students: A-rank Chu Zihang and S-rank Lu Mingfei. Both have an unquestionable bloodline advantage," Schneider said. "Their homes are local, and they're on summer break."

Even in this serious, tense moment that admitted no levity, Manstein gave a rueful smile at Lu Mingfei's name. A bloodline advantage? He had one, certainly; S-rank marked the highest bloodline. But...

"That's right! With Mingfei there's no problem! He's S-rank!" Guderian looked as though he'd found treasure in a garbage heap. As Lu Mingfei's adviser, he had always had confidence in his student.

"I really don't know where your confidence comes from. Your S failed two courses last semester; the transcript has already gone to the academic board." Manstein shook his head. "An S-rank who can't even use a Yanling. Without a Yanling he has no innate ability. As a hybrid he's useless."

"Send Chu Zihang," Schneider said. "He has successfully completed many missions."

"As head of the Discipline Committee, I'm responsible for student discipline, and there are things I remember very clearly. Your student Chu Zihang is a confirmed devotee of violence. His record contains twelve disciplinary citations for violent tendencies during missions!" Manstein shook his head again. "Put an ungraduated violent offender in charge of an SS-rank mission?"

"The Executive Department is itself an organization of violence!" Schneider was just as protective of his own student.

"I know you're the chief thug," Manstein said. "But no. Chu Zihang can't be in charge alone."

"We have no choice," Schneider said. "I know my student. Chu Zihang is suited to working alone."

"He doesn't have to go alone. Mingfei will support him!" Guderian seized the opportunity.

Manstein looked straight into Schneider's iron-gray eyes. "A top-level mission needs a top-level team. Chu Zihang does have a bloodline advantage, but he isn't good enough to carry out a mission of this level by himself. At most he can be one member of a team!"

"I head the Executive Department. This is its mission, and Chu Zihang is my student. Do you understand?" Schneider was just as forceful.

"There's Mingfei..." Guderian watched their gazes strike sparks.

After several seconds, Schneider and Manstein both realized neither could overwhelm the other. They turned simultaneously and paced apart in agitation.

"Mingfei..." Guderian looked from one to the other.

"Chu Zihang as agent! Lu Mingfei assisting!" Schneider and Manstein turned and spoke at once. At last they had compromised. They had no choice: time was running out, and no one could afford to offend the trustees.

"Norma, inform the board of the team roster," Schneider said, thrusting his fingers into the projection and moving them rapidly to summon information. "We're drawing up an operational plan and will report to them promptly."

"Understood." An elegant female voice came from speakers on all sides.

"The board has replied. The team is to be adjusted: S-rank Lu Mingfei is appointed agent for this mission, with A-rank Chu Zihang assisting him. Chu Zihang is to follow Lu Mingfei's direction." Several minutes later, Norma's voice came again from overhead.

All three duty professors froze. For a long time the control room was silent.

"My God! The board really does recognize Mingfei's talent!" Guderian pressed both hands to his chest in delight.

Manstein and Schneider both raised hands to their foreheads, perhaps checking for fever and wondering whether they were hallucinating. They knew exactly what the college's only S-rank Lu Mingfei was: a "gifted student" struggling on the verge of remedial exams; a loser who would have been demoted without the principal's unconditional protection; an unpredictable wild card who lost his nerve when needed and stunned everyone when he wasn't supposed to appear. Put someone like that in charge? Let him command the elite of the elite, Chu Zihang, president of the Lionheart Society, who had completed twelve missions without a single failure? How was that different from asking Cassell's number-one loser Fingel to solve the Sahara nuclear crisis? Were they trying to destroy the earth?

Morning sunlight poured through the skylight onto the empty basketball court. A ball struck a bright patch with a soothing thump, thump. Chu Zihang was alone, dribbling, crouching, breathing deeply.

An electronic whistle sounded across the court. Chu Zihang moved, driving forward with the ball, leaping like a hurricane, and dunking! His body blurred with speed, and the ball struck the floor so rapidly it sounded like automatic gunfire.

The ball never reached the floor. Chu Zihang landed first and caught it, then immediately turned, drove toward the other basket, and dunked again! The hoop gave a tremendous crack, as though it might break.

He repeated the cycle, the electronic scoreboard rolling upward. It was a basketball game with one player, but both sides' scores rose in turn.

The final whistle sounded, and the scoreboard reached 50–50. His shoes hissed sharply against the floor as he slid into the center circle and slowly straightened. Only then did the ball land with a thump at one side of the court.

Until that moment he had not shed a drop of sweat. A few seconds later it poured out as though a sluice had opened, soaking his jersey.

This was the basketball court in Chu Zihang's home; he was doing his morning exercise. In middle school he had played center on the city's youth team, but after his bloodline awakened, most human competitive sports became dull. Greater muscular strength, superior agility, and bones able to bend beyond ordinary angles meant playing basketball against normal people was now like golf: pure recreation. Few people at Cassell liked basketball. Even the girls could leap and dunk easily, making the game uninteresting. Intellectual contests such as go and sports such as downhill skiing, which tested agility and courage, were popular. No one wanted to play games won simply by brute strength.

So he could only play against himself, turning an enjoyable sport into monotonous morning exercise. Caesar always mocked his taste in sports. Caesar naturally preferred Cassell's classic pastime of sailing: noble and carefree, well-shaped arms drawing substantial ropes, cold water splashing against a bare chest as the boat sped across great lakes and oceans.

Chu Zihang kept playing basketball. He had never been an interesting person anyway.

That man had been the first to teach him basketball. That alone was enough reason to keep playing for life.

Chu Zihang jumped out of his red jersey and went into the shower. Even showering followed a procedure: exactly three minutes, one minute hot, one cold, one warm. The hot water drove out the remaining sweat; the cold tightened muscles and skin; the warm rinsed him clean before he left. While Caesar and the Student Council officers soaked in a petal-strewn whirlpool bath drinking beer, they often joked that if they were living in decadent ancient Rome, Chu Zihang was a medieval ascetic.

Caesar was not quite right. Chu Zihang did not enjoy hardship; he simply wanted to remain as precise as a machine.

Cold water flowed over his raised muscles like streams through mountain rocks. Muscles and tendons overheated by exercise slowly returned to normal. He breathed in and out rhythmically, slowing his heartbeat and blood flow. His physical training specialty was tai chi.

Then his phone, sealed in a waterproof bag, rang. He never let it leave his side, even in the shower.

"I have a mission for you." His adviser Schneider always spoke in commands, blunt as a club descending on one's head.

"I'm listening." Chu Zihang quickly dried himself.

"Urgent mission, SS-rank. Recover important information before seven tonight. Norma has emailed you the detailed instructions." Schneider paused and lowered his voice. "Exercise restraint... Don't make the scene too big. Avoid casualties as far as possible. Don't be like those lunatics in Equipment..." A faint explosion came through the receiver, and Schneider's voice filled with anger. "They're dismantling the campus!"

"SS?" Chu Zihang was uninterested in the Equipment Department's lunatics. It was the mission's classification that surprised him. The highest he had previously taken part in was A-rank.

"You heard correctly. You were originally scheduled to return to campus today, weren't you? Norma has booked you and Lu Mingfei on tonight's UA836 nonstop to Chicago."

"Lu Mingfei?" Chu Zihang was taken aback.

Schneider paused. Even a man as hard and blunt as he found this arrangement difficult to announce and had to choose his words. "The agent in charge is S-rank Lu Mingfei. Your job is to assist him. You are to follow his instructions."

Chu Zihang was confused. What did that mean? An emperor summons his great general and says he wants him to go north against the barbarians with Chief Palace Eunuch Lu. The general naturally knows Eunuch Lu is there as an overseer: the general does the fighting, the eunuch takes the credit, and the general can only thank the emperor and obey. That would be normal. What was abnormal was the emperor saying, I'll give Eunuch Lu armor, a sword, and a fine horse so he can charge in front, while you run logistics behind him... Wasn't that a plan to get Eunuch Lu killed?

"Understood." Chu Zihang's tone remained calm. He was not one to argue.

After hanging up, he opened his wardrobe. A long black tennis bag lay in the corner. He unzipped it to reveal a sword hilt wrapped in black rayskin, pressed against a racket. He took the hilt and drew the blade an inch. Iron-blue light flashed, and a chill ran swiftly up his wrist.

The sacred sword Murasame, the demon blade said to produce spring rain after killing, washing away the blood. Someone had cast this nonexistent sword from regenerated metal and enshrined it for ten years to cultivate its murderous aura.

"Did you get your Birkin? I've been on the waiting list for two years. Do you think they only sell them to VIPs?"

"I did. Last time I went to Europe, I bought tens of thousands of yuan worth of little things at Hermès, and the clerk quietly told me they had one in stock. I grabbed it without thinking. But it's alligator skin, and the pattern isn't very pronounced."

"Show-off! You're lucky to get one. When are you going to lend it to me?"

"Give me a kiss, pretty lady, and I'll reward you."

"Drop dead!" A woman curled up on the sofa kicked at the woman opposite with bare feet, which the other caught.

Four women of auntie age giggled, their hair disheveled, makeup smeared, rolling around on the sofa in silk nightgowns and drinking black tea to recover from their hangovers. Last night's three

bottles of cognac had been powerful enough to knock them all out, and they had slept in this state at Chu Zihang's home until the sun was high.

"It's nearly noon. What are we eating?" Someone suddenly felt hungry.

The door opened silently and a tall, slender boy walked in, glancing at the cans scattered across the floor and the four women who had been famous throughout the city for their beauty when young. He frowned. "What a mess. Couldn't you ask Auntie Tong to help clean up?"

"Oh, Zihang, you're so handsome! Come sit with Auntie a while," Auntie Shanshan said happily.

Chu Zihang wore faded blue jeans and a white T-shirt, simply dressed, with the black tennis bag across his body and the scent of freshly washed sandalwood in his hair.

He was no longer a little boy, but a genuine male. The beautiful aunties had no notion of being modest around him: graceful legs sprawled as before, slim waists twisted as before. They had watched him grow up. His mother had been the first of their circle to have a child, and the aunties adored this toy fallen from heaven. His early memories were traumatic: at two or three, enveloped in perfume and powder, scarlet lips all around, aunties competing to carry him and long elegant hands pinching his little bottom...

"I can't stay. I ordered food for you: two eel rice bowls and two teriyaki beef rice bowls," Chu Zihang said. "They'll be here soon."

"How thoughtful!" The aunties' eyes sparkled. Chu Zihang remembered what each of them liked to eat.

He looked at his mother, curled on the sofa under a thin blanket, and shook his head. "The air conditioning's too high. It's down to twenty degrees in here." He picked up the remote and adjusted it. "Air-conditioned rooms are dry. Drink plenty of water."

He went to the window and drew the curtains. "The public walkway is outside. People can see you dressed like that."

The nightgown sisterhood felt a little embarrassed. They nodded and tugged their gowns down over their thighs to show they accepted the correction.

"Going to play tennis?" his mother asked.

"Yes. I may be back late. I'm meeting some high-school classmates," he said. "I brewed your herbal medicine. It's in the refrigerator. Don't stop taking it once you've started, or the little bumps will come back on your face."

"Yes, yes! I remember, good boy. You're getting more and more naggy." His beautiful thirty-nine-year-old mother bounced up, mussed his hair with both hands, and planted a hard kiss on his cheek.

Naggy? Perhaps that came from the man's genes, Chu Zihang thought.

"As long as you remember." He turned and went out.

Later he understood why the man had always fretted about something as small as drinking milk. Perhaps he knew what had been lost could never be recovered and dared not ask for it, and only wanted to do something to show the past had not been an illusion, that he still had a connection to it.

It was a long thread leading back to the past. So long as it remained unbroken, perhaps there was still no despair, and he need not give up hope.

"I just can't resist a boy like your son, so poised and never smiling! My eyes are blinded by his radiance!" Auntie Shanshan announced.

"I can't help fangirling... He's too adorable! If I were twenty years younger, I'd carry him right out of your house!" Auntie Annie clutched her chest.

"As if you'd get a turn before me! Yingying, let Zihang be my godson!" Auntie EB shrieked.

"Dream on! How could my son be carried off by old women like you?" His mother's smug voice suddenly turned to giggles. "Oh, stop tickling, stop tickling! I was kidding, kidding! Shanshan, you can be my son's second mom from today, all right? Oh, I shouldn't have told you where I'm ticklish..."

Chu Zihang closed the door behind him, shutting out the women's clamor.

In the garage, beside the Mercedes S500, stood a new car, dark blue, long and low like a sleeping leopard: a Porsche Panamera, his "dad's" new toy. Dad had generously said Chu Zihang could use it whenever he liked. For one thing, Chu Zihang was a good driver, unlikely to damage it; for another, Dad was happy for his stepson to show their wealth and taste to classmates in his busy absence.

Chu Zihang sat in the driver's seat, lowered the sun visor, and studied his face in the mirror: clear lines, a broad forehead, straight nose, strong brows, and gentle black eyes, the face of a good student. He had been born looking like this. Even on a wanted poster, people would mistake his picture for an outstanding-student certificate.

He looked down and removed two soft black films from his eyes: Johnson & Johnson daily disposable cosmetic contacts, the popular Butterfly Black loved by fashionable girls. He closed his eyes, concentrated, and slowly opened them. Light flared in them like torches dropped into an ancient well!

He brushed back his hair and slowly, deliberately worked his facial muscles. The mirror now held another person: a face hard as a glacier, a flickering golden gleam deep in the pupils like will-o'-the-wisps. No one would willingly meet his eyes now. A savage, spear-sharp presence spread soundlessly; looking into those eyes was like having a gun with its safety off pressed between your brows.

Sometimes even Chu Zihang could not tell which was his real self.

He put on black sunglasses. "Start!"

The 4.8-liter V8 roared, the gears of the seven-speed PDK dual-clutch transmission meshing smoothly and delivering power evenly to all four wheels. The broad tires gripped the ground like a beast's claws curled before a pounce.

The roller door rose slowly. Sunlight poured over the windshield like a waterfall. Chu Zihang released the brake and floored the accelerator. The engine sang, and the Panamera pierced the brilliant curtain of light like a freshly sharpened sword.

Act Two

None of Our Young Classmates Are Losers

Every Junior Has A Good Time

The secretly circulated History of Shilan: Legends records that Lu Mingfei spent six years at school awkward, timid, and good for nothing. According to his cousin Lu Mingze, the legendary Lu had a pitiful background: his parents had abandoned him, gone abroad, and failed to show their faces for seven or eight years. Fostered at his uncle's house, he ate an enormous amount, a complete glutton... At Shilan High School, where outstanding people gathered, someone like him was a roadside weed, stepped on deliberately or otherwise by everyone.

At Sophie Lad Pizza, Lu Mingfei sat alone in a private room... carrying a toilet seat.

Damn it! Was this how you showed up to a Literature Club lunch? He looked like a foreign monk from the Western Regions arriving to wreck the place with some exotic weapon!

He had originally been in high spirits, but a courteous waiter stopped him at the door and knocked him senseless with one blow: "Out! Our restrooms all have squat toilets. We don't buy your toilet seats."

Lu Mingfei knew it looked bad, but what could he do? His aunt's orders outranked heaven. Even his uncle had to kneel on a keyboard if he disobeyed; who was Lu Mingfei to defy the decree? The building-supply market was some distance from his uncle's house, and after calculating every way, he had realized that buying the seat would leave no time to go home before lunch. He had to come straight here. Even then he had jogged all the way with the seat around his neck, feeling as if he wore the breastplate of a sacred suit of armor... and still he was the only one on time.

"Can't these people be more reliable?" The thought made him increasingly angry.

Apart from that, he was nervous. He hadn't seen a certain person in a long time and didn't know what expression to wear. People young and ignorant about love usually showed two symptoms: picking the least unfortunate-looking girl in class as their dream lover and even contemplating marrying her; and believing they could act convincingly before her, trying to produce a smile that would dazzle her without considering that nature had given them a bitter-melon face poorly suited to smiling.

Fortunately Lu Mingfei did not have a bitter-melon face. If he had to be compared to a vegetable, he was more like celery left too long in the sun...

The door opened, and in came someone short and plump, with a round belly no belt could contain.

"What's with that? Carrying a toilet?" The newcomer was startled by Lu Mingfei's appearance.

"Xu Yanyan?" He recognized him.

He was one of the twins in their class. At the Literature Club farewell, Zhao Menghua had declared his love to Chen Wenwen with an illuminated I love you display. Lu Mingfei had played the lowercase i; the Xu brothers had played the o. After a year apart they looked more like o's than ever.

Xu Yanyan looked him up and down. "Are you... all right?"

"I'm fine." Lu Mingfei was a little wooden, still rehearsing his long-awaited reunion smile in his head.

Nervous, Xu Yanyan perched on the edge of a chair and watched him from the corner of his eye.

Lu Mingfei was a legend at Shilan High.

As the city's foremost elite school, Shilan had no shortage of legends. Grade-ten pianists, grade-eight pipa players, and students who had passed College English Test Band Six were as plentiful as fish crossing a river. Each graduating class sent four or five scholarship students to America or Europe, and the school had supplied athletes to the national swim team and produced nationally ranked martial artists. One such fellow looked like a wandering hero, specialized in twin sabers, cut a dashing figure, and came from a wealthy family that chauffeured him in a Lexus. Whenever people saw him seated bolt upright in the rear of a luxury sedan, legs planted as though in a horse stance, two practice blades on his back and red tassels streaming over his shoulders... it was hard not to become a legend.

But once Lu Mingfei rose at Shilan High, every other legend paled.

The secretly circulated History of Shilan: Legends records that Lu Mingfei spent six years at school awkward, timid, and good for nothing. According to his cousin Lu Mingze, the legendary Lu had a pitiful background: his parents had abandoned him, gone abroad, and failed to show their faces for seven or eight years. Fostered at his uncle's house, he ate an enormous amount, a complete glutton... Naturally his grades were miserable, and he had a loose tongue; you never knew what nonsense would come out next. In class he either smiled dreamily out the window or sneaked naps in the back row, drooling all over his desk. No one attended parent-teacher meetings for him; presumably even his uncle and aunt couldn't bear the embarrassment.

At Shilan High, where outstanding people gathered, someone like him was a roadside weed, stepped on deliberately or otherwise by everyone.

His only talent was StarCraft. He made it work, mooching countless hours of internet access and drinks at cafés under the pretext of "teaching matches." Anyone wanting a few pointers only had to say, "Lu Mingfei, let's go to the internet café after school. I'll pay for your time and buy you a Nutritional Express drink," and he would sidle right up, shameless and ingratiating, without a shred of a teacher's dignity.

But legends are often made by a sudden, mysterious rise, blazing across the sky like a meteor!

Before his graduation, at the Literature Club farewell, everyone cheered when golden boy Zhao Menghua and beauty-ranked Chen Wenwen finally confessed and joined hands, while laughing at the legendary Lu for having once entertained improper hopes about someone...

An angel descended, bearing a sword!

A breathtaking young woman in the legendary Lu's service pushed open the doors, her beauty outshining the moon, bringing a whole company of pretty girls and an assortment of handsome clothes for him. She was all demure obedience before Lu Mingfei, and finally took his arm and whisked him away in a Ferrari.

Everyone talked about her beauty and presence: alluring and fierce, flowers and swords flying together. Shilan's boys were astonished and jealous; the girls felt that even all of them together could not match the grace of a single glance from her!

After that, Lu Mingfei shed his loser destiny and his life changed utterly. Soon news came that he had received the largest scholarship in Shilan's history to attend Cassell College, a private elite American university. Its admissions were so strict that all Shilan's top students had been rejected at interview, yet it seemed to beg Lu Mingfei to enroll. Later its principal sent Shilan's principal an enthusiastic letter thanking him for educating such a fine student. Comparing the letter's lavish praise with Lu Mingfei's transcript, which had crawled and struggled along the passing line, the principal felt his entire life had been an illusion.

Xu Yanyan secretly examined Lu Mingfei. After a year apart the legendary figure dressed just as before: a big white T-shirt, baggy shorts, and a pair of very unconvincing imitation Nikes.

As hopelessly uncool as ever.

Xu Yanyan decided to be cautious. With his stunning girl, Ferrari, and immense scholarship, Lu Mingfei had shattered countless people's confidence and risen to number one on Shilan's "This Villain Must Be Eliminated" list, an enemy every boy was entitled to kill. People could not bear seeing someone once beneath them rise to a height they had to look up at. But Xu Yanyan couldn't read him and dared not leap out and strike at once to rid the boys of this menace...

Xu Yanyan and Lu Mingfei had actually gotten along reasonably well before, but when someone in the group chat said Lu Mingfei was coming today, Xu's heart still skipped. Lu had been someone nobody respected, and Xu Yanyan had treated him coldly a few times. Now Lu Mingfei was a big shot, looking lost in another world and too indifferent to pay him attention. Who knew whether he held a grudge?

Lu Mingfei had not noticed Xu Yanyan watching. He was practicing his smile again, the corners of his mouth twitching stiffly. To Xu Yanyan it was a smile overflowing with indescribable murderous intent.

"Are you... fixing a toilet?" Xu Yanyan asked cautiously.

"No... I brought my own seat. It's more comfortable." Lu Mingfei didn't understand the question, but nonsense came naturally to his lips.

"Good for you." Xu Yanyan felt even less certain. A man with tens of thousands a year in scholarship money, a wealthy young master fixing toilets? Successful yet humble: a formidable rival indeed!

Another person entered, looking as though cast from the same mold as Xu Yanyan. He glanced at Lu Mingfei and also started. "Lu Mingfei? Are you... all right?"

"I'm fine, I'm fine." Lu Mingfei didn't understand why everyone asked.

The private room fell strangely quiet. Brothers Xu Yanyan and Xu Miaomiao spoke in low voices, stealing occasional glances at the legend opposite them. His gaze was vacant, he smiled from time to time, and he held a toilet seat. Though they couldn't read him, his murderous aura was unmistakable.

Fifteen minutes later people arrived in twos and threes. Every time the door opened a familiar face appeared, startled into asking if Lu Mingfei was all right, until he began to feel a little crazy himself and scratched his head with an embarrassed smile. Finally even Liu Miaomiao, the pretty pianist who rarely took part in Literature Club activities, arrived. The gathering had become a small class reunion. The room grew lively as everyone exchanged news, and fewer people paid attention to Lu Mingfei.

"What's on special?" Xu Yanyan studied the menu.

"Who cares? Zhao Menghua said he's paying for everything today. A fully loaded surf-and-turf pizza each and unlimited cola refills!" Xu Miaomiao announced.

"Country bumpkin! If Young Master Zhao's paying, why pizza? I'll have black-truffle meat-sauce pasta with Caspian caviar!" someone said.

"Keep pretending! Caspian caviar? Do you even know where the Caspian is?" Xu Miaomiao jeered. "That stuff won't fill you up. What's the point?"

"I saw it was the most expensive... I'm sharpening my knife to fleece Zhao Menghua. Haven't you heard? His family's company is going public. It'd be a waste not to!"

"Young Master Zhao's more of a class enemy every day! He's about to overtake..." Xu Miaomiao glanced at Lu Mingfei. "...and become number one on the 'This Villain Must Be Eliminated' list!"

"The boss has always been the class enemy among class enemies," one of Zhao Menghua's followers chimed in.

Only Liu Miaomiao was quiet, sitting obediently with her hands on her knees and smiling with pursed lips. She had always been a pretty girl who spoke softly and seemed a little delicate, looking a year or two younger than the others, with long fair hands, grade-ten piano skills, and sweet, well-behaved eyes. The boys in Lu Mingfei's class had split into three camps: one supporting the "Little Celestial Princess" Su Xiaoqiang, another declaring Liu Miaomiao much prettier than Su, and the rest under Chen Wenwen's banner.

Lu Mingfei let his thoughts wander through his school days. Chen Wenwen had still not arrived.

"You're at Fudan?" he tried, making conversation with Liu Miaomiao.

He had once been a stalwart champion in Chen Wenwen's camp, dismissing Liu Miaomiao as a little kid. In truth he admitted to himself that she was pretty, but he couldn't stand seeing boys flock around her like male attendants to a little goddess. He had even heard two of her admirers confide in each other: "I guess I won't get to marry Liu Miaomiao in this life. I'll let you have her!" The other had thumped his chest and said, "Don't worry. I'll treat her well!"

What kind of brotherly loyalty was that?

But Liu Miaomiao had been nice enough to Lu Mingfei, willing to talk to him. Once, bored, he asked how she practiced piano. She said it was hard work and you had to train finger strength from childhood. Then she played several measures powerfully with one hand against the window, making the glass tremble. Lu Mingfei couldn't produce that effect. He remembered the beautiful patterns of light and shadow her long, slender fingers left on the glass, and never called her a little kid again.

"Mm." Liu Miaomiao nodded.

She wore a Dai-style tube skirt dyed with blue silk-tree blossoms and a white camisole, her hair in a high ponytail. She even had light makeup on. In less than a year the little kid had blossomed; sleazy middle-aged men would probably turn to look if she walked down the street now. A year had passed and everyone seemed to have changed a little. None of their young classmates were losers.

Lu Mingfei glanced at the mirror. The fellow in it looked unlucky, his messy head like a clump of chicken feathers. He wanted to cover his face. Who would have thought Cassell's elite education could produce something like this? He had once read in Zhiyin that whether a person could become an aristocrat depended on their surroundings before age thirteen. Sure enough, a bumpkin was a bumpkin

for life. Even if he drove his Bugatti Veyron here, he wouldn't have Caesar's aura of a crown prince arriving.

Head drooping, he stood to escape the noisy room and wander outside. He pushed the door open. Bang.

Outside was an enormous face with a red mark down the middle, struck by the edge of the glass door.

Zhao Menghua, today's host and benefactor, stared at him as though he'd seen a ghost, unable to understand how Lu Mingfei could remain so calm after hitting him. In the past Zhao had paid for drinks and internet access while Lu flattered him; they had worked together beautifully. Now Lu Mingfei's eyes were vacant, as though he saw no one or his mind was far away.

"I'm fine, I'm fine," Lu Mingfei said hastily, coming to himself. Habit had taken over: those had been his first words to every classmate today.

"I... I'm not!" Zhao Menghua clutched his head.

In the past Zhao would have exploded, but for the moment he didn't dare. He couldn't read Lu Mingfei.

Zhao Menghua had been the city's top scorer in their year's college entrance exams and entered Peking University's Guanghua School of Management. His family had connections, and a place as a Yale exchange student in his junior or senior year was already arranged. Everything was wonderful; he should have been a legend himself. But their year had produced Lu Mingfei, a dark horse as black as a lump of coal, who stole all his glory. Shilan's old principal had no idea what Cassell College was, but when he calculated Lu Mingfei's scholarship at roughly 300,000 yuan a year, he was astounded. When the entrance-exam results were posted, Lu Mingfei's name appeared above top scorer Zhao Menghua, on a line of its own, truly outshining everyone! Zhao gazed up at the huge red notice while the crowd discussed the legendary Lu Mingfei. Him? That lowercase i? Zhao was so depressed he nearly spat blood.

Lu Mingfei went out, Zhao Menghua came in, and the door closed between them. Inside, a chorus called, "Boss!"

In the long corridor, fierce sunlight came from the right, erasing darkness layer by layer. Long shadows of windows and a person lay across the floor. The figure's long hair and skirt hem shifted gently in the breeze. Lu Mingfei slowly turned his head right and saw a white cotton dress and a book held in hands folded over it.

The corridor was long, but unfortunately it was empty. Nothing could obstruct their view of each other.

Silence.

"It's not like I'm meeting my first girlfriend. Why am I such a coward?" All the smiles he had prepared came to nothing. Seeing her again, he still didn't know what expression to wear.

"Chen Wenwen: Lu Mingfei's first unrequited crush, three years long, ended without result; she fell to Zhao Menghua."

If Lu Mingfei had a life file and reread it in old age, that would be all it said about Chen Wenwen. They had never held hands, seen a movie, or traveled together; he had never had the slightest chance. An unremarkable unrequited love. In the gradually fading memories, what sometimes flashed past was

the hem of a white dress on a bench on the first day of school and the light and shadow across the girl's face.

"Hi, Lu Mingfei," Chen Wenwen said.

"Oh, I'm going to the restroom," he said.

They passed each other.

Lu Mingfei wandered around the restroom and returned to find the pizza already served, everyone eating with enthusiasm. The splendid toilet seat lay on his chair, with Chen Wenwen seated beside it. He hesitated, but that was the only seat left. He sat down gingerly and forked a piece of pizza onto his plate. Chen Wenwen smiled and nodded; perhaps she hadn't slept well, for her complexion was poor. After two bites he looked up and realized Zhao Menghua sat opposite them.

"What the hell?" he muttered inwardly.

Chen Wenwen was Zhao Menghua's girlfriend. Naturally she should sit with him.

He worried they were playing another trick on him; it wouldn't be the first. Looking around, he suddenly realized they were seated this way because of him. No one had chosen the seat beside Lu Mingfei, and Chen Wenwen had arrived last, leaving her only that place.

"Should I swap seats with someone?" he asked Chen Wenwen awkwardly.

Chen Wenwen shook her head, busy texting. When she finished she placed her phone face down on the table and began drinking cream-of-mushroom soup. The bowl hid her face; Lu Mingfei couldn't even steal a glance.

Across the room Zhao Menghua's phone beeped. He read the new message, sent a brief reply, and also laid his phone face down.

"Boss, you've really made it!" A follower reached for Zhao's hand.

"Only just noticed?" Zhao shook it, a little uncomfortable. "Why are you shaking my hand? What's this about?"

"Who wants to hold a man's hand? I wanted to see your watch." The follower seized his wrist, revealing a heavy watch whose face shimmered faintly gold and blue. "Rolex?"

"Wow, a Yacht-Master! Caliber 4016! Boss, you're wearing a gold watch!" Some classmates knew their watches.

Everyone put down their pizza and gathered around Zhao's watch. The other side of the table grew lively; here only Chen Wenwen and Lu Mingfei remained among half-eaten slices.

Lu Mingfei wanted to look too. A good watch was always cool to a boy. Though he knew little about watches, he understood their great significance: like monkeys on South Pacific islands stuffing fruit into their cheeks to create a powerful jawline and attract females. Expensive male adornment. Caesar often wore a Patek Philippe, occasionally switching to a Zenith or Glashütte.

But Lu Mingfei didn't move, because Chen Wenwen hadn't. If he joined the crowd, she would be left alone. She was still texting.

The conversation grew livelier. Several boys wore watches and showed them off, also discussing how so-and-so had bought a Jeep to drive around campus, how another had failed three courses because he took golf lessons, and how another never lived in a dorm but rented a serviced apartment for twelve thousand a month. These subjects were far removed from poor Lu Mingfei. Those people

were distant too. The closest person to him now was Chen Wenwen, right before his eyes and as far away as the horizon.

She did not spare him even a glance, texting on and on.

How awkward. Suddenly he missed Fingel. If his useless senior were here, he clearly wouldn't be embarrassed... He'd seize the opportunity to drag the lobster pizza over to himself! Lu Mingfei felt a sudden delight and quietly pulled the whole freshly served lobster pizza close. Smelling the melted cheese, he felt better and laughed without thinking.

The laugh sounded so lewd and sleazy that everyone turned at once. The room suddenly fell quiet.

Lu Mingfei ducked his head.

Chen Wenwen pressed Send.

Zhao Menghua's phone beeped. "You have a new message."

Lu Mingfei knew whom she was texting. Suddenly it all became clear, a startling discovery: so this was the great advantage of having a girlfriend! Even if you didn't sit together at dinner you could text, talking slowly in a noisy crowd... whether to go out this weekend... whether yesterday's beef-noodle shop was good... a great comic you'd read lately... the flower you'd planted in the botanical garden last year had sprouted... Beep, back and forth.

However noisy the surroundings, the two of you still had a world of your own, quiet enough to hear a flower seed lost in the shade beneath a window last spring begin to sprout.

How literary. Literary enough to make a person sad.

Lu Mingfei's battle-tested eyes were blinded by envy, jealousy, and resentment. Why hadn't he noticed before? Oh, so that was it. He never knew how close other people were in private... He was always an idiot. His thoughts ran wild, and he grinned silently. Sometimes when he didn't know what expression to wear, he smiled like a fool.

Zhao Menghua retrieved his Rolex and put it on. "Eat, everyone, eat."

Liu Miaomiao sat nearby silently looking at her phone. Everyone else returned to their seats, chewing pizza and cursing some professor for being such a maniac.

The atmosphere was strangely stifling.

"I'm going to the restroom." Lu Mingfei stood.

At the waiter's "squat toilet," Lu Mingfei held a wad of paper and assumed the standard squatting position, but he was actually thinking. Suddenly many things tumbled through his mind.

On Nono's birthday, her official boyfriend Caesar had been leading the Student Council's lovely girls in white lace dresses around campus with submachine guns to slay a dragon, while Lu Mingfei and Nono watched the stars by the cold spring on the hill. Nono had placed her phone on a rock, waiting for someone's birthday wishes. He had sat beside her, kicking the icy water, feeling in tune with the red-haired little witch. Later he had given her a sky full of fireworks. His heart had stirred with foolish hopes.

One afternoon he and Chen Wenwen had classroom-cleaning duty. She sat on the teacher's platform with a faint smile, head bowed over her phone. He happily waved his mop and ran around, because in a world the size of the classroom only he and Chen Wenwen existed. He felt incredibly close to her, as if even holding hands wasn't impossible. Foolish hopes stirred.

At the Literature Club graduation gathering, he and Chen Wenwen returned from booking movie tickets and walked beside the river. She texted with her head down, her sleeve brushing his shoulder. A little deer bounded in his heart... No! Hundreds of two-and-a-half-meter stags with huge antlers crashed exuberantly around his chest, making his nose threaten to bleed and his face glow. He felt the moment belonged to him and Chen Wenwen and wished the road could stretch to the edge of the sky... Foolish hopes stirred...

Damn it! Was "foolish hopes stirring" all worth writing in the history of his love life?

Every time his hopes stirred, the other person had been sending or awaiting a text. A young hero and heroine ride one horse across a vast grassland, sky wide, clouds low, a lone goose calling in the west wind; he in white, she in red, and he wishes the moment could last forever. Meanwhile the heroine's lips move as she uses a long-distance voice technique to exchange love songs with her boyfriend far to the south. What kind of crap plot was that? What garbage writer would create such a pathetic male lead?

But if Lu Mingfei lived in a book... the book had been written by a garbage writer... and he was that utterly pathetic male lead.

No, not the lead. Just passerby A, B, C, or D.

Sometimes he thought Nono and Caesar didn't talk much and didn't seem particularly close... and foolish hopes stirred. But they were boyfriend and girlfriend, for heaven's sake. When Nono and Caesar were alone together... did they hold hands? Hug? Kiss? Damn it, Boss Caesar looked every inch a handsome, debauched, sex-starved devil!

The saddest thing in the world was secretly loving a girl while she happily shared her life with someone else. While you walked alone in moonlight, thinking of her in literary sorrow, under that same moon she held someone's hand, leaned into someone's arm, and kissed someone's lips... The air was full of the hormones of mutual desire...

Lu Mingfei picked at a crack in the floor tiles in grief and indignation, convinced no one in the vast world was sadder than he. Then he remembered he was in a restroom, and that crack in the tiles... A wave of nausea abruptly halted the melancholy literary mood in his head.

A text chimed. With the finger that had picked the tile crack held up delicately, Lu Mingfei extracted his phone and opened it.

"Happy birthday, wishing you a happy birthday, happiness every day of your life, never mind how you spend your birthday... I've learned Zheng Zhihua's 'Happy Birthday.' It's the first Chinese song I can sing. The attachment is my recording, your birthday present. As you know, your senior is dirt poor, so let's skip gifts that cost money." Sender: Useless Senior.

That was his roommate Fingel. Lu Mingfei had given him that name in his contacts as revenge: Fingel listed Lu Mingfei as Idiot Junior.

Lu Mingfei was touched. It was rare for anything in his useless senior's shaggy head to remember his birthday. The emotion didn't last long... because he couldn't resist opening the attachment. Fingel sang in German-accented Mandarin, wildly off-key being a perfect description, but he put force into every word and had clearly made an effort. Only... wasn't this "Happy Birthday" that song by the old-school literary singer from the 1980s?

"Your birthday reminds me of a friend from long ago. It was a cold winter, and he wandered the streets. I thought he wanted to beg for something, but he always shook his head..." Fingel sang on with extravagant feeling.

Was a song this miserable really a birthday greeting? It sounded more like something to play at his grave. Lu Mingfei covered his face and sighed deeply.

He closed the attachment, pulled up his baggy shorts, and stood. Looking up, he saw a line of neat writing on the partition: "I'm very boyish... seeking a lesbian... phone 138XXXXXXXX."

"Someone looking for a lesbian in the men's room?" He stared.

Wait!

His head buzzed. Something was wrong! Seeking a lesbian in the men's room plainly defied ordinary logic, but with a different way of thinking... everything made sense!

Damn it! Depressed when he came in, he hadn't checked the sign on the door!

Holding up his shorts, half squatting, legs weak, he couldn't stand up. No way. The wrong room again? Once was an accident, twice was natural absentmindedness, three times... that was a hobby!

He rapidly considered countermeasures. There was no time for hesitation. Only a few meters separated the stall from the door; if no one noticed, he could sprint out in three to five seconds. He tried combing his hair forward to hide his face. The look might barely pass for... a tomboy?

He pricked up his ears. It was quiet outside; apparently still safe. Relieved, he fastened his shorts and loosened his ankles as though preparing for a hundred-meter sprint.

"Did you tell her or not?" A girl's voice came from the corridor outside.

"It has nothing to do with her. Why should I?" a boy answered impatiently.

"If you don't tell her she'll find out sooner or later. Can you avoid seeing each other forever?"

"You know what she's like. She's exhausting, moping all day. What good would telling her do? She'd cling to me as though I owed her something."

"Don't talk about her like that... When you were together, didn't you say she was pretty nice?" The girl's voice grew quieter.

"How was I supposed to know what she was like at first? Oversensitive for no reason, playing gloomy one moment, pitiful the next, then unbearably bossy, as if the world had to revolve around her. Whoever wants to cater to her can do it. I'm done!"

"If we broke up someday... you wouldn't talk about me like that too, would you?"

"Come on, you're different from her. I'd never say that about you. I tell everyone how great you are... Damn, wrong answer. That day will never come. We won't break up! I'd have to hit my head to break up with you." The boy laughed ingratiatingly.

"Stop it! Why are you all over me?"

"Pretty skirt... Did you buy it in Yunnan?"

The jumbled sounds of kissing, fabric rubbing, footsteps, and soft murmurs faded away. Lu Mingfei turned to stone, his head buzzing.

Zhao Menghua and Liu Miaomiao had just passed along the corridor outside.

"Kissing and groping right there. Did they think I didn't exist?" Lu Mingfei muttered.

Of their three class beauties, Chen Wenwen, Liu Miaomiao, and Su Xiaoqiang, Zhao Menghua had hooked two: when the class flowers bloomed, he was the one smiling among them... A real winner in life. Once Lu Mingfei understood, righteous indignation filled him! Not just for himself, but for all the boys in class. There were already more boys than girls, and Zhao was taking more than his share! What was this? A waste of resources!

He was also a little dazed. The world changed so quickly. It was as though you looked up and everyone had gone far ahead, leaving you, a little kid, standing where you were.

He pushed open the stall door and walked out, then abruptly stopped.

In the mirror above the sinks he saw Sadako: white dress, black hair hanging over her face. Both hands were beneath the faucet, but the water wasn't running. She stood frozen in the posture of washing them.

At that moment he would rather it had really been Sadako, slowly crawling out of the mirror. At worst he could have screamed, "A ghost!"

But it was Chen Wenwen.

"I-I... came into the wrong restroom..." he explained. Only after speaking did he realize how irrelevant that was.

As though she hadn't seen him, Chen Wenwen turned on the faucet, wet her hands, and patted water onto her face. Her phone lay on the sink. When she reached for it, she fumbled; it clattered to the floor and slid across the tiles toward Lu Mingfei.

He slowly bent to pick it up, looked at her expression, and carefully offered it back. His curiosity was too strong. His eyes darted to the messages on the screen. Chen Wenwen used an iPhone too; its messaging system displayed all the texts with one person like a chat log, stringing scattered memories together.

"You're not wearing the bracelet I gave you last birthday..."

"Did you get my text just now? The one about the bracelet..."

"Got it. I'm not wearing it today. Too hot."

"Yes, it's too hot. I couldn't sleep last night, kept thinking about the past. I could only sleep an hour or two at a time. Did you sleep well?"

"All right. Drink a glass of milk before bed and you'll sleep."

"Do you still think about me?"

"Don't overthink it. We're still classmates."

"Last night I dreamed I was rowing down a river. I texted to ask where you were, and you said you were waiting on the bridge ahead. I rowed forward, but there was fog everywhere and I rowed a long time without seeing a bridge. I texted again and you said you were still waiting on the bridge. I wondered if it was behind me and rowed hard back, but the current was too fast, so I kept going forward... Then I woke up."

"Don't overthink it. Calm your mind and you won't dream."

"Do you understand what the dream means?"

"Yes, but I don't want to hear it. There's no point. Saying less is better for both of us."

"You don't want to hear me anymore. Do you have a new girlfriend?"

"Stop asking! We're at a gathering today. Let me eat in peace! You keep texting, and Lu Mingfei beside you can see!"

"Don't be angry. If you've found a new girlfriend, I'll wish..."

That final text was unfinished. Now there was no need to send it.

Want to wish them well? Easy: go out at once, buy flowers, rush in, and give them to Liu Miaomiao, saying, Little sister, you're wonderful; I can rest easy knowing Zhao Menghua is with you... But was that really what she wanted to say? Bless them? Bullshit. Even Lu Mingfei, whose romantic experience was a blank canvas fit for the most beautiful picture, wouldn't fall for it!

His face twitched. He didn't know what expression to wear.

Actually he had reason to smile smugly. The girl you once liked gave you a polite rejection and threw herself into the arms of a glamorous young prince, and now he'd dumped her. If the petty heart inside you didn't laugh a little, who would believe it? Karma never failed! Ha ha ha! Shouldn't you kick her while she was down, saying, "You thought I was a loser, but my feelings were sincere and dependable. What did that playboy have apart from money and looks?" Or you could be more gentlemanly and say considerately, "It'll pass. Who hasn't had their heart broken?" while secretly exulting, That's for kicking me aside!

But Lu Mingfei only scratched his head and sighed.

He was too timid, so timid he scarcely had a vengeful thought. In a dream Lu Mingze had asked, "Don't you want revenge on the world?" Lu Mingfei had never really thought about it. Not only that, he constantly handed out sympathy, even to Chen Wenwen, who had given him the polite rejection.

Reading the messages, he felt that Chen Wenwen was exhausted and had used all her strength. Her face was wet and pale, so tired it hurt to see.

"Don't look," she said softly, taking the phone from his hand and switching off the screen. "It's all right."

"Oh, okay." He nodded quickly.

Chen Wenwen lifted her long white skirt to wipe her face, arranged her hair, took a deep breath, and straightened her chest. A resentful woman? Not at all. She looked more like Joan of Arc going into battle.

"Don't say anything. Promise." She looked at Lu Mingfei in the mirror.

She had always spoken to him like that. In the Literature Club, when she assigned him something such as arranging the venue, she would say, "Make sure it's arranged. Promise," as if his promise could really guarantee anything.

"Mm. I promise." As before, he raised his hand.

They returned to the room, where a fresh round of pizza had arrived. Everyone was cheerful. It seemed the party was livelier without the two of them.

Lu Mingfei ate absently, watching the people around him. They all seemed different now. He noticed details: Zhao Menghua took two slices and tore one off for Liu Miaomiao; she absentmindedly drank his cola; the boys who used to praise her beauty no longer stole glances at the slender legs beneath her skirt; Zhao and Liu sat close together and far from the others.

Suddenly he understood. When it came to feelings he was a complete idiot. He had never understood other people's looks. Everything he thought he knew was wrong.

Zhao Menghua glanced at Chen Wenwen opposite him, a strange light flashing in his eyes. He cleared his throat and reached into his pocket like a leader about to make a speech. Liu Miaomiao hurriedly pulled at him under the table, but he shook her off.

Lu Mingfei suddenly felt uneasy. He didn't know what Zhao intended, but instinct told him it would be idiotic, stupid, and had to be stopped, even if that meant pouring a glass of cola over his head.

Damn it, why was his glass always empty at moments like this?

Zhao stood with a blue velvet jewelry box in hand and looked around the table. "Since everyone's here today, I'll announce something..." He glanced down at Liu Miaomiao, who instinctively avoided his eyes, cheeks flushed as though she had drunk a great deal.

He opened the box. Inside was a Tiffany platinum wire ring. "Nobody's allowed to pursue Liu Miaomiao anymore. Anyone who does answers to me... We're getting engaged. This is the engagement ring."

Everyone fell silent. Though they knew about Zhao and Liu, engagement... in freshman year? What grand family still played the engagement game?

"Boss, your family actually lets you get engaged?" a follower asked.

"Hell, my mom kept saying if I thought she was right, I should make it official. Mom bought the ring herself. What? Got a problem? I'm telling you so nobody tries to pursue her without knowing and runs into a wall." Zhao grinned and surveyed the table, his eyes not pausing on Chen Wenwen.

"Of course it's fine! So that's why we're having lunch. If I'd known, I'd have bought a present," the follower said quickly.

"Zhao Menghua, you're ruthless. Engaged as soon as you win her over, leaving us brothers no hope at all," someone congratulated him with a mournful face.

"Then we should order a few beers."

"Bumpkin! For something this big it has to be champagne. You think Zhao Menghua can't afford it? If we don't fleece him now, when will we?"

"Come on, put the ring on her! Pictures! Can we post them in the alumni group?"

"Happy now? I've told everyone." Zhao grinned at Liu Miaomiao. "Now you're tied to me for good... marry a carrying pole and you have to carry it around..."

"Stop it..." She lowered her head and pinched his waist.

"Ow, look, she's hitting me..." Zhao laughed and teased his girlfriend—no, now his fiancée.

While the room buzzed with celebration, outside everyone's gaze, a person silently crumbled, as though consumed by fire until only ashes remained.

"Hey, man, you..." Someone stood, the corner of his eye twitching, and stared at Zhao Menghua. "Have you no decency?"

The room fell dead silent. Everyone looked at Lu Mingfei as though they had seen Godzilla.

Lu Mingfei understood why Zhao had done it. He had to give his current girlfriend an assurance. Anyone who landed Liu Miaomiao would be so happy he'd parade around campus banging a lunch basin and blowing snot bubbles, wishing everyone knew he had claimed that flower. Zhao had been

fairly careful today, holding back because Chen Wenwen didn't know yet. But Liu had a knot in her heart, and Zhao had to make a gesture. By evening news of the engagement would spread across the school; everyone would know what a devoted boyfriend he was, and from then on Zhao and Liu would be bound together openly and properly.

But Lu Mingfei had something to say. He wanted to say... She already knows, she's been struggling to hold herself together and can't much longer, she won't text you anymore or nag you... What are you showing off for with your arm around your new girlfriend? We all know how cool and handsome you are, big brother! Of course you won't lack girlfriends! Your life must be wonderfully happy, with a girlfriend to eat late-night snacks with, unlike a loser like me... Oh, right, nothing to do with me... In short, all those thousands of words came down to one sentence:

"You're already happy... just leave her a way to live!"

Lu Mingfei delivered his bold, powerful speech in his head, but not one word escaped his mouth.

He glanced at Chen Wenwen, who was close to falling apart, and sighed. He knew her personality: if he said those things, she would suffer most.

So he could only puff out his cheeks and glare at Zhao Menghua with eyes that were neither quite timid nor quite arrogant, so much white showing around the irises. In high school his homeroom teacher had once said before the whole class, "Lu Mingfei, are you really that useless? Are you a dead weight? You alone dragged our class average down half a point. You're unbelievable." Lu had answered with the same stare, impossible to tell whether it was stupidity or defiance, and made the teacher's heart race.

Lu Mingfei was confident that stare was still quite lethal... Apart from that he didn't have much killing power.

Actually, playing the brave young defender was not for him; this was the situation he handled worst. He instinctively feared awkward scenes. Watching Tom Hanks in Cast Away, for example, Hanks lived like a savage on an island for years after a plane crash, yearning to return to his wife and child. After endless hardship he finally got home, emotions surging at the door—Hanks didn't yet know his wife had remarried, but Lu Mingfei watching did. So he would urgently change channels to avoid embarrassment that had nothing to do with him. He couldn't bear the door opening and Hanks seeing his wife approach in tears on a strange man's arm. Even a movie scene was unbearable.

But this time his brain had overheated and he had run right into the scene himself, playing a passerby with a sense of justice. Really, what the hell did any of it have to do with him?

Zhao Menghua's face twisted, his brow knotted as though the god Erlang's third eye lay hidden there, ready to open and stare the damned monkey before him to death.

"None of your damn business!" He spat the words like a deadly dart from an outlaw's mouth.

"You're right," Lu Mingfei said.

Zhao froze. He had prepared several more concise and vicious replies for when Lu finished talking tough. But Lu Mingfei had readily admitted it.

Yet Lu didn't move away, still holding that wide-eyed stare.

"What do you want?" Zhao stepped forward.

"Nothing." It was true. Lu hadn't had time to think. Given a minute to consider, he might well have retreated.

Zhao nearly broke down, veins jumping in his neck, but several friends held him back. "We're classmates... Forget it, forget it."

Zhao took a deep breath, glared at Lu, and forced out through his teeth, "Pay the bill! We're leaving! What are we eating for? I've lost my appetite! I'll take you all somewhere else for Italian tonight!"

Lu Mingfei breathed easier. Good. Let it end here, leaving room to retreat. Hybrids were supposed to have exceptional physical abilities; Caesar's beautiful Student Council combat squad could take on 200-pound wrestlers in high heels and evening gowns. But that advantage had never appeared in Lu Mingfei, and he had yet to take a fighting class. If it came to blows, two of him would be no match for Zhao. He glanced at Chen Wenwen. She stared blankly into a corner, as though the scene had nothing to do with her.

"The emperor isn't worried, but the eunuch is..." Lu Mingfei muttered inwardly.

The bill came. Zhao pulled several notes from his wallet and tossed them onto the tray, then thought better of it, took one back, and pointed at Lu. "This one pays for himself! Nothing to do with me!"

"Fine, I'll pay for myself." Lu wasn't afraid of that; instead, his spirits rose.

A Cassell student ID was also an American Express credit card with a hundred-thousand-dollar limit! Though he was penniless, he could borrow from an American bank by swiping it! Without thinking he took out his student card. Nicknamed the black card, it had a matte-black surface stamped in pure silver with the college emblem, the half-rotten World Tree. With the gesture of an emperor handing out a tip, he held it between two fingers and passed it to the server.

"We don't take library cards..." The young waitress spoke timidly.

Dark lines covered Lu Mingfei's face. "Get the card machine... I'll show you..."

Someone drew a sharp breath. The back of the card bore both the Citi Bank and American Express logos. Shilan students considered themselves worldly and knew what an American Express black card meant. The highest black card had no spending limit and was called the Centurion; only a very small number of credit cards were permitted to be pure black.

The waitress quickly brought the terminal. Lu entered his PIN with an air of surveying all beneath him, spinning the pen in his palm as he waited for the slip to sign.

"Fake. Declined," the waitress said in her local accent, the words sounding like "tragedy."

It really was a tragedy. The terminal displayed PAYMENT DECLINED.

Sweating coldly, Lu swiped the black card he carried everywhere, the symbol of his incomparable S-rank status, again and again. It was refused each time, as though the mighty organization in North America had abandoned him.

Someone laughed, and sneers rose around the room.

"Pay cash," someone said mildly.

The door opened and air stirred, like breaking the clay seal on a jar to let in a cool breeze. The young man entering placed several large notes in the black billfold and returned it to the waitress. "Keep the change."

Only a class enemy could utter such punchable words; normally anyone hearing them ought to give him the finger. But this boy spoke with natural detachment, without a trace of showiness. No one

noticed how he had suddenly entered, without a sound. He wore faded jeans and a white T-shirt, enormous sunglasses, and no expression on the half of his face visible.

Such a figure looked ordinary enough to be found on any street, nothing remarkable. But Liu Miaomiao suddenly stood, staring at him, tense.

Lu Mingfei also sprang up, tense. But his tension was different from hers. His instinct was that something had happened; why else would these human-dragon hybrids come looking for him during summer break? And he knew exactly why this fellow carried a tennis bag. Whenever he appeared with any long object, you had to be careful: repeated experience showed he would inevitably draw a blade from it.

"How much longer until lunch ends? The college has something for us to do. I'm here to assist you," the boy told Lu. "Waiting for you to start, boss."

Boss? This fellow called him boss? Lu thought he was hearing things. Don't joke! Since when was he this man's boss? Boss Caesar had wanted to take over the Lionheart Society for years, only to be repelled head-on by this harmless-looking fellow.

Yet it didn't seem to be a joke. This man supposedly had no sense of humor whatsoever.

"Chu Zihang. We're all alumni." The boy briefly removed his sunglasses, then put them back on.

This time everyone turned to stone.

For Shilan students three years above or below him, "Chu Zihang" was a symbol, always far out of reach.

You knew his name and had seen him, but couldn't quite remember his face, because you rarely had a chance to get close.

At graduation he spoke for the student body in a sea-blue uniform, head lowered over his notes and bangs hiding his face. On the basketball court he played center, devastating opponents and leaping to dunk; by the time the ball landed he was already turning back toward midcourt, not even high-fiving teammates. At the Spring Festival show he played a cello solo of the theme from Schindler's List. While the audience remained immersed in the music, thinking his talent belonged on the national gala, Chu Zihang had already packed his cello, bowed, and left the stage, leaving only a slender back.

In Liu Miaomiao's memory, every time she saw Chu Zihang it was raining.

Beyond the eaves rain fell in curtains, mist drifting between the strands. Chu Zihang stood under the roof in a brown denim overshirt, a scarf tied at the collar, hands in his pockets. A bag hung from one shoulder, bulging with what was obviously a basketball. He bent slightly like bamboo in the wind, its joints firm. Faint daylight haloed his dark silhouette.

Liu Miaomiao walked forward surrounded by girls from her class. It felt as though hundreds of little frogs had been stuffed into her heart, jumping furiously. She talked and laughed with the girls as they approached that figure. Each step closer seemed long, so long that time nearly stopped. At last she stood behind him. Chu Zihang politely shifted aside and nodded. She noticed his bangs were wet from the rain, hanging over his eyes.

Time resumed its normal pace. Chu Zihang and Liu Miaomiao passed each other.

After walking a long way, she suddenly turned her head and asked, "Can you see if I have a pimple?" Her classmates leaned close and said no. She said good, it had felt itchy, and quietly withdrew her backward glance.

Through layers of rain Chu Zihang still stood there. Liu Miaomiao had always thought he liked rainy days. Whenever it rained, he seemed so absorbed that she wanted to brush his soaked bangs aside and see his eyes.

Chu Zihang had used his life to define one word: awesome.

So awesome that even a meteoric force like Lu Mingfei could only prostrate himself beneath Brother Chu's slim-fit jeans. The true hidden number one on the "This Villain Must Be Eliminated" list would always be Chu Zihang.

For Liu Miaomiao and many girls at Shilan, Chu Zihang taught them the meaning of an unrequited crush. But he seemed unaware of his mastery in this field, and people misunderstood him. His face was simply expressionless, yet many thought he was pretending to be cool. He didn't like rainy days at all; he stared into space when it rained because he wondered whether that Maybach might come to pick him up again...

Chu Zihang attracted countless admirers but was dense to an extraordinary degree. He was like one of the Easter Island stone statues gazing out to sea; blossoms falling on him were utterly wasted.

Why must he be eliminated? If the many Shilan boys dating girls in their class discovered the same man's shadow had already invaded their girlfriends' hearts, it would be strange if they didn't want to destroy him!

"Thanks, thanks. You're a real friend, senior." Whatever the circumstances, Lu Mingfei was grateful for Chu Zihang's sudden appearance. "I'll pay you back when we get home."

"It's nothing. You're the boss today; you make the calls," Chu Zihang said calmly.

Lu stared. The act was getting more convincing. Who was he to deserve this? It would be an honor to polish the president's shoes, and he dared call himself boss in public? But Chu looked as if to say this was a fact not worth discussing, so he could only keep quiet.

The crowd murmured in amazement. They had known Boss Lu was astonishing, but not that he was so modest, displaying only two parts of his twelve-part greatness. Even Chu Zihang called him boss; surely he had built a vast empire in his year in America. How gracious of him to condescend to eat pizza with his old classmates. That also explained his lack of cash: underlings always paid, so why would the boss settle the bill himself?

"The car's waiting outside." Chu held the door and gestured for him to go first.

Chu's icy expression made Lu uncertain what was happening. The courtesy lay somewhere between a bodyguard addressing his boss and the CIA addressing a terrorist with nowhere left to run. He realized refusal wasn't an option and walked out with his head down.

Chu followed without missing a step, their footsteps echoing down the hall. Lu thought of the people watching him from behind, eyes full of envy and resentment, but he didn't feel honored at all.

Damn, what rotten luck. It wasn't his business, so why had he stepped in? And once he did, even his credit card had proved as useless as he was. The president had rescued him, but what did that amount to? Every scrap of face Lu Mingfei had ever enjoyed had been provided by his seniors. Not once had he stood up and been impressive on his own. He was like a little kid beaten up in a fight, face covered in snot, who went home to fetch his big brother. Others feared you a little, but never respected you, because even with a fierce, stone-faced fighting brother and a gorgeous, long-legged sister, you were still a little kid with snot on your face.

You are incapable. You are useless.

Chu Zihang opened the Panamera's door. Pure white leather racing seats welcomed the honored guest.

Suddenly Lu Mingfei stopped, turned, and ran back!

The people talking at the door to the private room backed away in alarm and made a path. Lu had returned at a hundred-meter sprint, bristling with murderous intent.

He walked up to Chen Wenwen and reached out... seized the toilet seat leaning against his chair... and dashed out of the door.

Chen Wenwen said nothing, gently brushing her long bangs aside.

"Headquarters has assigned a mission. You're the agent and I'm assisting, so you're the boss today. It's not a joke." Chu handed Lu an iPad and skillfully steered one-handed as the Panamera joined the stream of traffic.

Lu Mingfei could hardly believe his ears. A mission with him in charge? What task could he excel at enough to have Chu Zihang assist him? Unless they were going as a team to challenge the Deyun Society at comic dialogue, with Lu as the funny man and Chu as his straight man...

But the iPad ran a Cassell-developed interface directly connected to Norma, and his name was plainly listed under AGENT. After reading the details, Lu Mingfei felt lost in a fog. Was this a criminal investigation? But Field Investigation seemed to be a junior-year elective. He was a complete novice in that area... apart from watching Detective Conan movies.

The air conditioning raised goosebumps on his skin. He glanced timidly at Chu Zihang; the hard profile was expressionless and showed no intention of explaining to the person in charge what to do.

His courage failed. He sank into the seat and stared blankly out the window. He was in a bad mood. When Chen Wenwen had brushed back her hair, he had seen her dreadful face. Ugly—she had never looked so ugly, tears clinging to pale skin, eyes swollen... like a little goldfish. Where was the girl of his dreams? Once she had sat at one end of a bench in a white cotton dress reading Duras's The Lover, her spotless fairy aura seeming to banish sunlight and dust alike. Every fairy, apparently, would one day fall for an idiot and knit him sweaters, loving and resentful, and from then on her life was a downhill road of no return. At such a time a toad like Lu Mingfei, who had never tasted swan flesh, ought to clap in delight, but for some reason his heart clenched and he suddenly grew irritable.

"I listened outside the room for two minutes."

Lu Mingfei nearly jumped out of his skin. Chu had spoken without warning. The flat statement sounded like a threat: I know what you did last summer.

Would the president take an interest in his useless junior's petty gossip and silently listen for two minutes? For a man with Chu Zihang's rigorously organized schedule, what could possibly be important enough to stop him for two minutes?

"You should inform your card issuer of your travel plans. Otherwise, if they see the card used in another place, they'll suspect theft and temporarily freeze the account," Chu said. "I know you liked Chen Wenwen at school."

Lu Mingfei's heart lost its rhythm and his face flushed purple. Even when Fingel exposed his feelings for Nono, he hadn't reacted so strongly.

Nono's beauty was dazzling and sharp, an angel bearing a sword, sometimes madly loyal to her friends. Any man ought to like Nono; Lu suspected Fingel liked her too. He had never imagined Nono dumping Caesar and falling into his arms... All right, given their relative strength, Nono would take him into hers. It was pure admiration: a lovely lady, a worthy gentleman's desire, and a loser's desire too. Nothing to be ashamed of, as long as Boss Caesar didn't know.

But Chen Wenwen was different. Chen Wenwen was a secret. When he had been innocent and still capable of embarrassment, he had thought marrying her would be the happiness of his life. He never tired of sitting beside her on a bench reading all afternoon, running Literature Club errands at her heels like an eager little dog. Back then he had never liked anyone else, wasn't thick-skinned, and had experienced nothing momentous. He was an uncool boy weaving a future with this girl in his heart. If she had nodded, he would have impatiently placed his whole life in her hands for her to command... But she hadn't chosen him.

He always wanted to find a hollow tree and bury that story in it, because it was embarrassing, or... because the feeling of loving someone like that was so tender that if people knew, they might touch it and break it.

"You... you..."

"Probably the whole school knew," Chu added.

"Senior, don't make it sound so scary. The whole school? Our high school banned dating!" Lu felt as if struck by five thunderbolts. "If everyone really knew, wouldn't the dean have dragged me off to confess my wrongdoing?"

"He didn't because he knew you had no chance. He didn't need to concern himself with your fantasies."

"But surely not the whole school?"

"Someone else liked Chen Wenwen and told people you liked her as a joke. So the whole school knew."

Lu stared. "Zhao Menghua?"

Chu did not answer.

Lu sat stunned for a long time, suddenly very tired. Nono had said everyone had played him at the Literature Club farewell. But he hadn't wanted to believe it. He thought he had hidden his feelings well; a few people making fun of him wouldn't matter as long as Chen Wenwen wasn't one of them. He would rather she had never known he liked her and therefore chosen Zhao. But if even Chu Zihang could recount his romantic history in detail...

He was that i, lowercase, a very small "I"... but with no love and no you.

"I don't mind you standing on the seat, but at this speed it's unsafe," Chu said.

Only then did Lu realize he had somehow crouched on the luxurious leather seat, arms around his knees, chin resting on them—a posture somewhere between an elderly northern Shaanxi farmer on a field ridge and a stray dog taking a rest. He hurriedly jumped down, wiped at his shoeprints, and smiled awkwardly.

"It's all right. You weren't saying anything, so I was finding a topic to talk about," Chu said coldly.

Lu was dumbfounded. Huh? What did that mean? Was this merely the president's icebreaker, like the table-tennis diplomacy that opened relations between China and America? He hadn't had time to

wonder why Chu had turned to Chen Wenwen instead of discussing the mission. Was this heart-souring subject merely the stone-faced senior's friendly small talk to break the silence between them? Damn! Table tennis would have been better!

"I'm not Conan..." Lu tried to discuss business.

"Chen Wenwen knew you liked her but pretended she didn't. She wasn't good to you and treated you as a follower. Yet you still stood up for her?" Chu cut off his topic like a blade.

Lu was unaccustomed to such forceful questioning and froze.

"Because she's vulnerable now and you pity her?" Chu shot him a cold glance.

"She was never bad to me. I liked her; that had nothing to do with her." Lu grew anxious.

"Zhao Menghua was unhappy because Chen Wenwen was his girlfriend. She still loves him, and psychologically he still feels possessive toward her. He can discard her, but he doesn't want anyone else standing up for her." Chu raised an eyebrow. "Why did you?"

The cold, pressing tone was like a knife digging into his heart. Lu suddenly grew angry. He didn't want to discuss this, but Chu insisted. What did Chu Zihang want? He was only a senior, only president of the Lionheart Society. Lu Mingfei was an underling of Student Council President Caesar, with no connection to the society. Why must he report his romantic history to its president? They were only doing a mission together; afterward they would go their separate ways! What was Chu trying to ask? Did he only want Lu to admit he was an idiot? That girl had set him up and embarrassed him publicly, yet now he insisted on standing up for her?

"All right, I know what you're going to say. I'm an idiot. I'm useless and still try to play the hero, but I... I can't stand seeing someone treated unfairly." Lu turned hard toward the window, raising his voice. "Anyway, senior, you'd never be treated unfairly! You've been outstanding all your life. You don't understand!"

The Panamera braked suddenly, tires screeching against the road, and stopped dead in the middle of the street.

"Get out," Chu said.

"What?" Lu was bewildered. The sudden stop had almost given him a concussion. What had he said wrong to be thrown out? Could it be... the president had secretly loved Chen Wenwen for years too, and hearing his rival pour out his heart had made him sulk?

"Get out and wait for me. I have something to do. I'll be right back." Chu was expressionless.

Sitting in someone else's luxury sports car, arguing was pointless. Lu obediently got out and stood by the road. Chu shifted into reverse and floored the accelerator. The Panamera accelerated backward into traffic with smoke rising from all four wheels, retracing their route.

Lu stared. He had never seen anyone drive so outrageously. He didn't know this was a driving style inherited in certain families.

Sunlight stung the skin, hot air rising in wisps from the asphalt. Chen Wenwen trailed far behind the group. Through the heat the boy's back ahead of her looked distorted.

Everything was distorted.

"Hey, sister-in-law, do you eat foie gras?" someone called.

"No, it's too salty. I'll have a salad. You eat what you like," Liu Miaomiao answered absently.

"Boss, it's burning up. Why are we wandering outside? Let's get ice cream at Cold Stone," another said.

"Save room for dinner." Zhao Menghua's voice came faintly.

The conversation was distant, yet seemed close to her ear.

Sometimes people couldn't help listening closely to words that pierced the heart. Perhaps their brains had short-circuited...

Chen Wenwen looked down at her white sandals. Again and again, her slender fair feet emerged beneath her skirt as she shuffled forward.

When she was still with Zhao, he had come to school to see her and they had walked under the lights after dinner. She had walked with her head down then too. Students passed on their way back from evening study, and whenever someone called, "Chen Wenwen, is this your boyfriend?" her face burned, as if it were embarrassing, yet she felt so happy. Zhao would throw an arm firmly around her shoulders and grin as he greeted them.

Now she still couldn't lift her head. Not from embarrassment, but because it felt so heavy it might break her neck.

Zhao Menghua was annoyed. Since leaving Sophie Lad Pizza, Chen Wenwen had followed them, inexplicably refusing to leave.

What was the point of clinging now? It was over, and she was acting like a resentful wife. Zhao didn't think he had wronged her. It was just a breakup, wasn't it? Before splitting up they had had a terrible fight. Zhao had gritted his teeth and said they should break up, and Chen Wenwen had actually bitten her lip and agreed. Startled, he had said, "If you dare agree, don't regret it!" and stormed out. A few days later he happened to sit beside Liu Miaomiao at a gathering and suddenly felt glad he had broken up. He muted his phone throughout because Chen Wenwen kept texting him, dozens of messages in a day.

He wanted to turn and tell her, Aren't you annoying? I told you not to regret it if you dared agree! Playing the tragic victim afterward is pointless.

But Liu Miaomiao was beside him. Being too harsh to an ex would make his new girlfriend think him ungallant, so Zhao endured it. He liked Liu: she was pretty, agreeable, and from a good family; unlike Chen Wenwen, she didn't argue with him and made him look good before his friends. Conveniently, their fathers were golfing partners. On hearing that her son had a new girlfriend, his mother had clapped delightedly and said, "Good breakup! You and Chen Wenwen weren't suited!"

Zhao agreed. Watching Chen from afar, he had always seen her reading quietly, untouched by dust, eyes lowered, utterly lovely. Only after winning her had he learned the more literary they were, the more annoying, oversensitive about everything.

Chen Wenwen also thought she and Zhao Menghua weren't suited.

They had not seen each other for nearly two months. He didn't answer her calls, and emails sank without a trace. Late at night she stared at his QQ status. One weekend he'd gone rafting, the next to an amusement park, the next hiking on Fragrant Hill... Every weekend he had something to do. With whom? She didn't know.

She sat by the library's floor-to-ceiling window. Outside the light was dim and wind stirred the dense green leaves. She remembered The Lover and Marguerite Duras, imagining the girl on the Mekong River slowly turning gray.

Suddenly she burst into sobs, frightening the elderly librarian so badly his chronic leg pain flared up.

Actually the story of The Lover was nothing like hers.

The only thing they shared was being unsuited. The white girl and wealthy Chinese young master in The Lover had parted forever because they were unsuited too.

She had come today to see Zhao. That hope had overcome her heavy hesitation. She had put on light makeup so she would look healthier and he wouldn't worry. She had invited Lu Mingfei because everyone else at the gathering was one of Zhao's friends, which frightened her a little. She hadn't imagined getting back together with Zhao; she only wanted to see him casually.

Then why had she burst into tears?

Why was she still following them?

She knew doing so wouldn't make Zhao look back. She knew his character better than anyone... But if she left like this, perhaps she would never see him again, and all those memories would be gone. In memory they walked side by side beneath streetlights along the school river road; now the lights had gone out. In memory they got meals together in the cafeteria; now the food had spoiled. In memory she had bought a Hello Kitty charm and insisted on hanging it on Zhao's phone. By now, she thought, it must have been torn off. The little pink furry cat lay in a garbage heap somewhere in the world beneath all kinds of filth, but it couldn't even cry, because it had no mouth...

She regretted it. She should never have bought that Hello Kitty. If she hadn't, the kitten would still be lying obediently in the display case waiting for someone to take it home.

Why make that innocent little cat so miserable because of a relationship that wasn't right?

That poor... little cat...

At last tears spilled from her eyes, falling onto the scorching concrete tiles and rising as a faint wisp of steam.

"Hey! Hey!" Xu Yanyan nudged Zhao in the waist with his elbow. Out of the corner of his eye he had seen Chen Wenwen stop, tears streaming, and felt a little pity.

"Will you stop bothering me?" Zhao forcefully knocked his arm away.

He wished he could strike Chen Wenwen instead. She was too annoying! He couldn't bear it. What did she want? If she hadn't come today and they met alone another time, he would have patted her shoulder and comforted her. But she insisted on coming; if she came, she shouldn't cause trouble, and she'd even brought Lu Mingfei. That boy was really stubbornly devoted to her. Now she had made everyone part on bad terms. What more did she want? His new girlfriend Liu Miaomiao was beside him, and he had to take his friends out for Italian that night to recover his standing. He hadn't invited Chen Wenwen. Who did she think she was, following along?

Suddenly a deep, powerful engine sounded. Before Zhao could look up, hot wind cut past as though it might slice his hair. A dark-blue shape flashed beside him; brakes screamed, and the Panamera stopped sharply beside Chen Wenwen.

The lunatic was driving backward!

The window lowered. Chu Zihang's face, half hidden by dark glasses, was icy enough to play a killer utterly loyal to his boss in any Hong Kong film. He said, "Lu Mingfei says he'd like to take you to dinner tonight."

"Yes, you." He nodded to the bewildered Chen Wenwen. His handsome, thoroughly masculine face seemed to say, It's that simple. I've delivered the boss's message.

His seriousness, commanding presence, coldness, and nosiness combined perfectly. This was probably an invitation no one could refuse. Imagine someone admired you and invited you to an intimate, elegant dinner for two, but delivered the invitation so forcefully that you felt if you said no, the messenger would pull a Desert Eagle from the glove compartment and shoot you between the eyes...

"He reserved a table at Aspasia tonight." Chu drew a business card from the compartment and handed it to Chen. "The address is on here. Seven thirty."

She stared at the black card. Aspasia. She had vaguely heard of this fashionable Italian restaurant, luxurious to an almost unimaginable degree. Could this really be the timid boy's doing? Such unmistakable commanding presence... Boss Lu stood tall and firm!

Nearby the Shilan boys stared, jaws nearly hitting the ground. Given the temperature of the pavement, one might soon smell roasted jaws. Zhao clenched his fists. He had a premonition that an opponent he had never respected was about to crush him again...

"Are you refusing?" Chu frowned.

Could anyone refuse that tone? He was plainly growing impatient. Surely his Desert Eagle was itching to come out of the glove compartment. Even Zhao felt refusing would be courting death.

Chen lowered her head, smoothed the fine hair by her ear, and sniffed. "All right."

The window rose and the Panamera sped away, arriving and departing in a rush. Its four exhaust pipes again left Zhao's ears ringing.

Act Three

Reward

Reward

Cassell College did not belong to ordinary people. Nono had said it was another path through life: take that fork, and the door to your old life closed. You could only go forward... never return to the world of humans.

With a blade already in your hand, prepare to fight.

Have a golden insignia pressed onto your collar, arm yourself with the immense overdraft on a black card, command those imposing men as Commissioner Lu, and ride in this luxurious car to the most expensive dinner with the girl you once secretly loved.

The Panamera turned onto the elevated road. Its two occupants once again had nothing to say.

"You're really good at driving, senior," Lu Mingfei said awkwardly, trying to break the uncomfortable silence.

Five minutes after leaving him by the roadside, Chu Zihang had returned to pick him up. Since then he hadn't mentioned Chen Wenwen, as if that conversation had never happened. Lu Mingfei thought he must have misunderstood him and regretted his earlier impatience. To complete this mission, wouldn't he need the president's help as his "assistant"? If Chu Zihang angrily abandoned him, Commissioner Lu's assignment would be a total disaster.

Chu Zihang hadn't said a word about the mission details, as though he were simply a chauffeur. But he drove well, using manual mode, shifting gears with swift, decisive movements. There was beauty in the way he held everything under control, as if a flock of butterflies might fly from between his fingers.

"My dad taught me." Chu Zihang seemed surprised Lu Mingfei had brought it up. After a pause he added, "Happy birthday."

"Oh, oh." Lu Mingfei hurriedly nodded and bowed. "Your text moved me so much I practically bubbled over."

"You're replacing a toilet seat on your birthday instead of going out to eat?" Chu Zihang glanced at the thing on his lap.

"My aunt didn't give birth to me. It's normal for her not to remember." Lu Mingfei wasn't complaining; he really thought so. He apparently had never celebrated a birthday. You couldn't blame the government for a hard life. Who told him to have unreliable parents?

This topic was a hundred times better than the previous one, and the two seemed to get along a little more easily. "How do you usually celebrate your birthday, senior?" Lu Mingfei asked.

Chu Zihang thought. "House party, cake, presents, a garden party, photos, dinner, travel... About the same every year."

Lu Mingfei stuck out his tongue. What more could you want, brother? Launch a spacecraft to the moon for your birthday and write HAPPY BIRTHDAY, MASTER CHU ZIHANG on its surface?

"Do you like Italian food?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Never tried it." Lu Mingfei shook his head.

"Cheese, pizza, fried chicken, steak, pasta, that sort of thing. Italian food was the predecessor of French cuisine. It emphasizes natural flavors, and uses olive oil, black olives, dried cheese, tomatoes, spices, and Marsala wine for seasoning. Its air-dried meats and sausages are excellent."

Lu Mingfei didn't know what this had to do with anything, so he nodded. "I like meat."

"Mm." Chu Zihang nodded and connected the car's Bluetooth. "Aspasia restaurant? I'd like to reserve a table for two tonight..."

"I'm very sorry, sir. The restaurant has been booked for a private event tonight." The female manager's voice was gentle but firm.

"Fully booked?" Chu Zihang frowned. "Can you add a table?"

"I'm very sorry. The Black Prince Group is holding a wedding banquet tonight for Mr. Chen's son. We can't accommodate individual guests." The manager left no room for negotiation. "I'm terribly sorry. Please try another restaurant."

Chu Zihang held the phone in silence. The Black Prince Group was a major local taxpayer and a government-supported company. Its boss was a prominent figure whose portrait often appeared on the evening paper's front page, someone even the new mayor sought out. Naturally, none of that intimidated someone with Chu Zihang's elite Cassell education, a man whose face radiated authority once he took off his dark glasses. The problem was that Boss Black—as Chu Zihang always called the group's owner for short—was a major client of his father's, and the families visited from time to time. If this got back to his parents... Chu Zihang scratched his eyebrow, a little intimidated. Everyone had a weak point, and he was no exception.

"Senior, why insist on hanging yourself from this one crooked tree?" Lu Mingfei suggested quietly. "Can't we pick another restaurant?"

"I'm booking for a friend. It's already arranged, so it would be awkward to change." Chu Zihang thought for a while.

A figure sprang to mind. He wasn't the only person at Cassell who radiated authority, nor the most lawless. To suppress a local strongman, you needed an unreasonable dragon from out of town!

He dialed another number. "Fingel, are you at your computer? Post a reward on the Night Watcher forum for me. Yes, using the ID Murasame. I'll text you the details..."

The Night Watcher forum had originally been Cassell College's internal message board, a place for students to gossip, ask about class schedules, and rate the pretty girls in the current class. Gradually it grew popular, becoming a self-service guide to life at Cassell. Early in the morning a tarot master posted fortunes for the day; in the morning someone asked for lecture notes; at noon someone cursed the cafeteria's increasingly awful pork knuckles; in the afternoon someone who had just woken up organized that night's party; and after dark the anonymous boards filled with proud young men and women pouring out their love stories behind masks. Then the News Department was formally established. Its head, Fingel, was the undisputed king of campus paparazzi, claiming the righteous principles of a journalist: anything reasonable ought to be exposed to sunlight. Thus professors' scandals, unofficial histories of the Dragon Blood Secret Party, even Principal Anjou's large travel-expense bills could all be found there, provided you were willing to dig through the posts.

By then every Cassell graduate kept their old ID and remained a regular. Some had joined archaeological teams digging up dragon ruins in the middle of nowhere, others the Executive Department on secret missions in Europe. But whenever they had a free moment and internet access, they connected to the Night Watcher forum first, to feel the warmth of home and... the spirit of gossip.

It was late at night in America, peak traffic. More than ten thousand people were posting across the boards, white instant messages bouncing up the dark interface one after another.

Suddenly an inconspicuous white message turned red! This was rare: ordinary users couldn't do it; only an administrator working behind the scenes could. Then the red message rose above all the others and was pinned to the top!

A stream of data burst from Norma, the intelligent core at North American headquarters, crossed the undersea cables of the Pacific, and rushed to tens of thousands of clients worldwide. For a moment, people before more than ten thousand screens held their breath. What kind of news warranted this? Previously, only gossip on the level of an actual photograph of the department head's first girlfriend seemed to have received such treatment.

"REWARD: A table for two at Aspasia restaurant tonight at 7:30 p.m. (coordinates: 119.28439° E, 26.08774° N), reservation under Lu Mingfei. The person posting this reward offers one promise in exchange."

The posting ID was Murasame.

That ID appeared on the Night Watcher forum about as often as a South China tiger. But everyone knew whose it was. Chu Zihang, president of the Lionheart Society, was openly posting a reward to the Dragon Blood Secret Party worldwide.

Seven time zones away: Portofino, Italy.

At seven in the morning, sunlight covered the Gulf of Genoa, surrounded by mountains. Seagulls gathered and flew low, waiting for little fish to leap among the waves. On a clear morning, the sea was their abundant table.

Among the gulls was a black-and-white hobby falcon. Unlike them, it had not fixed its sights on little fish; it soared and waited for a cod or eel to surface.

A blurred shadow grew clearer. Something was rising from the seabed, and it was certainly big. The predatory bird's blood heated. It folded its wings, extended its talons, and plunged toward the water like a dive-bomber.

The surface broke. The prey leaped half a meter out of the water and caught the falcon's talons in a tenth of a second. The bird beat its wings in terror, unable to escape. It had judged wrongly: this was neither eel nor cod. It had no business being in the depths of the Gulf of Genoa. How could a human reach the seabed without diving equipment?

"Shh." The young man smiled coldly and laid a finger against his lips. He was actually speaking to the falcon.

A faint gold flashed in his eyes, like reflected sunlight. The falcon stopped struggling and perched quietly on the back of his hand. One instant of eye contact, and it was tamed.

"From now on you're my falcon. I'll call you Antony, after an ancient Roman general. It goes rather well with my name," the young man said. "Oh, I'm Caesar Gattuso."

He waved. Antony obeyed, beating its wings and circling overhead. Caesar swam backstroke toward shore like an arrow cleaving the water. On the empty beach stood a tiny motorcycle, only a little over half a meter tall. Though short, it looked every inch a proud Harley cruiser; the rising tide had covered its wheels. Caesar swung aboard and turned the throttle. It roared cheerfully, kicked up a person-high spray, and charged onto the road. The road climbed around the mountain. Plain houses with pink and yellow walls and deep green woods flashed past. Looking back, he saw yachts gathered in the bay below, white wind pennants streaming from their masts.

Caesar held a white bath towel high overhead. Antony understood at once, descending to follow the motorcycle, wings beating as it soared now above and now below the towel, like a warrior following his master's warhorse.

Caesar put on sunglasses against the increasingly fierce sun, a faint smile on his handsome face.

This was his summer vacation, utterly different from the life of the S-rank loser Lu Mingfei. He spent the hottest weeks in Portofino, in a permanently rented suite at the hilltop Splendid Hotel. The little town attracted wealthy Italians and luxury goods, yet remained simple and natural. It was also a superb diving harbor, with red coral and ancient shipwrecks beneath the water and schools of fish swimming leisurely above them. He knew it as well as his own garden.

The Splendid had once been an old monastery. Its pool and restaurant lay among ancient trees, like a garden suspended in the air when seen from below. Caesar entered the lobby bare-chested, and his secretary handed him a phone.

"Your classmate is calling. He seems to be an officer of the Student Council."

"What is it?" Caesar asked casually, holding the phone between neck and shoulder. During the vacation he had left several capable officers on campus, so any news would reach him promptly. Caesar wasn't used to losing control of a situation.

"Big news! Lu Mingfei is taking someone out for authentic Italian food tonight. He can't get a table and is looking for help."

"Who is this?" Caesar paused. The voice was familiar, but not one of those he'd left behind.

"Your loyal lackey Fingel!" The voice was exceedingly ingratiating.

"What does that have to do with me?" Caesar frowned.

Fingel was indeed in the Student Council, but unless he surfaced on his own, Caesar would never remember he had such a subordinate. The fellow had repeated so many years that his original file couldn't be found, and he hadn't reported for duty once since Caesar took office. He was a thoroughgoing drifter.

"But Chu Zihang posted a reward!"

"Chu Zihang?" Caesar's face grew serious.

"Chu Zihang says whoever helps Lu Mingfei get a table at Aspasia tonight can ask him to do one thing within his ability, as long as it doesn't violate morality. Basically, they get a promise from him and can come to him when they have a problem."

"A considerable reward." Caesar pondered for a moment.

The game of posting "rewards" was common at Cassell: helping one another in an exchange of equal value. Caesar had posted one himself when courting Nono, asking people to send her postcards from their hometowns over vacation. Each said, "My hometown is a beautiful place. I hope one day

you'll visit it with Caesar Gattuso." The postcards piled up on Nono's desk like a little mountain, and Caesar sent each sender a new-model PSP as promised.

Compared with Chu Zihang's present reward, however, a few hundred PSPs were nothing. A promise from the Lionheart Society's president could be worth very little or an outrageous amount. You could ask Chu Zihang to bark like a dog, or to give up the presidency. Caesar believed Chu Zihang kept his word. Only such a man was worthy of being Caesar Gattuso's enemy. He was beginning to find this interesting. Lu Mingfei's reservation had nothing to do with him, but... everything involving Chu Zihang did!

"Trying to win people over on campus?" Caesar raised an eyebrow. "Ridiculous! Lu Mingfei is a Student Council member. He's mine. If he needs anything, he should come to me, and I'll help him!" He smiled coldly, radiating authority. "Tonight I'll have Lu Mingfei dining at the best table in the best Italian restaurant he can reach, served by the finest chef and the finest waiters. Everything must be perfect!"

"Brilliant, boss!" Fingel praised him. "But Chu Zihang named Aspasia, and there aren't any tables left."

"That three-Michelin-star restaurant?" Caesar frowned. "I've eaten at its Rome branch many times and never once had to wait."

"Apparently it's booked out for a wedding banquet."

"It's not as if China has no other good restaurants. They can simply get married somewhere else." To Caesar the matter was simple. It was trivial to him; his precious brainpower needn't be wasted considering the bride and groom.

"It's tricky. The people who booked it have considerable influence."

Caesar frowned. "Considerable influence? Politicians?"

"No, a local listed company. Their son got a girl pregnant..."

Caesar lost interest. "Only a business owner. I understand. Someone will take care of it; they're professionals... You're surprisingly eager to help your roommate. You owe Lu Mingfei a lot of money, don't you?"

Fingel sounded sheepish. "I've eaten a lot of his late-night snacks without paying..."

"Then I'll repay the favor for you." Caesar hung up.

He handed the phone to the butler beside him. "Call the Mint Club for me. Once it's arranged, text my classmate. His name is Lu Mingfei." He thought. "The message is: 'Happy birthday, with best wishes from Caesar Gattuso.'"

"Using Mint? The cost won't be small. Isn't that rather elaborate for a classmate?" the secretary advised tactfully.

"Do you know Zhou Enlai?" Caesar asked.

"Yes. He was a very famous diplomat."

"I just read his biography. Some of it is quite interesting. Chinese people care a great deal about details. Mr. Zhou could clearly remember all sorts of information about someone he'd met once, and greet them the next time, making them feel deeply honored. He even bought a shirt for a cleaner whose clothes his car had dirtied. It's a leader's philosophy: attend to details concerning your subordinates."

Caesar dried his wet blond hair, voice firm. "It strengthens a team's cohesion. That's an important lesson I've learned these past few days."

Had Lu Mingfei been there, he probably would have reminded him that this important lesson came from material fit for a middle-school textbook.

"But... all this seems like a roundabout way to ask for your help." The secretary smiled. "Like a little trick."

Caesar raised an eyebrow, looked at the secretary intently, and smiled too. "Yes, Chu Zihang's little trick. I saw it, but it's one I have to fall for because," he said slowly, "Chu Zihang has put himself on the line. I don't need his promise, but I don't want someone else to get it and make some bizarre demand that turns our competition into a mess."

"I understand. I'll arrange it." The secretary bowed slightly. "Young master, it's almost time. Please get ready. The trustees are on their way."

"The main courses haven't been served yet. Why should a side dish like me hurry? I'd still like another swim."

"In your uncle's eyes, you're the main course at today's meeting."

Caesar turned to the young secretary with a subtle smile. "Parsi, don't say that to me again. First, I'm not a dish for a chef to decide about. Even if I were, neither you nor Uncle should expect to be my cook."

"Sorry, young master. I'll be more careful." The secretary withdrew submissively.

Chu Zihang's and Lu Mingfei's phones rang at the same time. Both had received texts. Chu Zihang glanced at his and silently closed it; Lu Mingfei stared in astonishment.

"Happy birthday, with best wishes from Caesar Gattuso."

The second birthday greeting on his nineteenth birthday came from Caesar Gattuso. Lu Mingfei was dizzy. What had he done to deserve birthday wishes from the presidents of the Lionheart Society and the Student Council? Zhou Yu and Cao Cao had fought each other to the death on the Yangtze, yet both wished the same person a happy birthday. Who could earn such an honor? Probably... Jiang Gan.

The world was strange. Some people saw him as a lump of crap; others saw him as a treasure.

"Where are we going now?" Lu Mingfei leaned back and looked out the window.

"You're in charge of the mission. You decide."

"Senior, don't mess with me, okay? We'll go wherever you say. Once we get there, you do your thing... I'll... help dust your car." Lu Mingfei looked miserable.

"Then the ruins of South Railway Station. We don't know who took the documents, so we'll look at the scene first," Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei looked out. The collapsed, tortoise-shell-shaped aluminum-alloy dome of South Railway Station came into view. This branch of the elevated road led straight there. So from the beginning they hadn't needed him, the nominal person in charge, to do anything at all, right? The car had been heading straight for the station. Thinking that made him feel pretty useless... but since it was true, he didn't mind admitting it. Senior Chu Zihang certainly had his measure.

"How long will it take? I'm afraid I'll get home too late... and the toilet seat won't get installed." Lu Mingfei was worried.

He imagined his aunt rushing home sweaty and hot, making for the bathroom, and finding no toilet seat, so she had to squat on the rim. Her rage would turn into a sonic boom and kill him, wouldn't it?

"I've arranged it. You're the commissioner; just complete the mission. I'm responsible for assisting, and I'll take care of your toilet seat," Chu Zihang said mildly.

"You'll call the maintenance guy who fixes the drains in our building?" Lu Mingfei thought that sounded sensible.

Chu Zihang froze. Evidently it hadn't occurred to him that a call to the building management would fix the toilet. Young Master Chu was hardworking at home too, but he'd never repaired a toilet. His family had plenty of housekeepers and drivers.

"Don't worry. I've arranged for professionals," Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei relaxed. Chu Zihang was clearly an extreme perfectionist. If he said professionals, they had to be professionals, capable of going to heaven or underground, let alone fixing a toilet.

The car stopped five hundred meters from South Railway Station, where yellow tape blocked the way. Under the blazing sun, the once beautiful building looked like a work of postmodern art: only a vast, twisted aluminum-alloy frame remained, desolate in the extreme. Cicadas screamed, and crows perched on the frame croaking hoarsely. The municipal government's press conference explaining the "shoddy construction" was being held that afternoon at the city hall auditorium. Reporters had all rushed there, leaving discarded sheets of notes scattered on the ground. Police and security guards sheltered in the shade, fanning themselves with their caps.

"Whoa... Was the earthquake that strong? I didn't feel a thing!" Lu Mingfei exclaimed. Only standing before the ruins could you truly understand the immense force that had destroyed the building, and in turn feel how small you were.

Like two ants arriving before the shell of a sea turtle that had died thousands of years ago.

"It's hard to imagine. Its mechanical structure was very stable, designed to withstand an earthquake of magnitude eight. The aluminum frame was heat-treated to eliminate internal stresses. This morning's small quake was magnitude three; theoretically, it shouldn't even have been damaged. Yet it collapsed, and not a single pane of glass remained intact." Chu Zihang spoke quietly. "I imagine Raymond felt as if the sky was falling."

"Follow me. Don't say anything careless." He opened the car door.

A security guard was already shouting. "Move the car! Move the car! It's closed ahead!"

"Damn, the sky really did fall." Lu Mingfei sucked in a breath.

Chu Zihang gave the guard two packs of cigarettes and said they were seismology students who wanted photographs for a graduation thesis. The guard let them in. Now Lu Mingfei stood among shattered glass, looking up at the sky. The twisted aluminum beams possessed an extraordinary beauty.

Chu Zihang crouched and gently wobbled the shards embedded in a wooden bench. They had sunk deep; anyone standing in that rain of glass could hardly have met a good end.

"Blood." Chu Zihang pointed to a patch of ground. "Raymond was standing here."

"Senior, what can you possibly see in all this broken glass?" Lu Mingfei followed him like a little attendant.

"You can't see it, and neither can I," Chu Zihang said. "But someone can. It's an ability to reconstruct what happened through observation. You know the person who has it."

He put on a baseball cap with a high-resolution camera fixed to the brim and connected to his phone, then started a 3G video call.

"Nono? I need your help," Chu Zihang said.

"Norma has already assigned the task, so I understand. I need you to walk Raymond's route again. I'll try to reconstruct the scene." Chu Zihang switched on the speaker, and Lu Mingfei heard Nono clearly.

Lu Mingfei was wondering whether to greet the little witch when she said, "Who's on your left?"

He started. He hadn't appeared in front of the camera at all.

"Lu Mingfei. He's the commissioner on this operation; I'm assisting him," Chu Zihang said. "How did you know he was here?"

"I saw his reflection in the broken glass in front of you, though his image was small," Nono said. "Tell him to move farther away. He'll interfere with my judgment standing there."

Lu Mingfei had to retreat to a distant corner. The little witch's ability to catch details while profiling was extraordinary. He'd seen it before and didn't mind, but she hadn't shown the slightest intention of wishing him a happy birthday, treating everything as business. It was a little depressing.

Chu Zihang walked through the enormous space, every detail captured by the camera transmitted to Nono. At this moment he was Raymond, entering South Railway Station before its collapse, carrying important documents, surrounded by danger and unsure where the enemy was hiding.

"Stop. He should have paused here," Nono said. "He'd just entered the station. He wasn't familiar with the new building, so he would have stopped to read the signs."

Chu Zihang turned his head slowly, scanning the entire station.

"Good. Raymond's Yanling wasn't visual, so a sweep would probably take three or four seconds. He was noticed at this point," Nono said confidently.

"Now forward. Stop. Turn your head. Raymond would have looked back here to check his surroundings. It was his habit and also followed the college's reconnaissance procedure."

Chu Zihang turned and looked around as instructed. Watching the little witch and Chu Zihang play this crime-scene game from his corner, Lu Mingfei felt a little envious. Chu Zihang was a great player, expressionless and calm, doing whatever she told him. Somehow that even made him a little cute. In Lu Mingfei's place he'd be pulling complicated faces and saying "Really?" and "No way," which wouldn't look cool at all. But he couldn't imitate Chu Zihang's bearing, so all he could do was envy him.

"Raymond found nothing suspicious at the observation point and continued fifteen meters to the ticket gates. Here he discovered that the station was about to collapse," Nono said.

"Are you sure this is the spot?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Yes. He couldn't have been where he died when he realized it was collapsing. He died close to the benches, and with his training he'd certainly have hidden beneath one, but he didn't. That means he saw the danger where he couldn't take cover, then ran toward the benches, trying to escape it, but was too late. The most reasonable nearby position is where you're standing now," Nono said.

"Good." Chu Zihang nodded.

"The conclusion is clear. No one could have snatched the documents from Raymond in so short a time. They were lost after his death, within the next few minutes."

"Why within a few minutes?"

"Someone stepped in Raymond's blood. Your camera caught the footprint just now. It's blurred, which means it was made when the blood had only just flowed. There are lots of footprints at the scene, but only this one approaches Raymond. He was an experienced commissioner and wouldn't have dropped the documents even while seeking cover. So this person stole them from beside him within minutes of the collapse," Nono said. "And judging from the footprint, this was a human with an unsteady step. A pure human would be nervous in a place like this, so they'd have to flee by the nearest exit. C2, right beside you. We should find more information there."

"Understood."

"Now imitate that person's actions. Run to exit C2, but don't use your top speed; he couldn't run as fast as you," Nono said.

Chu Zihang started running at a moderate speed. Fully immersed in the situation, he naturally glanced left and right as he ran, like a nervous little thief who had stolen something.

Was the college's SS-rank mission really only because a petty thief had stolen the documents?

He stopped abruptly in front of exit C2. Outside was the parking lot, and the camera revealed two deep black tire marks. You could imagine how panicked the driver had been: a tremendously powerful car, its tires softened by heat, and the person who stole the documents pressing hard on the gas in their nervousness. Only that would leave marks like these.

"You boys all know cars, so you don't need me for the rest." Nono giggled through the phone. "You've worked hard, Mr. President. I'm taking your girl into the mountains to play."

Chu Zihang paused and nodded slightly. "Thank you."

"Oh, one more feeling, though it isn't very reliable. Just for reference," Nono said. "There was a third person there, standing right where you are now, without moving. They watched from Raymond's death through the theft, and the little thief evidently saw them too. The thief had blood on his feet, and the trail of footprints bent here, which means he saw something that surprised him. It should have been a person."

"What kind of person?"

"I don't know. They left very few traces, so that's why I say it isn't reliable. Looking at all the images you've sent, I just have a feeling that a blurred shadow was watching it all."

Chu Zihang was silent for a moment. "Understood."

"Let's go." Chu Zihang approached Lu Mingfei. "That's about it. I think we can solve this tonight."

"Good, good!" Lu Mingfei nodded.

"There's still some time. Aren't you meeting your cousin, uncle, and aunt tonight? Go back first. I have something to do, so I won't take you for now."

Lu Mingfei thought there weren't any taxis to be had here, but couldn't very well say it. He just kept nodding. "Then I'll meet up with you tonight."

"Let's meet after the mission. I'll arrange a car to pick you up. We'll work in two different places. I have a little more experience, so may I temporarily handle the operational details for you, Commissioner?"

"Sure, sure! The capable should do more!" Lu Mingfei thumped his chest. "With you handling it, I'm not worried!"

Cassell College headquarters, central control room. It was midnight, the easiest time to get sleepy. Guderian was sprawled on the table, fast asleep. Manstein and Schneider, eyes red, leafed through a thick stack of lists and crossed off names one by one.

Manstein glanced at his sleeping friend, frowned, and rolled up a tissue to put beneath his open mouth so his drool wouldn't wet the lists.

"Found it," Schneider said quietly, pushing the list across the table to Manstein.

"The tire marks Chu Zihang found were made by a large-displacement SUV, twenty-two-inch oversized wheels and 285-millimeter-wide Bridgestone tires," Schneider said. "Only modified Hummers or Escalades use those tires. This is the most suspicious name on the owners' list."

Manstein glanced at it. "I know that name."

The Escalade Schneider had underlined belonged to Millennium Labor Services, registered at Runde Building.

"Right. Those people are hunters," Schneider said. "The group calls itself the Three Young Masters. The leader is Tang Wei."

"Some inexplicable things are getting mixed up in this," Manstein said. "A real nuisance."

At Cassell, carrying a gun into the mountains to shoot pheasants didn't make you a "hunter." The word referred to a particular group: a loose organization hired to solve problems. Its members included desperadoes, artists, avant-garde young creatives, and gangsters, a complicated mixture. Their jobs weren't to rescue an elderly neighbor's kitten from a tree, of course, but work on the border between legal and illegal. Usually they weren't hired to murder or commit arson, but they stole, robbed graves, and looted artifacts. A substantial number of these jobs involved dragons, such as stealing alchemical implements from tombs.

They came from everywhere to enter this dangerous and disreputable line of work for one real reason: the "call of blood." Most had some dragon ancestry.

The college had noticed this hybrid organization twenty years earlier, but had never fully understood it. Nor did it want to recruit the scattered bands, as their bloodlines were usually not very pure. It still kept watch, however. Executive Department members stationed around the world registered every hunter they found, and the files already contained several thousand.

Serious research into the organization had begun only last year. Before awakening as the Dragon King, the elder of the King of Bronze and Fire's brothers had been a hunter operating in New York, essentially a petty hoodlum.

Even so, the college had avoided direct contact with hunters, whose minor activities rarely infringed on its interests.

This time was different. Apparently some ruthless figure had emerged among these half-skilled hybrids of low blood purity, capable of bringing down Executive Department commissioner Raymond and trying to take the documents wanted by the Board of Trustees.

"Only four hours remain until the trustees' deadline," Schneider said. "No time for an indirect approach. Act directly."

"Use force?" Manstein frowned. "China is a country governed by law..."

"Human laws don't fully apply to us, do they?" Schneider said. "Both sides are hybrids. Just warn Chu Zihang not to hurt anyone uninvolved."

"You should know your student isn't a precision sniper rifle, skilled at picking off individual targets. He's practically... a shotgun that fires as soon as it lands! I'll say it again: his mission record is poor. He's already caused the college a lot of trouble." Manstein lowered his voice. "If we hadn't kept a lid on it, the trustees would have heard long ago!"

"What's wrong with it? He has a hundred-percent success rate. His methods are just a little too forceful sometimes."

Manstein sighed. "Listen, Schneider, I know you value Chu Zihang, but don't let personal feelings affect your judgment. What's that saying? Impulse is the devil! Remember the bronze city mission? If we'd known Ye Sheng and Aki were a couple, we wouldn't have put them on the same team. We might have saved at least one."

"Right! Good point! Mingfei and Nono have no feelings for each other, so their mission was a great success!" Guderian woke at precisely the right moment, found an opportunity to boast about his student, and immediately brightened.

"The whole campus knows who Lu Mingfei has a crush on," Schneider said coldly. "Except perhaps Caesar."

"Stop! We don't have time for gossip!" Manstein grew angry. "And don't drag my student into this too!"

"Sorry, I forgot Nono is your student now," Schneider said.

The three stared at one another. The central control room fell deathly quiet except for the ticking of the old wall clock. Time passed, second by second.

After a long hesitation, Manstein handed Schneider a list. "To tell you the truth, I've already contacted the trustees directly. They seem to have begun doubting Chu Zihang's abilities. Besides appointing Lu Mingfei commissioner, they immediately dispatched the people on this list to assist them. They're driving to meet Lu Mingfei and Chu Zihang now. They're elite veterans with many years of experience. The recovery plan must also be approved by the trustees and directed remotely from here."

Schneider scanned the list and started. "Why send these people? They're far too conspicuous!"

"The trustees understand that, so they ordered them to dress in plain clothes and keep a low profile."

Schneider was silent for a long time. He gave a long sigh, rose, and walked toward the door.

"Hey, Schneider, don't be so stubborn." Manstein stood and raised his voice. "Not everything depends on an excellent bloodline, right? Don't assume only your own student is the best."

"Once the trustees have decided, the Executive Department can't overturn it. Do as they say. Those politicians only know how to issue orders; they don't understand operations at all. Those people can't help Chu Zihang." Schneider looked back from the door. "Worse, Chu Zihang can't work with other people at all! Every mission he's undertaken, he's actually completed alone!"

On the twenty-first floor of Runde Building, heavy velvet curtains covered every window, shutting out the light. At the center of an enormous conference table stood a red tea-light holder containing a lavender-scented candle. That little light couldn't illuminate the huge, luxurious conference room or the client opposite. He sat between light and shadow, looking thin, with tousled red hair, a deathly pale face, a red-and-white striped shirt, and a yellow vest.

"Whiskey on the rocks? Camus XO? Or... would you like a Chicken McNuggets meal?" Tang Wei turned a glass of Yamazaki whiskey in his hand, unable to resist a joke.

Because the client opposite was Ronald McDonald.

Tang Wei had faced all kinds of clients: burly men with blue dragons tattooed on their backs and Chairman Mao quotations on both arms; obvious success stories with fat bellies and glamorous women in black stockings and miniskirts on their arms; even someone who came in, poked two holes in the conference table with two fingers, and said, "I've trained in the two-finger technique, brother. I advise you not to pull any tricks!" Tang Wei had thought he'd seen enough not to be shaken by anything, but the sight of Ronald McDonald as a client still filled him with respect.

Tang Wei had grown up poor. As a child he'd stared up at McDonald's big sign, swallowing hard.

"Camus XO, on the rocks," the client said in a deep voice.

Sipping the expensive Camus, the client opened the case he'd brought. Inside were neatly stacked high-denomination U.S. bills. The case held exactly $2.5 million.

"The goods," the client said simply.

Tang Wei lifted the case at his feet onto the table and opened it. Inside was a sealed paper bag, its seal printed with an emblem: a great, half-decayed tree. Tang Wei was about to cut it open with scissors when the client said, "That's enough. Don't."

He pushed the heavy case toward Tang Wei and raised his eyes. The moment Tang Wei met them, he nearly jumped to his feet.

Damn, he doesn't have severe hepatitis, does he? That was the first thought to surge into Tang Wei's mind. Otherwise, why were his eyes so yellow? And shining gold...

In each golden eye seemed to be an unfamiliar symbol, slowly rotating backward. The symbols drew Tang Wei into staring hard, even as he realized he shouldn't. The sight made him dizzy, like looking into a kaleidoscope.

"What the hell!" Tang Wei shouted inwardly. When he recovered from the momentary fright, he was drenched in cold sweat. The client still sat quietly across the table, with his rightful fee in front of him: $2.5 million in cash.

"The Three Young Masters are very efficient. I'm pleased." The client picked up the tea-light holder and blew the candle flame into his glass of Camus. The strong grape brandy began to burn quietly, a dark blue flame floating above the ice-filled liquor. He swirled the glass and swallowed liquor, ice, and flame in one gulp. Nodding with satisfaction, he rose to leave.

"Hey, you forgot the goods!" Tang Wei said.

"A courier will come at seven tonight. FedEx. Just give it to him." The client left without looking back.

Tang Wei drank his whiskey in a daze and failed to notice that the wall clock seemed to have gained a few minutes.

"Boss, got the money?" As soon as the client left, Tang Wei's underling darted in.

Tang Wei patted the case proudly. He'd checked the bills: the full amount, all genuine. He'd never expected to get the money so easily. It was almost too comfortable.

"Wow, now I've seen everything! A job from Ronald McDonald!" The underling was full of curiosity.

"What the hell do you know?" Tang Wei rolled his eyes. "He didn't want to show his face. If he'd come dressed as Zorro, security would have grabbed him on the first floor."

He couldn't help admiring the client's ingenuity. Disguised as Ronald McDonald making a promotional visit, he'd come all the way to the office without anyone suspecting him. One brainless young woman at the company had even followed him, asking whether he'd brought a delivery.

"So we get a bonus this month?" The underling gazed at the case full of dollars, delighted.

"Get lost! Don't be so uncultured. In our line of work, we stay cool!" Tang Wei chased him out. "Have the brothers keep a good watch tonight! Someone's picking up the goods. Put extra men on every floor. We'll enjoy dividing the money once we've handed them over!"

On the surface Tang Wei ran a major labor-placement business and drove an imposing Cadillac Escalade SUV. In fact, he considered himself a blue-collar worker. He was a hunter.

He knew there were many others like him around the world, taking jobs for substantial rewards on a website called the Hunter Market. Clients from all over uploaded assignments and solicited capable hunters. Registered members confident they could do a job could reply through the site's mail system, attaching a résumé. This was called "bidding," and the client chose among the hunters who applied.

Tang Wei knew these jobs usually involved strange and supernatural things; crawling in and out of ancient tombs was routine. But you couldn't make money without hardship. He had a talent for this line of work. His company was a hunters' company, and his men all had skills. For each job, the underlings and the company split the proceeds fifty-fifty.

The work was thrilling, dangerous, and profitable. The only problem was that Tang Wei didn't know whether he belonged to the underworld or the legitimate world, and he had little confidence in the Hunter Market site that had made him rich.

No one could say what the site really was. It didn't even have moderators, only an administrator named Nido who rarely appeared. Break the rules and you'd receive a warning email from him, that was all. Tang Wei's ID was 3rd_young_master: Third Young Master.

The always-dark site was like the ruined tombs they often had to "visit" for jobs, with clients and hunters drifting and trading like midnight ghosts. You didn't know what was hidden deep in a tomb, but wandering those boards you felt that someone in their depths was watching your every move. Each extra word you typed, each extra minute online, let someone—or something—in the depths of the tomb learn a little more about you.

By comparison, a client who came to pay in person dressed as Ronald McDonald was almost amusing.

This job had earned Tang Wei more easily than any he'd ever done. He'd originally planned to send his men to seize the packet by force, but an underling had returned delighted. "We got there just in time for the earthquake! South Railway Station collapsed! The falling glass really sliced that guy up. I

risked my life to grab the case and run... It was dangerous, but all it cost was gas there and back! Boss, you need to give me a bigger bonus this time!"

Such damn good luck, and $2.5 million just like that? It was enough to make him wonder if he was dreaming.

Tang Wei touched the bills, took out his phone, and dialed. "Hey, Dad, it's Tang Wei. Wait for me to come home for dinner tonight... Mm... Did your passport application come through? Damn it, call and hurry them up. The lawyer's waiting to file the immigration papers!"

He was planning to take his father and run. He'd applied for Canadian investor immigration. In a few months he would close the company; this was actually his last job. He intended to settle his father in Canada first, hire a few housekeepers to look after the old man, and then travel the world. First stop: Vietnam. His brothers said years of war had left the sexes out of balance, and beautiful Saigon girls by the handful had trouble finding husbands, all wearing those fitted Vietnamese dresses, áo dài, slit high up the sides. A wonderful country full of beautiful legs. On reflection, though, the Sino-Vietnamese battle of Laoshan had been in 1984. However war-torn and unbalanced the sexes had once been, girls unable to find husbands since 1984 would now be middle-aged women with wrinkles and yellow teeth...

Whether or not that dream country of beautiful legs existed, Tang Wei would close his Hunter Market account and stay away from supernatural affairs from then on.

He glanced at the wall clock. Two and a half hours until seven thirty. Two and a half hours until he washed his hands of the business for good.

Chu Zihang stood below Runde Building in a FedEx uniform. The sun sank gradually westward, stretching his shadow long.

His sunglasses reflected the Escalade parked before the main entrance, with its enormous twenty-two-inch chrome wheels.

A BMW 320, loaded down with shopping, drove through the sunset.

"Mingze, once you're abroad, don't rush to find a girlfriend. Your parents won't be there, so don't spend all your time playing," Aunt lectured Lu Mingze in the back seat.

"I know, I know. Will you stop nagging?" Lu Mingze texted without looking up.

"He's grown up and sensible." Aunt was pleased.

"You believe him? Your son might bring home a foreign girl." Uncle looked forward to his son bringing glory to the nation in romance.

"No foreign woman is coming through our door! All you do is watch Hollywood movies and think American women are pretty. Let me tell you, their skin is rough. Close up it's all pores, and their blond body hair is an inch long..." Aunt spoke as though she'd inspected a foreign girl's thighs with a magnifying glass. "Once Mingze gets his Harvard doctorate, plenty of female classmates will want him. Whatever happens, he'll do better than your brother's boy! Just look at that timid Lu Mingfei. He's got an American scholarship, but he didn't even know to buy me a gift when he came home..."

"Didn't he bring you deep-sea fish oil?" Uncle tried to say a few words for Lu Mingfei. He was one of the Lu family, after all.

"What's that worth?" Aunt snorted. "He gets so much American money every year!"

Aunt had always resented Lu Mingfei's damn good luck. At first she'd hoped he would open a path abroad for Lu Mingze, but after swallowing her pride and calling him several times to "find Mingze some connections and help out," Lu Mingfei had only vaguely agreed, with no good news following. It wasn't that he hadn't tried. Cassell was essentially a research center for abnormal humans, but Lu Mingze was too normal.

Aunt had finally called Professor Guderian herself. He'd told her bluntly there was no chance. "Although your son's grades really are better than Mingfei's, ma'am, you must understand: Mingfei is a genius! Do you know what a genius is? An incomparable, irreplaceable, outstanding individual born among us only by chance and opportunity! Edison said genius is ninety-nine percent perspiration and one percent inspiration..."

Aunt suppressed her anger. "I know you Americans emphasize hard work! Our Mingze works hard. More than ninety-nine percent perspiration: he puts a hundred percent perspiration into studying! Definitely more sweat than Mingfei sheds."

Lu Mingze really did sweat more than Lu Mingfei. Aunt wasn't making that up. Mingfei weighed 130 jin at 178 centimeters, Mingze 160 jin at 160 centimeters. If they slept in the same room and Mingfei sweated more, it could only be a feverish night sweat from physical weakness.

"But Edison hadn't finished. He also said that one percent inspiration is more important than all ninety-nine percent perspiration!" Guderian was animated on the phone. "If Mingze is already a hundred percent perspiration, where is the one percent inspiration supposed to go?"

"So Mingfei has inspiration?" Aunt raged.

"Mingfei is inspiration from head to toe!" Professor Guderian said excitedly. "I'm counting on him to help me become a full professor..."

Aunt slammed down the phone. For several nights she tossed and turned, unable to understand how Lu Mingze, whom she'd borne with immense effort, could be inferior to listless Lu Mingfei. Thinking about it brought tears. She shook Uncle awake and told him how hard life had been since she married into the Lu family. Everyone said Lu Mingfei's mother, Qiao Weini, was learned and well brought up, and that she and her husband got along so well. It was as if Qiao Weini were a swan and Aunt a toad... no, an ugly duckling... In any case, they were bullying her to death!

Resolving to turn her pain into action, Aunt rose early and stayed up late for a year, driving Lu Mingze to study like a donkey. At last the acceptance letter arrived from overseas. Her day to lord it over everyone... no, to hold her head high had come. She immediately picked up the phone to call Lu Mingfei's parents. Only then did she discover they had no telephone number for them. All these years they'd kept in touch only through letters written in fountain pen on white paper, and not one had ever had a return address!

The pain of wanting to show off with no one to see was like eating abalone alone, with no audience!

The family of three squeezed into the elevator with bags and bundles. Aunt had even bought Lu Mingze toilet paper.

"I'm exhausted," Uncle groaned. "What's for dinner?"

"I told Mingfei to slice the radish, steam some sausage, chop scallions, and soak the rice noodles. Doesn't Mingze like crossing-the-bridge rice noodles? Tonight it's pork ribs stewed with radish, rice

noodles in the rib broth, Cantonese sausage, and I bought salmon to slice into sashimi for our son." Aunt stroked her son's round face lovingly.

"Don't always make Mingfei run errands for you. Isn't he going back to school tomorrow? He needs time to pack too," Uncle said.

"So what? Going to college means he can't do a few things for me?" Aunt rolled her eyes. "Never mind all the years I raised him."

The aging elevator creaked up from the underground garage to the first floor and stopped. As the doors opened, a sweat-soaked fellow rushed in and frantically pressed a floor button.

"No manners!" Aunt snorted, looking elsewhere so the fellow could hear her but couldn't accuse her of insulting him.

The fellow snapped to attention.

"Lu Mingfei?" Aunt recognized him and flared up. "Where have you been playing? I told you to steam the sausage and buy and install a toilet seat. Didn't you hear? All you know is play! Just like your parents! Where's the seat? You didn't buy it? You go out and all you do is play with classmates? You're so grown up and still don't appreciate how hard adults work!"

Lu Mingfei immediately wilted. Aunt had guessed correctly. He'd just returned. Chu Zihang had dropped him at an intersection not far from the complex, and he'd run all the way, hoping to get home before his aunt and uncle. He hadn't expected to meet them face-to-face in the elevator.

All his life he'd been afraid of Aunt. He hadn't been that frightened even before Norton. What was a Dragon King compared with her? Even if that Yanling: Torch Dragon went off, at worst he'd be blown to ash holding a nuclear bomb. He wasn't Caesar, with a fortune and a beautiful girlfriend to make him reluctant to leave the world. But Aunt was different: waves of brain-piercing demon sound rose higher and higher, and her middle-aged, plump face wore an expression of pity for his misfortune and anger at his lack of ambition. It made life worse than death.

"Fixed, fixed! The toilet's fixed!" Lu Mingfei remained at attention.

He could only gamble on Chu Zihang. He'd said he'd send professionals to take care of it. The Lionheart Society's leader was no ordinary man, and his word carried weight at the college. A little follower like Lu Mingfei had to trust the bosses' power.

"Then why are you running, like you desperately need to take a dump?" Aunt was still displeased.

"I, I, I..." Lu Mingfei kept sweating.

He didn't really know why he was so timid. Even if Aunt threw him out, it wouldn't be a disaster. At worst he wouldn't come back for summer vacation, and could hang out with Fingel.

Perhaps he was simply used to cowering.

The elevator opened. Lu Mingfei carried the bags and followed Aunt carefully, praying everything would be done as Chu Zihang had said when they opened the door. Today was important: dinner was the "family celebration of Lu Mingze going abroad to study." He'd bought his cousin a gift too, a universal power strip with a transformer. A useful little thing; Aunt probably wouldn't have thought the voltage in America differed from China's. Last year Lu Mingfei had suffered in the waiting hall of Chicago's train station, unable even to charge his MP3 player. With this, Lu Mingze wouldn't have to go through that.

"Did you slice the radish?" Aunt felt for her key.

"S-sliced it." Lu Mingfei stammered. He had told Chu Zihang he still had to slice radish, steam sausage, and chop scallions, but had emphasized the toilet seat. He wasn't sure the young master had paid attention.

The door opened... The house was full of white radish slices, neatly stacked, each one centimeter thick. The knife work was exquisite, like a Japanese chef slicing raw fish, with bright green chopped scallions sprinkled on top. The dining table, coffee table, refrigerator—every flat surface in the living room was covered with radish and scallions. All the lights were on, making the slices shine translucently. Aunt was so careful about the electricity bill that she never allowed two lights on in one room.

The steady, forceful chopping from the kitchen suggested dozens of knives rising and falling together, as though a class of chefs were practicing knife skills inside.

A deafening hammer drill sounded from the bathroom. Tiles broke, cement cracked, and the entire wall shook.

The family was stunned. Lu Mingze had been exchanging affectionate texts with a younger schoolmate; in his distraction he dropped his phone, and the battery flew out.

An imposing figure emerged from the kitchen: 190 centimeters tall, shoulders fifty centimeters wide, more than two hundred pounds, his gaze sharp as lightning behind dark glasses. The burly man surveyed them with authority. His left hand held a bucket full of radish slices; his right carried a U.S. military standard M9 bayonet. The gray titanium blade had blood grooves on both sides, a genuine deadly weapon, now decorated with a few delicate pieces of scallion.

"Robbers!" Facing the thug, Aunt lost her breath and nearly fainted.

"There's money in the desk drawer. Take it yourselves!" Uncle raised both hands.

A second thug appeared in the kitchen doorway, wearing only a tank top that exposed bulging muscles, a black military cap, and holding a U.S. military standard Ontario cavalry saber.

"Commissioner Lu?" The thug removed his cap, revealing a splendid bald head with a terrifying skull tattoo on its scalp.

Lu Mingfei didn't answer. He only wanted to cover his face and say he didn't know the man. But he did... These people had once belonged to the Navy SEALs, throat-cutting thugs, but they were retired now and simply maintenance workers at the college.

Cassell College, Maintenance Department!

A burly man carrying the hammer drill came out of the bathroom, his military boots leaving clear prints on the solid wood floor Aunt had carefully polished. He approached Lu Mingfei, removed a large cigar from the corner of his mouth, and smiled with pure manly pride on a square face like RoboCop's. He extended a hand. "Hello, Commissioner Lu! Following your assistant Chu Zihang's arrangements, we've installed the toilet seat. Please inspect it!" He gestured toward the bathroom. "Quality guaranteed! Repairs are our specialty!"

"'Professionals,' all right..." Lu Mingfei pressed a hand to his forehead.

A club boss really was dependable! He'd sent first-rate people, with PROFESSIONAL written all over their faces! But... what was their profession? Killing? Holding terrorists overhead and snapping them in two? Charging through a hail of bullets with a submachine gun in each hand? This was China. Why had these thuggish maintenance men appeared here?

"We took annual leave over the summer and came to China as tourists. We'd planned to visit Guanyin on Mount Putuo tomorrow, but came immediately when we got the call." The leader seemed to read Lu Mingfei's mind.

"Won't you try sitting on it? We bought a top-quality teak seat." The man was puzzled by the commissioner's complicated expression.

"No need..." Lu Mingfei waved weakly.

"We also steamed the sausage and sliced the radish and scallions," the man added.

"But you didn't have to... slaughter all the radishes, did you? And the scallions... Were you making chili sauce, chopping that many?"

The man looked surprised. "The assignment didn't mention chili sauce. To be honest, cooking isn't among our specialties. This is our first time handling this kind of work, so it's a little unfamiliar. Please point out anything we did badly, Commissioner. During reconnaissance and search... I mean, after entering the apartment we looked around and found big bags of radishes and bundles of scallions on the balcony. We guessed it was time-consuming work requiring several people, so we called in the Maintenance Department. Everything else was fine, but the knives weren't handy. Fortunately we all carried our own." He felt he should mention another achievement. "We also cleared the drain while we were at it."

"Look what you've done, Lu Mingfei! You resent me giving you orders, don't you? Showing off for me, are you? How dare you... how dare you turn my home upside down!" Aunt finally understood. Her shrill demon voice could split clouds and stone.

"I... I didn't mean to..." Lu Mingfei murmured like a mosquito.

Disturbed neighbors poked their heads through the door, trembling as they peeked at the room full of thug-like men. They heard they were "friends" of the child the Lu family had taken in.

The burly man immediately grew alert and raised the hammer drill as though it were a loaded Desert Eagle.

"No, no!" Lu Mingfei hurriedly held them back. Their Chinese wasn't very good, and they couldn't understand the neighbors' chatter. They only felt the situation was out of control. They stood shoulder to shoulder, knives in hand, eyes cold, shielding Lu Mingfei in their midst.

The commissioner was the highest authority on an operation and had to be protected first.

"You look down on Mingze! You can't stand me giving you orders! You're so important now, bringing a whole gang to make trouble. Well done! Your family has walked all over me for a lifetime! Go ahead and bully me! I'm not as well educated and gentle as your mother, and Mingze doesn't have your grand style, your American professor backing him... I... I raised you for nothing!" Aunt no longer cared about losing face before the neighbors. Hair disheveled, she cursed him.

Lu Mingfei lowered his head and looked at the floor, feeling incomprehensible gazes on him from every direction. Though the workers didn't know what they'd done wrong, they roughly understood what he meant. They stood in a row behind him, lowered their heads together, and accepted Aunt's scolding alongside him.

Lu Mingfei felt dazed, yet suddenly things seemed clear. So... he and Aunt had never lived in the same world at all. In the world Aunt imagined, he was ruthless and scheming, looked down on Lu Mingze, had an American professor backing him, and possessed status and influence... Apparently he'd

always stood above her. Perhaps he'd been too timid before and should just have stayed that way, never lifting his head. Only keeping his head down and silently slipping along the wall was the life meant for Lu Mingfei.

He suddenly remembered it was his birthday! For the first time in his life people had texted him happy birthday, and someone wanted to dedicate an ill-timed birthday song to him.

Lu Mingfei suddenly laughed aloud. It was clearly inappropriate, but he couldn't control himself.

Uncle and Aunt looked up at him angrily, took Lu Mingze by the hand, and went into the inner room. The door slammed. Through it Lu Mingfei heard a shout: "Get out!"

Head lowered, Lu Mingfei was silent for a long time. Then he patted the Maintenance Department leader's shoulder. "Wait for me."

He returned to his bedroom and packed. Finally he put the multifunction adapter he'd bought for forty yuan on the old IBM laptop he and Lu Mingze had shared, on which he'd wasted so much time.

Lu Mingfei led the Maintenance Department's large contingent through the living room. On the floor were the groceries Aunt had bought, the bags for Lu Mingze's trip abroad, and a cake. He'd never had a birthday cake of his own. Though he was born in the summer heat, when cake wasn't appetizing, he still wanted a cake with his own name on it, even if only to smash it.

"Commissioner Lu, did we do something wrong?" a maintenance worker asked.

"No," Lu Mingfei said. "I know your toilet-repair skills. First-rate."

There was no right or wrong. Whatever he did, this family would never like him. Like a girl who didn't love you, so whatever you did was wrong.

Without love, everything was wrong.

A top-of-the-line black BMW stood at the entrance to the building. A uniformed driver in white gloves respectfully opened its door for him. "A table for two has been reserved at Aspasia. Dinner for you and Miss Chen Wenwen begins at seven."

Lu Mingfei stared. "Aren't we going on a mission tonight? What dinner? I don't know anything about that."

"According to your assistant Chu Zihang's arrangements, you're responsible for the most important part of the mission tonight: dining with Miss Chen Wenwen at Aspasia," the Maintenance Department leader explained. "He'll lead the support team."

"What support work?"

The leader smiled. "Probably leading a team into Runde Building to recover our lost documents."

"Oh, he thinks I'd be too much of a burden, right?" Lu Mingfei understood.

He looked up at the window that had once been his. A solitary light shone there. He suddenly understood why he cowered before Aunt: that three-bedroom apartment in an ordinary complex was like a home. He was different from the others at Cassell. He didn't want to be lonely; the impressive, sorrowful condition called blood sorrow had nothing to do with him. He wanted a home to return to, like an ordinary person.

But he should have understood long ago. Cassell College did not belong to ordinary people. Nono had said it was another path through life: take that fork, and the door to your old life closed. You could only go forward... never return to the world of humans.

With a blade already in your hand, prepare to fight.

Have a golden insignia pressed onto your collar, arm yourself with the immense overdraft on a black card, command those imposing men as Commissioner Lu, and ride in this luxurious car to the most expensive dinner with the girl you once secretly loved.

What you must pay... is only that little bit of warmth and softness in your heart, hardened into iron from now on.

The black BMW glided silently into the night. Lu Mingfei sat in the back seat, his back perfectly straight.